Close Through a closed door

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/24510532.

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General Audiences

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra)

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Glimmer and Catra still comfort each other through a close door, Fluff, proposal, Kids, Pregnancy, Hurt/Comfort, glitra, platonic glitra, Bow's and Glimmer's babies, Crystal Angella, Arrow Saber, Marazz, Adora's and Catra's baby, catra and glimmer being friends, Future Fic

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Close Through a closed door

by LyrZetara

Summary

"I'm going to sit right here outside the door, okay?" Glimmer said laying her back against the frame and sliding down to the floor.She could hear Catra do the same. Now they were back to back divided by a wall,each on their side, each in solitude, but neither alone.
It had become a comfort for both, now every time they needed each other, they could lay back to back and face their new reality several years after the defeat of the Horde.
Realities such as proposals, having kids and weddings...

Catra and Glimmer being close friends through a closed door.
I don't own the rights of the brand.
Enjoy!

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Chapter 1

Catra shut the door behind her and locked it the moment after. She ran a gloved hand through her long mane up to her ponytail and exhaled unevenly. She hadn't felt this helpless or trapped since she left the Hoard, since the chip had been removed, since she had kissed Adora for the first time. Now she felt like a kid again, running to the shadows to conceal herself in the privacy of her room, at least now she had a room, one she shared with-

A knock cut her short as her ears perked up.

"I'm-I'm going to change, Adora" she called from the other side of the door, but there was no attempt to turn the handle.

"Adora is still at the breakfast table with Bow" replied the Queen's voice.

"Sparkles" Catra huffed, if nothing it was a relieve it was her and not Adora "I'll change and then take a walk through the woods, I'll take Melog, so if you could tell-"

"You have been avoiding Adora" Glimmer interrupted her with a stern voice.

"I have not!" Catra retorted stubbornly.

"Please, not even I could teleport fast enough out of a room to leave as quickly as you do every time you are about to be left alone with her"

"I'm not running from her!"

"Oh really?" Glimmer's tone was certainly unimpressed "Because if I wanted I could puff her inside right now and lock you both in"

"N-no! Please don't" Catra begged placing both hands over the door, the panic in her tone was so evident it made Glimmer's heart ache a bit.

"Catra?"

There was a silence and Glimmer feared the other woman had perhaps jumped through the window and into a tree to make her grand Escape. She was about to teleport inside when she saw Catra's shadow still glued in place.

"I'm going to sit right here outside the door, okay?" Glimmer said laying her back against the frame and sliding down to the floor. She could hear Catra do the same. Now they were back to back divided by a wall, each on their side, each in solitude, but neither alone.

Catra clasped her hands together digging her nails against the soft part of her palms.

"Did…did Adora asked you to come?" Catra ventured to ask, her voice weak and soft.

"No" Glimmer assured "As far as she and Bow know I went to talk to my dad" she let another pause pass them by before breathing in "You have been avoiding her" Glimmer pointed out more calmly than before "Even for someone as dense as Adora she's beginning to notice it too, she just tries to hide away the pain"

Catra hugged her knees to her chest wrapping her tail around her ankles "I don't want to hurt her" Catra answered, her tone honest and vulnerable.

"Then why are you doing this?" Glimmer insisted turning over her shoulder even if she couldn't meet her eyes.

"Because she's about to do something stupid!" Catra threw her hands up.

"What are you talking about?"

Catra pressed the heel of her palm against her mismatched eye trying to stifle a sob "Your-your dad told us about this tradition

you Etherians have, something to bound your life to your partner, to commit, to stay by each other's side forever"

Glimmer's eyes went wide "Marriage?"

"Yeah" Catra chuckled out of breath "I think that's what he called it" Catra sniffled "Ever since that Adora has been looking at me differently, she thinks I don't notice her little research, how she's been asking about the tokens you exchange and such"

"She's trying to propose to you?!" Glimmer exclaimed turning around just to be faced by a door "Catra that's-!" but she didn't finish the sentence because she could feel Catra's guilt, her somber aura "You…you don't want her to?" Glimmer mumbled.

Catra hugged herself even tighter digging her nails on the fresh of her own forearms fighting against the tears.

"I-I don't understand" Glimmer knelt before the wooden door "Don't you love her?"

"Of course I do!" she yelled heartedly, wounded by even hearing that assumption "That's why I don't want her to propose" she confessed "She deserves better than me"

Silence. And there it was, the realization hit Glimmer as winter's cold breeze.

"Catra" she whispered.

"I always thought she would outgrow me, some days I was selfish enough to think she wouldn't but I became to fear she would get stuck at my side" Catra shut her eyes tight "She's…she's more than She-Ra to me, more than the savior or the hero, she's…she's been my life… I learned her name before I even knew what to call the sun, I held her hand before learning how to fight, she's my friend, my love, my…my home" she decided not to fight the tears anymore "And I only could ever hurt her…for so long I thought I could redeem myself, be better of what the Hoard built me to be but…but I am not enough to be the person to stay by Adora's side

forever. I always knew this would come to an end because Adora deserves so much more of what I am, of what I could become, she can't get married to me" she finished "That's why I can't face her right now, because the moment she says something I don't know if I will have the strength to say no" she hung her head in shame.

"Catra…" Glimmer breathed in "you…idiot!" she didn't care anymore, she puffed herself right in front of her and grabbed her shoulders tightly gazing into her heterochromatic eyes "You absolute moron!" Glimmer's eyes were teary "you don't get to decide who Adora wants to propose to! You don't get to look down on yourself like that! You have come such a long way! You saved Etheria too, you saved Adora, you've changed!" she shook her shoulders "You are not an outsider in this palace, you don't get to hide behind a door and lurk in the shadows anymore because you belong in the light too, you are part of Bright Moon, you are not a Hoard soldier plotting the next attack, you are not your past anymore, you've grown" she said heartedly "And so help me if you don't realize this you big dummy, but you are my friend and we have been for so many years now and if you think I only let you live here because of Adora I will let you drop from a cliff and into the ocean because with my ancestors as my witnesses, I trust you. And I know you are perfect for Adora"

Glimmer all but shouted at her face, her rage was mixed with hurt and sadness, all encircling her true feelings; she was hurt that Catra still thought so little about herself. The now Queen was breathing heavily, pressing down Catra's shoulders, pinning her against the door without a chance to escape, but upon seeing her yellow and blue eyes inspect her with such shock and helplessness, she let all her anger go.

"I'm so-"

But Glimmer didn't get to apologize, she really didn't needed to in Catra's eyes, because the brunette had just wrapped her arms around her waist and was hugging her tightly, with all her might.

"Thank you" was the only thing that left her lips as she hid away against her shoulder.

Glimmer slowly let the image sink in as she gently enveloped her arms around.

"You are welcome" Glimmer stroke her back gently "And I mean it, Catra. You are worth it"

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

Yes I am back! Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer puffed out of the hallway as soon as she heard Bow's footsteps getting closer.

"Glimmer please!" he begged but she was already gone. The archer gazed down defeated, even after so many years, he still wore his feeling on his sleeve, that hadn't turned him into a weak man as Catra had expected, but into a an honorable one.

"What's wrong?" Adora asked reaching to touch Bow's shoulder while her other hand still intertwined her fingers into Catra's.

"It's…it's nothing guys" he offered a smile "It's something I said. I think I upset her, it's all"

"Well maybe I can go talk to her" Adora offered.

"I don't even know where she went to, perhaps it's best if we give her some space" he folded his arms looking away.

Catra gazed at the murals around them; they were standing right in front of the last one to ever be added into the mausoleum.

"Let me try" the brunette spoke up letting go of Adora's hand after planting a kiss on her fingers, her lips grazing the golden engagement ring that contrasted with her silver one.

"Are you sure?"

"Yeah, worst case scenario I don't find her, so no harm done in looking" she shrugged her shoulders taking a few steps backwards "I'll see you at dinner"

Adora threw an encouraging smile her way "Okay love"

Catra nodded reassured and turned around.

Truth be told, she didn't need to guess were the Queen would be at, the scent of her perfume, the feeling of her magic tingling in the air and the sound of her sparkles were a clear give away for someone with Catra's abilities, but the former warrior didn't even needed to use those cards, because she knew where she would be at, the place the former Queen used to spend her time at according to the stories she heard. It wasn't surprising that the door was locked once she got there, so she had the courtesy to announce herself.

"The surprising amount of locks in this part of the castle leads me to believe you were a bit or a riot as a kid, Sparkles. Not that I think the doors were ever a huge obstacle for you"

"Catra?" she heard her voice from the other side, part of it sounded surprised, the other perhaps annoyed but it all was dimed down but how drowned and distant it seemed. She had been crying "What are you doing here?"

"Took a walk with Adora, turned right two too many times, found you trail of glitter puffing off…" she mocked before leaning over the door looking at the ground "saw how worried archer man was…"

Glimmer sighed loudly "Honestly it's fine, we didn't even argue"

"Didn't say you did" Catra retorted kicking a non-existent rock "he did mentioned that perhaps it was something that he said" Catra admitted "Did he hit a nerve?" she asked trying to sound carefree when actually she was trying her best to get to talk to her.

Glimmer sighed more frustrated now "Again, it's fine, we will work it together, I just needed some time alone" she emphasized the last word.

Catra wagged her options, this much time later and still heart to heart talks were a bit of a mine field to her, years of repressing feeling as a child would do that to you "Fine" Catra spoke up and paid special attention when she heard movement from the other side cease "If you want to be alone that works for me" she removed the cape she usually stole from Adora and tugged it under her arm "But that doesn't mean you'll be lonely" she sat outside the door getting comfortable, resting her head back and closing her eyes. Even if the now ruler didn't want to talk, it didn't mean Catra couldn't be there for her.

Several seconds went by before Catra heard steps getting closed and the shuffling as Glimmer laid down as well. Not for the last time she sighed, this time slowly, defeated.

"He…he didn't say anything to upset me" Glimmer began and Catra's ear perked up at the sound of her voice. Her blue eye already looking over her shoulder even if all that she could see was a white division.

"He would never do something like that, it isn't in his nature" Glimmer continued.

"True" Catra agreed in a mumble. Then there was a silence and Catra softly cut through it "Then what happened?"

Glimmer shrugged hugging her knees to her chest tightly "He…he wants to have kids" she admitted leaving Catra aback; she couldn't have guessed that would be it.

"Ow" the feline girl said unsure "I…I didn't know you were considering it" she cleared her throat "Do you…not want to?" Catra tried to ask softly.

"I don't know!" Glimmer exclaimed more frustrated by her own indecision than the question itself "But he was so sure, so centered, so decided and…and that scared me because what if I can't be a good parent?" she asked running a hand through her pastel colored hair "And I don't want him to resent me for it, for

not being up to it, for the distance and hurt I'll cause" she sniffed "I always thought that when the time came I would have my mother to guide me through, help me..."

Catra felt her heart being stabbed by the memories of the past. She sucked in a mouthful of air and mustered the courage to ask what had never been resolved "Do you hate me for it?" Catra spitted out "It was my fault, if I hadn't- If I could change it- I-"

"I don't hate you, Catra" Glimmer said evenly, no bite or resentment on her tone "I...I did blamed you at first, it was easier that way, to deal with her absence" she admitted "But at the end my mom took a decision" she slumped her shoulders "And what kind of hypocrite would I be if I still held it against you? I brought the whole Hoard into our dimension, I did just as much if not more damage than you ever could and my friends forgave me... they helped me fix my mistake even when it could have been at a great cost. You helped me fix it. You already righted your wrong, if there was ever a debt you covered it full, believe me" Glimmer exhaled gazing at her own hands "Besides, in a way I didn't lost her, you know? She's still here and everywhere else in the world at once, I'm...I'm never alone and I have my dad...I can say I've grown up having both my parents, just not at the same time" she smiled to herself, even if it was bleak and soft, it was a genuine smile at the reminiscence.

Catra swallowed the knot on her throat, for so long that had been hanging over her head and now the blow was never to come. So she finally breathed in "Then...if your mom is always here... you wouldn't be taking care of your kids alone, would you? You'd have her essence, you'd have Micah and Bow and Adora and...and me" she offered "They'd be your children, no doubt but...but you wouldn't do it on your own" she shrugged "It's less scary to think about it that way, isn't it?" she offered before chuckling "And believe me, I have an award in awful childhoods and even more terrible role models and I can tell you, you would never be a bad mother. You care genuinely about everyone and everything. With such a heart...how could you mess up?" she mumbled before chuckling dryly "Besides, if I survived through Shadow Weaver

and became a descent enough person, there's a high chance your children would turn out fine as well. Just don't let Adora help you change diapers, she thinks her sword can turn into anything useful, but she's just kidding herself" her hearing picked up on the silence and her own laughed died down "Glimmer?"

Then the unmistakable sound of her teleportation hit her senses and soon the bright flash blinded her for an instant before she was enveloped in a tight embrace.

"Glim-mer?" she relaxed upon seeing she wasn't in pain or hurt.

"Thank you, Catra"

The taller woman eased up and patted her puffy hair "You'll do great if you decide to be a mother. If you are not ready, that's just as valid"

She felt Glimmer nod against her red shirt.

"Okay" Catra fully embraced her against her body and allowed her to cuddle there.

For a long while there was nothing else to be said and as nightfall fell upon them, the other members of the Best Friend Squad were still looking for them.

"You think maybe Glimmer took a quick visit to another kingdom?" Adora asked.

"And what about Catra? Did she just ran off to the woods?"

"Well, she tends to do that sometimes, more often than not when we try to settle a date for the wedding" Adora shrugged hugging herself "But usually Melog goes with and they come back by sunset" she mumbled unsure.

"We'll find them" Bow assured as they took a left turn and found their respective lovers, both covered under Adora's cape and

wrapped into each other's arms soundly asleep laying into the door.

"Found them" Bow chuckled lightly as they kneelt.

"Hey, love" Adora shook Catra's shoulder lightly noticing she had been purring softly. It melted Adora away as she leaned in to kiss her. The action on its own could have not only woken up Catra from eternal sleep, but transformed Adora into She-Ra again.

Catra opened her mismatched eyes answering the kiss sweetly, her purring more present "Hey Adora" she greeted a bit breathless and definitely sleepy.

"Come on, let's get you to bed"

Catra then realized she was still holding Glimmer, so she gently allowed Bow to grab her in arms while Adora helped her up capturing her into another kiss.

Bow gently cupped Glimmer's face "Glimmer, hi, let's wake up, shall we?" he pressed a tender kiss, as if with that he could take all the worries and fears away.

As soon as Glimmer could lift her eyelids and focus on Bow, her face lit up.

"Let's go Glimmer, time for bed, okay?" his voice was soft and pleading, he didn't want her to leave his side.

"Yes" Glimmer said with conviction.

"Alright, time to sleep then"

"No, Bow, I mean yes. Yes to have children, to be parents together, to build our own family"

"Yes?" he asked aback, his eyes growing wide

"Yes!" she repeated throwing her arms around his neck kissing him heartedly.

Catra smiled as she leaned into Adora's shoulder, her tail wrapping around her lover's leg. When Adora leaned in to press a kiss to her forehead Catra looked up at her mesmerizing blue eyes "Yes"

"Yes?" Adora asked confused.

"Yes, set a date, whatever date you want. There's no reason to wait any longer" she stated "I'll marry you, I'll stay by your side. Because as long as I have you, I have a home" she tip toed reaching for her lips before tilting her head to the side "and as long as we have those dorks, we have a family as well"

Chapter End Notes

More chapters to come, let's see where this story takes us!

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Glimmer shut the door with might and forgot about the rest as she doubled back and emptied her stomach. She groaned as she tried to ease up the feeling.

She then exhaustedly leaned against the door and groaned yanking a towel to clean her mouth.

Not a minute later she knew she wasn't alone anymore and she didn't even have to guess who it might be. She instead gave a faint knock on the door and another one answered from the other side at the same level, her counterpart was already sited there.

"Hi Catra" Glimmer said breathlessly, tiredly.

"Hey" she corresponded "How are you feeling?"

"Fine it's just something that I ate didn't agree with me"

"I know it was Adora's turn to try and make dinner but even she isn't that bad of a cook" Catra retorted "Besides is about, what? The third time this happens?"

"You noticed?" Glimmer actually sounded impressed.

"Please, you are not that discrete; you literally glow whenever leaving a room" she remarked "Adora is completely naïve but you ought to tell Bow soon"

"I'm not even sure if this is it" Glimmer answered twiddling her thumbs "What if I'm not and I only get his hopes up?"

"What if you are and he isn't here to help you through?" Glimmer heard Catra shuffle on the opposite side and thought that perhaps

she would leave "Wasn't there a vow of in sickness and health or something? I'm trying to memorize my own"

And then the door clicked and Glimmer almost stumbled backwards as it swung open.

"Hey!" Glimmer complained as Catra allowed herself in closing the door the moment after.

"It's only fair, you can materialize inside any room, I can pick a lock"

"Great, now I'll have to add guards to every entrance"

"Please, I can still take them all out with one hand tied behind my back and my shoes on" she reached the sink dampening a cloth. She then proceeded to put it over her forehead. Glimmer would be lying if she said that didn't felt nice, a lot better indeed.

"Admitting you still are a bit of a Hoard Scum? Good to hear"

"Careful, that sort of language will be out of service soon, better get used to the idea" she smiled smugly "Scoot over" she tapped her leg sitting next to her.

Glimmer rolled her eyes pretending to be annoyed, but as soon as the brunette was at her side, she rested her head over her shoulder taking a moment to relax, let all her walls down and allow the possibility to sink in.

"I don't recall my mother telling me stories about morning sickness" Glimmer protested.

"Would you tell your own children about this?"

"No" she answered grumpily "Not unless they asked"

"Well then" Catra shrugged her shoulders pointing at the obvious but Glimmer only groaned readjusting her position "You still have Micah, you can ask him how it was like"

Glimmer breathed in, her eyes still closed "Yeah, I guess you are right, I just…I really don't want to be wrong about this…what if I am not pregnant?"

"Then someone has been poisoning your food all week"

"Catra" she groaned yet again and the feline girl smirked victoriously before turning her features soft.

"Then you keep trying, right?" she asked naturally "If you want this you won't give up after a false alarm" she pointed out "Plus, I can't even picture you giving up on something, you are the most stubborn person I've ever met and believe me that is saying much"

Glimmer chuckled finally looking up at her "Thanks" she sat up reestablishing a bit of distance between the two "It's just…kind of scary, you know? This changes everything. If the universe needs us…well I couldn't leave, I'd stay here because they would need me more, but I have a mission and a duty to restore the magic through the entire universe"

"Your first priority should be yourself, Glimmer" Catra deadpanned "you princesses are so selfless it's a bit selfish at times. You can't risk your health, your life isn't just your own anymore, you have a new loyalty and that is your kid" she pointed at her stomach "And I'm certain Bow will feel the same way, so the two of you can stay put for a bit, protect the front and Adora and I will continue the travels"

"We wouldn't want to leave you to face alone all that"

"Believe me, and I'm sure Adora will tell you the same, but it would mean a lot more to us if you raised your kids together safe and sound, after all, we know what the lack of functional parents can do to you. We rather take our chances against alien threats than even the possibility of you not being there for your kids"

Catra explained, there was something in her eyes, a bit of resentment to the shadows of her past, but Glimmer didn't dwell

long on that before nervously looking around until she decided to reach for Catra's hand and held it on her own "Bow and I have talked and…if something was to happen to us…you and Adora… you would…I mean, if you could, would you look out for them?"

Catra's eyes widened in shock.

"Would you be their guardians if we ever couldn't?"

Catra for the first time in years was rendered speechless "I-I-"

"You don't have to answer anything right now, I'll talk to Adora as well and Bow's dads and my own are of course on the list but they are getting older and more worn out, so we figured the two of you would be the best people to ask this, we want our babies to stay in the family, that's why you guys were the logical choice"

It was until Glimmer's eyes inspected her with worry and surprise that Catra even knew she had been crying. Hot drops of salty tears running freely down her cheeks. She sucked in a breath cleaning herself and looking away embarrassed.

"Catra, I'm sorry, I know this is overwhelming, I didn't mean to drop it on you like that"

"I'd be honored" she said with resolve "I'd be more than willing to step up if you ever couldn't, Glimmer" she said genuinely, heartedly. The other girl had become what Catra understood a sister to be. A kind of friend you could live and share a home with, someone she would risk everything for without feeling a romantic connection. Glimmer was that for Catra and she had comprehended so many years later why Adora had welcomed her so easily into her life back when she had first deserted the Hoard.

Glimmer's eyes matched her teary ones as she smiled moved by her sincerity.

"Thank you" she snuggled back into her shoulder, their hands still intertwined "Thank you so much"

Catra laid her head on top of Glimmer's and smiled "No. Thank you"

Chapter End Notes

Next chapter will revolve around one of Adora's and Catra's fights- See you soon!

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra slammed the door so hard it echoed through the entire hall. Every guard and guest at the castle did their best to mind their own business as if the previous outburst and huge argument between She-Ra and her consort hadn't happened.

"Catra!" Adora yelled from the other side "That was uncalled for! You have to come out! They are important people to the kingdom, to the universe! I need you by my side"

"No, please, go back to that meeting; I'm sure they only need She-Ra!"

"You know I'm dreading every minute of this just as much as you do!"

"Give me a break!" Catra shouted back "When they see you they only see a hero, I'm still the face of what destroyed them and believe, I know that's blood on my hands, but I'm done with them telling us how our own wedding should be like!"

"It's just a formality for She-Ra"

"Well I'm not marring She-Ra! I'm marring Adora! And if she told me to just exchange vows in the back garden I'd do it tonight, because that's who I want to spend my life with, not She-Ra!"

"You know I'm both!" she retorted, her voice at the verge of desperation "It's part of me!"

"But it shouldn't be the best part! You are so much more as just… just you!"

"It's still a responsibility I have to uphold!"

"I thought we were through with you trying to be perfect for everyone else"

"I'm not trying to be perfect for them, Catra!"

"Well, you are definitely not doing this wedding for either of us neither, so…"

Adora flinched walking backwards, that had hit home, square in the heart.

"That's-that's not fair… all I ever wanted is you…"

Glimmer approached Adora tentatively reaching for her shoulder "Hey, don't take it to heart, you both have been really stressed lately" she tried to mediate between them "You two are lashing out, it's best if you cool down"

"I'll go talk to the emissaries" Bow pointed to the end of the hall "maybe we can conclude this later on, we are all a bit worn out"

Adora exhaled "Yeah, thanks" she hugged herself "I'm…I'm going for a walk"

"Okay" both nodded as the blonde made her way out of the castle.

Bow then sighed pinching the bridge of his nose "This has been dragged for far too long" he mumbled.

"I know, love" she turned around tip toeing to kiss him "It's been a stressful couple of months"

"I'm surprised they didn't snap sooner"

"They are right though" Glimmer added under her breath before leaning into his shoulder "Let me talk to Catra. If you can convince my dad to invite all the dignitaries for dinner we can continue the arrangements on the morning"

"I mean, you are the Queen, you can command anything"

"Yeah, that's why he is going to think it was his idea" she mocked kissing him again before flinching for a moment.

"You shouldn't exert yourself" Bow said concerned gazing down at her, placing a hand on top of her growing baby bump.

"I'm okay, just a little kick" she assured "now go" she commanded with her most childish smile.

Once alone in the familiar routine, she dragged herself to the door and laid against it loudly, she was right about done with subtleties.

"Listen, I can't sit down on the floor anymore because how would I ever stand up in a dignified way afterwards? And my legs are killing me, so I wager I have about 15 minutes before I have to look for a chair, so either you open that door and let me in or expect me to teleport there and have nauseas"

"Save it, Glimmer" Catra cut her short, her tone still ringed with hurt and annoyance "Let's skip this whole charade, just go"

Glimmer sighed "I know you are mad-"

"Mad? No, I'm not mad, mad would be easier than this" she shouted "I have been mad in my life, mad about people making decisions for me, mad at Adora's self-righteous acts, mad at having to relive the past, so no, I'm not mad, that I know how to handle"

"Fine" Glimmer said sternly "You are feeling betrayed" she accused and the silence on the other side was a clear give away, she had hit the nail right in the head "That's the word you were looking for?" she ask rhetorically "You feel like she's taking their side, that we all are"

"You don't get to tell me-"

"I'm the Queen, Catra" she cut her short "I do get a saying in all of this too. You think it's fun for me to see my friends fight like that? That I enjoy the fact that I have to entertain this entire ridiculous circus we are doing? Let me tell you, all this 'fancy parties' that you dread so much, all the formalities and parts to play, I have been doing them since I was able to talk. Bow has too and Adora had to grow used to being on display like some trophy for the sake of peace and prosperity. I understand that this is still a foreign terrain for you, but the fact that the rest of us know how to fake a smile and put on a show doesn't mean we are taking their side over yours. We have been trying to spare your feelings, which is way more complicated than I gave Adora credit for"

That sting in ways Catra didn't know possible, she had the resolve to argue back, but bit into her own tongue, because as painful as hearing all that was, it resonated within her. It didn't invalidate her feelings but it helped gain perspective. She might still lash out at times, but she was trying to grow from experience.

"Adora has gone out of her way to avoid casting a shadow over you, so you wouldn't feel like second best. So when she says she dreads every minute of this, she means it. She even asked my dad if there was a way she could resign the title of She-Ra but apparently it can't be done, so we are stuck with this" she folded her arms, a sour frown on her face before she inhaled deeply "That being said, I can't imagine how awful this all must be for you. I'm not aloof at the nasty looks, the unsolicited comments, the subtle jabs they throw your way. If I could I'd teleport them out of the window, but as Queen I am not allowed to do that anymore" she added grumpily under her breath, she definitely would "I know this is meant to be a special day for you and Adora and I'm sorry it has to be such a grand event and I know I have my part in the blame, I have to portray my Kingdom's stability and prosperity and the easiest way to show that is by throwing something this massive" she exhaled "And I know due to all the politics in the in-between we have pushed the date several times, dragging out this stressful situation..." she rubbed at her own stomach comforting herself with the presence of her future child "So, yeah, you get to be mad, to be angry and frustrated, but not

at Adora. She's trying so hard for you and I know it's because of her title that this nonsense of a wedding has to be done, but she didn't ask for any of it either, she just wants to marry you, so she's putting up with everything so she can finally do it. So instead of fighting against each other, you should be a team. That's when you both are stronger" she finished, her ankles were now definitely taking a toll on her "Okay, I'm leav-"

The door cracked open and a chair was pushed outside. Glimmer didn't get to see her, but she knew Catra was on the other side.

"Thanks" she pulled the seat to her end and sat with a loud huff "I'm starting to believe Madame Razz's prediction of having twins"

A small chuckle came from the room, it was nice at least to hear Catra's presence.

"…Are you okay?" Glimmer asked softly "that man had no right to mention the attack on-"

"He wasn't lying" Catra intervened "he spoke the truth, I did lead that attack, I did conquered those lands, I did all those terrible things in the name of the Hoard and for my own personal glory" her ears fell flat against her head "I just…I wish I could scape all of it, my past, I mean" she clarified "because they are right…She-Ra should have someone worth it at her side and whenever people see me they only ever perceive my flaws…and…and they think She-Ra is being played, that Adora is dumb for staying with me and that little voice in my head, it agrees"

"But when have you ever done what you've been told, right?" Glimmer teased lightly before evening her tone "If you still care what others say, you'll be miserable, no matter where you are or what you have done, you need to live for yourself, Catra"

"I know... I only really care what Adora thinks of me" she said with little voice "I am…I am afraid she'll listen to them, that they get some sense into that hard head of hers" she chuckled trying

to joke around the issue, but her own words had sank deep into the wound.

Glimmer then piece together that was the kind of betrayal she feared.

"Come on, Adora has always seen the core of who you are and if even during a war she was willing to fight for you, I think she has more than the resolve needed to stay in a conference room and state that she wants to marry you"

"Then she's really dumb" Catra sniffed with a dry chuckle.

"Yeah, that she is. But she's your dumb fiancée. So…go talk to her?"

"I don't even know how to say…"

"Start with 'sorry I've been such a pain, I was feeling hurt and insecure' and go from there"

Catra chuckled "That's not usually how we go through stuff"

"I know" Glimmer answered, her tone carrying something special in it because she knew Catra only ever really talked like that when it was them, even if there was a wall in-between "She said she was going for a walk, but that doesn't sound like her, that's more of a you thing, so she's probably…" she left the rest unsaid. Catra smirked.

"Alright, alright, I know where to go" she stood up opening the door finding the Queen sat there in the chair, still rubbing a hand to her stomach "Thanks, Sparkles…for…always trying to reach out. It's annoying but…I also really appreciate it"

"Right back at you, Hoard Scum"

"Hey, those are the first words your kids will associate with me, give me a break" she laughed shortly alongside the monarch "I'll… I'll apologize to the dignitaries in the morning"

"Don't worry too much, you have diplomatic immunity in this palace, otherwise I'd thrown you to a cell long ago for pranking me with Adora"

"You walked into that one" she stuck her tongue out. Glimmer smirked standing up with difficulties until Catra lend her a hand.

"Anyways, you'll have to attend breakfast with the emissaries tomorrow, but I bet it won't be as bad if you don't have to face them alone"

" 'Go get Adora', I know, I know, your Majesty" Catra rolled her eyes "Urgh! It's so infuriating when you are right"

"Then you must be furious most of the time, huh?" she raised a brow challenging.

"Don't press your luck, Sparkles" Catra smirked back "Now go lay down, you must be exhausted"

"Yes! I just want cake and a bed" she began to head to her room "See you tomorrow"

"Yeah" Catra smirked until Glimmer disappeared from sight to then turn on her heels and walk down the hall to an abandoned part of the castle, a last minute put-together sparing room. And of course, only one person would be there at that odd hour or any other hour for that matter.

Adora swung the staff with such force and precision it cut through the air with a whooshing sound and broke the wooden board in half.

Catra sighed as she removed the cape out of her shoulders and began to take off the boots. When Adora's eyes finally meet hers, Catra was already reaching for a staff. They exchanged looks as an unspoken conversation took place, an agreement of a sort before taking action. So much time later and the language both seemed to understand and always be on the same page was when fighting. It was almost like a dance, something with rhythm

and cadenza but with a more intimate tint into it, because here they trusted each other with their lives, one missed step could mean fatality and still, they never feared when stepping into the arena.

Adora swung first, a direct blow, a conversation starter 'Why are you being like this?'

And of course, Catra deflected 'It isn't easy', she countered and with not a syllable escaping their mouths other than grunts, gasps and sudden groans of pain, they let it all out until they were both panting on the floor. They had been mindful enough not to leave a scar or mark on each other, having to explain a busted lip or a bloody nose was something they had done in the past with little success. So their improvised waltz ended when Adora pinned her battlefield counterpart to the ground, the staff pressed against the length of her collarbone, aware not to obstruct her breathing. She had her right where she needed her, nothing in the middle, now there was nothing left out of the table.

"I'm doing this for both of us" Adora finally verbalized, the sweat running down her face as her piercing blue eyes searched for heterochromatic ones

"I know" Catra mumbled out of breath "I know you are"

Adora's eyes inspected her with more curiosity and confusion than before, so she finally removed herself, letting Catra sit up as well.

The brunette grunted holding her sore side "I was just…I was afraid they would convince you not to marry me. So many proposals have arrived, so many kingdoms even planets want you as an ally and…it scared me they'd made a valid point by bringing back so many of my past actions…I don't want to lose you Adora…and I know I keep pushing you away every time I feel this way because…it'd be easier if I cut the ties, I couldn't bare it if you left…"

"Again…if I left again" Adora finished sighing loudly, her head hanging. She couldn't believe she hadn't seen that sooner "Catra, that's never going to happen" she assured reaching for her face cupping it with care "I love you and nothing they could possibly say would change my mind because they don't know you, they don't know us. I'm aware of every single thing about your past, I was a Horde soldier too, they just cleaned my slot because of She-Ra, not even because of what I did as Adora" she caressed her bruised cheek with her thumb "I was hoping this wedding would do that for you too, that somehow people would finally let you be. That if my word as Adora wasn't enough to persuade them, that maybe they'd listen to She-Ra. And I wanted the whole universe to listen as I said out loud that I love you, that without you, I wouldn't have been able to save Etheria or defeat the Hoard, that you are my everything Catra" she said earnestly "Why would I want to walk away from you?"

Catra's eyes were overflow by tears that she desperately wanted to hide away, but Adora simply leaned in and captured her lips into her own as is she could kiss away the pain and the hurt.

"You deserve better" Catra whispered through drowned tears, her ears flat against her head, her tail curled into her ankles "better than me"

Adora leaned her forehead against hers, holding her nape, caressing there as she had years before when the chip controlled her "Don't you see? I am better because I have you" Adora reinforced deepening the kiss "I love you, Catra"

Against every fiber of her being telling her to refute and sink deeper into the depressing thought of her past, Catra allowed herself to be cared for, to be worthy of Adora's affections and as she kissed back, her devotion scape her lips as a tender "I love you, Adora"

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for all the support! I'll see you next time! (Wednesday probably!)

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"A year" Glimmer sentenced with little voice.

"A year from now?" Adora asked, her tone even but her eyes saddened.

"Yes, apparently the stars will align in a prosperous way and it was ruled to be the most fitting date" she explained.

"It's okay" Catra tried to keep her face from showing disappointment as Adora reached for her hand under the table to give it a squeeze.

"We are sorry, guys" Bow added softly "we tried to talk them into choosing a full moon night, but it wasn't special enough"

"Not special enough for She-Ra" Adora said bitterly, if it were for her, she would have married Catra the same day she proposed "Is this the final change?"

"Yes, they won't dare move it past that date, nor will they agree to a sooner one" Bow explained.

"Okay, so can we keep our travels now that the date has been moved further or is our presence still demanded here?"

Glimmer guiltily avoided her eyes, that was answer enough.

"So they won't let us get married sooner, nor will they let us move on to do other things" Adora voiced, the frustration growing.

"Maybe we should call it" Catra's voice cut though the room; even if it was a whisper it spoke so many different volumes.

"What?" Adora snapped her head back at her with such an urgency and despair, but upon seeing Catra's eyes she didn't found hurt or anger in them, perhaps only resignation.

"Don't get the wrong idea, I still love you very much, I don't want us to change, but ever since we made the announcement nothing but struggle and politics have come in-between. You can't go two days without meetings with dignitaries or overseeing the progress and it's clearly wearing you down. So maybe if we just call it off we could go back to travel the universe, restore the magic in more planets and then, down the line when we are closer to this special date we can resume the arrangements, or later on if needed"

"It's…a sound plan" Bow mumbled "not ideal but it is a way out"

"Would there be any riots or backlash if we do this?" Catra asked Glimmer, the Queen seemed off by the idea; it took her a moment to wrap her head around the concept.

"Um…no, since you are both in Bright Moon's kingdom your loyalties are the same, so there are no ally agreements broken"

"Will it look bad on your Kingdom's prosperity? Calling off something this important?" Catra added since she knew what Glimmer had told her before.

"Well…it would take a statement from She-Ra herself explaining that the cancellation is due to personal reasons and not anything related to the state of Bright Moon"

"Right" Catra exhaled looking back at Adora who seemed like she just had been slapped and thrown a cold bucket of iced water at "What do you think?"

"I…I don't know" she mumbled holding into her hand harder "Catra, I really want to marry you" she looked into her eyes.

"I know" she mumbled back leaning in, resting her foreheads together "And I really want you to, but I am not going anywhere

and if this is keeping us from helping others, maybe it's not the smartest decision right now"

"You are always such a strategist" Adora chuckled weakly "Okay… so we call it off…" her voice was faint and defeated.

"Yeah…" Catra looked down; even if it was her idea it didn't mean she like it any more than Adora did "We call it off…"

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Adora removed her tiara before the vanity and set it down sighing, Catra was sitting on the edge of the bed looking at her from a safe distance, the mood around them was heavy and dense, so somber. Catra swung her tail from one side to another in a lazy dragged motion while Adora did her best to put up a smile turning back at her.

"I better go with Micah, he'll help me write down the speech to make the announcement" she looked away "it's going to be very different from his advice on writing vows" she laughed dryly, unmotivated.

Catra stood up reaching for her hands "Hey, we aren't cancelling anything, just postponing it in our own terms"

"I know" she drove Catra's hands over to her face kissing them "It's just…I was really excited for this. For a long time I didn't know what I wanted and when I finally have the determination for it, things like this happen"

"That's life for you" Catra tried to joke but she felt her own joke fell short, so instead she cupped her face and leaned in for a kiss "Hey, for all I know, the day I finally said I love you, I made my commitment to you"

Adora's smile turned out to be the prettiest sight Catra had ever witnessed "You are right, in our way, we already have each other bounded to life"

"Yeah, you are not getting rid of me that easily" she smirked playfully before allowing herself the indulgence of cuddling into her arms "As long as we have each other…"

"I promise" Adora mumbled back laying a kiss on top of her head.

***

Adora had been gone for several hours now and Catra still hadn't found the will to leave their room. She didn't felt up to it, up to anything at that point, if she had to admit it to herself she was sad, more than anything at how down and defeated Adora had look. The other woman had been so invested in proving to everyone that she was worth it, worth being saved, worth being loved and Catra had called off her efforts. It was the logical thing to do given the circumstances but she hated to have to be the one suggesting it, to be the one crushing Adora's dreams, her own dreams even.

A knock on the door distracted her form her spiraling down.

"Hey Catra…"

Her ears perked up, she hadn't been expecting her visit this time "Um, hey Sparkles" she sat up on the bed "what's up?"

"Well…I wanted to say sorry" she explained with a faint threat of voice "For the wedding"

"Ow" Catra's ears bent back making her feel small "It's okay, it wasn't your fault"

"Still I feel partially responsible, my kingdom it's the one that has to blow things out of proportion and I couldn't even do anything about it and… and I know you did wanted this, and as much as you act as if it didn't bother you, I can tell"

Catra exhaled walking towards the door resting her forehead against it "It just felt important...I wanted to do this one thing with Adora, a memory we could look back into and not have a war in our hands or space travels or missions, just…an ordinary day we turned extraordinary by just being us, with each other…I didn't quite get it before but…I don't know, so many people around us have tied their lives together like that and…and they look safe and happy…I guess I wanted that for us too"

"That's…the best reason to do it" Glimmer agreed before clearing her throat "Um…this is probably the last thing you'll want to do but today was supposed to be your fitting, your tuxedo is here, I… I thought you might want to have it anyways…so I brought it"

Catra chuckled dryly "Yeah, definitely not up for it, Sparkles"

"Okay, I'll admit, it was an attempt for you to open the door; I'm not getting in without your permission, not today. I just want to make sure you are alright"

Catra took in a deep breath and exhaled unlocking.

On the other side Glimmer held a three piece suit with golden ornaments to match those Adora would have worn. Catra's breath caught up on her throat "It's…it's really nice" she let her fingers run through the smooth fabric "It's quite outstanding" she cleared her throat as she felt the tears assaulting "I'll, I'll just put it on the closet" she grabbed it and practically shoved next to the other clothing, as if by being in the darkest corner would make the suit and the events related to it disappear.

"Your hair" Glimmer pointed "It's down" she mumbled "I haven't seen you wear it like that in a long time" she shrugged her shoulders.

Catra then realized that during her lockdown she had showered, disposed of the elastic and allowed her mane to run wild as frustrated fingers ran freely through her scalp and that she hadn't actually tamed it back down afterwards.

"Don't read too much into it" Catra held a small smile "It just calmed my nerves"

Glimmer smiled back with the same fragility "My mom used to comb my hair when she noticed I was sad or frustrated" she walked to the vanity taking the brush "Do you mind?"

Catra's ears spiked up as she held and uncomfortable frown, raising an eyebrow at the device, not even in the best days she liked the idea, let alone in a night like that.

"I promise it won't hurt, the moment I make you anxious I'll stop" Glimmer offered.

Catra forced her shoulders to drop as she sighed resigned "Sure" she sat on the bed hugging her knees to her chest "But you better not put ribbons in it" she warned.

"It was one time when your hair was growing back and it kept it from falling on your face" Glimmer countered with a smile, feeling more at ease when they could joke so casually,

"All I recall is Mermista's teasing"

"Well, I'll make sure no one can make a comment regarding my handiwork, don't you worry" she stood behind her beginning to brush her wild mane. Her movements were gentle and thoughtful as promised and as they fell into a soothing rhythm, Catra began to let the tension fade "It amazes me how long it is" Glimmer mentioned after a few minutes of silence "I could never stand having it reach below my shoulders" she added, but Catra didn't made any comments, she just kept on embracing herself lost in thought.

Glimmer began to style it, beginning with little braids on the sides that would come to meet on a bun at the top of her head, just behind her ears.

As the monarch continued she noticed Catra's eyes were fixed on the closet "What are you thinking about?" she asked softly and as casually as possible knowing her mind must have drifted back into the wedding or lack of it.

Catra jolted up as if her private thought had been heard and her shoulders tensed again "Nothing" she mumbled into her arms.

"Why don't you try it on?" she suggested.

"What?"

"The suit" she tilted her head into the direction her eyes had been "it's yours after all, you deserve to wear it"

"And let a hundred of 'what ifs' run thought my head? No thank you" she huffed dryly "I'll have time to do that later tonight as I stare at the roof" her eyes averted the garment "I was wondering where Adora might be, actually" she admitted "I don't think writing a speech should take that long so I might have to end up looking for her at the sparing room again"

Glimmer bit her tongue down preventing herself to answer such question, so instead she provided a half truth "Bow is with her"

"And you are with me, both babysitting I see. Good practice for your children" Catra grumbled under her breath.

"Hey, we care about you and as much as we all like to believe everything is okay, we can't expect either of you to shove your feelings aside, you deserve to cope" she grabbed her shoulder giving them a tight squeeze "And I think you should try on the suit, not so you can torture yourself with what might have been, but to picture how it's going to be like, to have something to look forward to" she offered " You should have seen your face when you saw it, you loved it"

Catra shrugged avoiding her eyes as a blush ran through her cheeks. She still wasn't used to having things made for her, to be allowed to look gallant or dashing. Her favorite part of it was getting a reaction out of Adora, seeing her loose her breath and stare, it made her feel all kinds of beautiful.

"It's yours Catra" she repeated "own it" she smirked endearingly.

Catra wasn't even sure when she agreed, but soon she was behind a screen buttoning up the last golden brooch. It felt like wearing an armor. Not that it could protect her from any attack, but it made her feel the same kind of confidence to walk into any battlefield.

When she stepped outside Glimmer's face was completely stunned, a kind of reaction she couldn't have faked.

"You look…you look really handsome, Catra. It definitely embodies you"

Catra smiled trying to hide her sheepishness "Thanks" she looked at the reflection, she liked what she saw, even if it was just a distant fantasy "I bet Adora would have look gorgeous, she always does"

Glimmer smiled at how dreamy Catra seemed at that thought "I bet she would" she stood up from the bed inspecting her up close, tapping a finger to her chin "Come with me, I have just the ornament you are missing" she grabbed her wrist driving her to the hall.

"We don't have to go overboard, Sparkles"

"I know, I know" Glimmer chanted "But there's this one piece of jewelry that I think can make the look come together, don't worry, it's nothing too flashy or princess-y"

"Or pink?"

"Definitely not pink" she assured as they reached the garden gates.

"Wait, your room is the other way" Catra pointed.

"I know, we are not looking for it at my room" she smiled in a way Catra had never seen her before and as she opened the door she found the other side to be lighted by torches and decorated with flowers that formed a hall up to a little kiosk where Micah awaited holding a gauntlet. On every tree there was a chandelier hanging and a a quartet of instruments magically playing themselves into a sweet melody.

"What-what's this?" Catra asked still processing the image in front of them as they walked down the petal path.

"This is your wedding" Glimmer explained softly.

"What?" Catra jolted looking at her "What do you mean?!"

"I am Queen of Bright Moon and have the authority to hold whatever ceremony I see fit in my land and my father is one of the greatest mages there is, he has enough authority to officiate this and make it valid, even if no one knows about it, if it ever gets questioned, it will be binding and Bow and I will be witnesses of it"

"Won't this get you in so much trouble?" she asked, her tone ringing with concern and excitement all at once.

"When they find out, sure" Glimmer admitted "but you guys are worth it" she handed her a ring "here, you'll need this"

Catra inspected the engraving, it had Bright Moon's Royal Family's crest in it "This belongs to you" she shook her head unable to accept it.

"It's tradition to exchange tokens that are past down by family members, so knowing this will stay with you and Adora, makes me incredibly happy, you are my family too" she settled the box

on her hand closing her palm so she would hold on to it "You have fought and thrived, always looking out for others, you deserve to think about you own happiness" she looked over her shoulder smiling as the doors opened again " so for now, enjoy this" she turned her around just in time for Bow to walk in next to a clueless and equally surprised Adora.

When Catra laid eyes on her she took in the image of Adora wearing her white and golden dress, looking just as gorgeous if not more so than Catra could have ever imagined. When they finally locked gazes both lost their breaths and in just that brief exchange of glances, they knew they were doing it for real.

"This is your day, Catra" Glimmer mumbled to her ear pressing a kiss on her cheek as Adora walked up to the kiosk holding Bow's arm, her eyes never leaving those of Catra. When they were finally face to face both giggled nervously unable to hold back their excitement.

"We are doing this" Adora breathed out "In our own terms"

"More like their terms" Catra tilted her head towards the other couple "And how I love them for it"

"Me too" she chuckled "Are you ready?"

"As I'll ever be, as I've always been" she nodded.

"If that's the case" Micah smiled turning their attention to him as he began the ceremony, his words as moving and touching as they were, got lost between them, because there was only one thought roaming through their heads.

"Now, you can exchange your vows"

"Promises" Adora cut in looking at him "We always made promises, it's…"

"Our thing?" Catra provided with an amused smirk.

"Yeah" Adora giggled with anticipation and exhilaration "Now I know how to make good on those"

"Me too" she nodded "We'll exchange promises"

"Very well" Micah smiled "Adora, what are your promises?"

Adora grabbed Catra's hands into her own and searched for her eyes with her ocean blue ones "That I'd always be with you, no matter what the future might hold, I am here and I'll be there and I say this not as She-Ra, but as Adora, promising you that I will never leave your side, not again, not ever" she leaned in caressing her cheek "You have been my friend, my family, my rival, my enemy, my lover and if not fate, war or destiny had been able to pull us apart, then I'm sure our love is stronger than whatever the future might throw our way" she closed her eyes leaning in "So bring it, I'm ready"

Catra did her best not to steal away a kiss just yet, so instead she fought the tears and nodded moving a loose buckle of her golden hair back.

"Adora…I learned how to love you before I even loved myself and although I hurt you for that same reason, you only made me stronger and you never gave up on me, even when I pushed you to the edge, quite literally" she huffed nervously "So I promise, I'll always love you, because you too have always been everything to me. I want to marry you because that way, even if we are galaxies away, I'll still know that you have stayed with me. No matter the distance, we'll be together"

"Forever" Adora whispered.

"I promise"

"Do you have the tokens you wish to exchange?" Micah asked.

"Yeah" Adora hastily reached Bow taking a strange looking piece of jewelry "I…I found this, it was Mara's, since she's the closest thing I have to a connection to the First Ones and for all her

sacrifices, it-it felt right to take it as a token. Madame Razz said someone special to her had given it to her first, someone back home, so, whenever you see it, I want you to know, I'll always be your home" she presented the object and Catra accepted it heartedly, she was never going to take it off.

"I…I just got yours" she looked to the side at Glimmer "From someone that saw past where we came from and gave us both a new home as well as a second chance" she showed the ring and Adora recognized the emblem in it "So I want you to know, I'll never take for granted the opportunity I was given, and when you see this ring know I'd go through the entire cosmos to get to you"

"Now, if you both accept each other and the promises you just made-"Micah continued but neither needed to hear what came next, they were soon enveloping each other in arms sharing their first kiss as wives and nothing else mattered. For that instant no corner of the universe was dark, no shadows from the past, no worry or harm could reach them, because as long as they were together, nothing could stop them.

A whitish flash forced Catra to open her eyes and find clearer blue ones inspect her with a deep blush, as She-Ra had transformed.

"Really Adora?" Catra smirked against her lips, her arms still around the shoulders of the now taller woman.

"Really" Adora sweep her up carrying her bridal style making the feline jolt in surprise and embarrassment "Now that I can call you mine, I'll never let go"

Catra cupped her face knowing she meant her words "I love you" she leaned in to kiss her again "all of you" she mumbled between pecks.

"You guys!" Bow launched into a hug and Adora turned back to normal letting him congratulate them "we are so happy for you!"

"You are the best!" Adora crunched him in arms "I can't believe you did all of this for us"

"There's one more thing" Glimmer added "Both of you will go to my aunt's palace to spend a week away from all of this, Swiftwind will take you and Melog can make sure no one will see you. Bow and I will handle everything here so you can enjoy time together"

"Are you sure we can do that?" Adora asked, her eyes sparking with illusion at the prospect of a getaway with Catra "What if there are any disputes from any of the emissaries?"

"I'll make the announcement saying the wedding is off" Glimmer explained "any problem will be addressed to me"

"And we have the princess alliance to back us up, so you can relax" Bow assured "everything is covered"

"Consider this out wedding gift"

"Glimmer!" Adora swung her around while Catra hugged Bow.

The instruments started to play a different tune and Adora eagerly stretched her hand towards Catra.

"Shall we?" she asked.

"What?" Catra smirked amused.

"I really don't get to do this often and…I'd like to make a new memory of us dancing other than in Princess Proms. So…can I share a first dance with my wife?"

Catra let go of the faintest tension on her shoulders and grabbed Adora's hand, her wife's hand "I'd be happy to"

Bow extended his palm towards Glimmer "Mind doing the honors?"

Glimmer took it as both couples began to sway from side to side into the music.

"This is not how I picture our day would end up looking like, with us getting married" Adora chuckled, her arms on the small of Catra's back.

"Definitely, but it was how I picture my life would end up being like, with you by my side" Catra gazed at her with devotion, her arms resting over Adora's chest as she leaned in to kiss her again. She was going to kiss her until her lips felt numb and she had her taste committed to memory and then she'd kiss her all over again for the rest of her life.

"I love"

"I love you too"

When the song came to an end they were briefly interrupted by the other couple as they changed dance partners.

Bow allowed Catra to lead as they took in the music.

"I'm so happy for you" he said honestly "Who would have thought all those years back we would end up living under the same roof?"

Catra chuckled "Not in a million years would I have picture that" she admitted "And now I can't imagine it any other way"

"Good" Bow said "Because this is your place, even if you go beyond our star, you can always come back to us"

"We will" Catra said solemnly, knowing that behind those calmed eyes laid a promise, even if their paths drifted they could find a way back to Bright Moon and be received with open arms.

"Excuse us, may we cut in?" Glimmer asked standing next to Adora.

"Of course" Bow lead Catra's hand into Glimmer's as they switched partners.

Glimmer flashed her an endearing smile knowing what question lingered in the other woman's head.

"How did you thought of this?" Catra asked resting a hand on her waist and another on her shoulder, she was still trying to figure out how the most fluffy, pink-y princess of them all had outsmarted her.

"Well, you did say that if Adora asked you, you'd exchange vows in the back garden that same night. Figured you meant it. A little magic here, a bit of schemer-y over there and here we are" she said smugly before turning a bit shyly "I hope it was okay, thought, I wanted to ask but that would have ruined the surprise and I'm sorry I couldn't bring Scorpia, teleportation is not on my cards right now"

"It's okay, I'll get to tell her in person when we get back" Catra shrugged nonchalant "It'd be fun to see her struck face when she hears you fooled me" she swirled her around catching her back in arms.

"...I meant everything I said before, thought, you know, through the door and at your room" Glimmer said softly. Even if she had planned all this behind her back, her words would never be deceiving, not when it came to their talks.

Catra hugged Glimmer with might nesting against her shoulder as they still swayed gently "You are so annoying"

"Yeah, yeah, I know you love me" Glimmer mocked tapping her back as they came to a complete stop.

"I do" Catra mumbled "I love you, Glimmer" she said only for her ears. They had known each other for several years now and still Catra could count the times she had said those words out loud, it was rare for her to say it out front, but at that time, Glimmer had become one of the most important people in her life.

Glimmer was caught off guard by how heartedly she admitted it and held on tight in return, closing her eyes, resting in the

embrace "I love you too"

The music stopped while Adora and Bow approached them and Glimmer knew it was time to bare her farewells, she sniffed trying her best to hide away the tears "Now both off you go" she released her turning to Bow, avoiding gazes to wipe her eyes "We'll see you next week"

Adora turned to Catra breathing in excitedly "Ready?"

"Almost" Catra grabbed Glimmer's shoulders planting a messy kiss on her cheek as the Queen had done so many years ago "Ready"

Chapter End Notes

I might add a small chapter of one of Catra&Adora's interactions at Castaspella's palace...

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

> I did started a chapter about Adora and Catra being at Castaspella's palace but it just wasn't flowing and it felt off with the dynamic of previous chapters, so I'll probably post that one on a separated one shot somewhere in the future.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer exhaled tiredly gazing at the roof from the comfort of her bed and the dozen pillows around her. It had been two days now since she had been glued to that place, but she couldn't bear to walk another step and the twins were being so restless lately, kicking and digging their elbows on her hip. Her due date was sure to be soon.

So she sighed as her hands rubbed her now giant stomach trying to ease up the pair.

"Please sweethearts, stay put for a moment, mom needs to rest" she talked in a soothing tone with little success. Glimmer actually huffed "The level of insubordination from such a young age, you'll make me pay for being so difficult as child, huh?"

A knock interrupted her one-sided conversation, it was late into the night, so the Queen didn't expect anyone to reach her door "Who is it?"

"The Hoard Scum, your Majesty" the sarcastic voice answered.

"Catra! What are you doing here? You were supposed to come back tomorrow" she tried to sit to speak properly but the twins were against it.

"We decided to come home a bit earlier, Adora said she felt like we should be here" she answered "Is Bow with you?"

"No, he went to pick up his dads, he'll be back in a couple of hours"

"Good" she opened the door "Because Adora is raiding the kitchen and from what Micah told us, it seems like you could use this" she showed a plate "here you go"

"Cake!" she beamed "Bow hasn't let me have sweets in days!"

"He is not the one pregnant and about to give birth" she raised a brow looking at her belly "how are you feeling?"

"Happy, nervous, excited, exhausted" she listed, her eyes showed all those emotions at once.

Catra chuckled as she reached the end of the bed sitting at her side "Quite the ride" she smiled before averting her eyes "Were things too messy after we left?"

"Only you would ask something like that five minutes after coming back" Glimmer complained taking a piece of cake into her mouth "I told you, you don't have to worry about anything"

"And neither should you, you are obviously about to pop"

Glimmer stuck her tongue out "I'm perfectly fine, this is just me avoiding paperwork"

"Sure" Catra rolled her eyes getting right next to her throwing an arm around her shoulders. Glimmer didn't hesitate to lean into her and exhale tiredly. She didn't have to keep putting a façade, unlike with the other visitors that came bearing news and asking for advice.

"Is there anything you need?" Catra asked, her voice soft like a whisper.

"You already brought cake, I'm good" she assured taking another bite "And Bow and my dad have been managing thus far, so really, there's nothing to worry about" she reaffirmed.

"Okay, your Majesty" she swiped a finger on the frosting having a bite out of the cake "Your kids will have such a sweet tooth"

Glimmer chuckled heartedly "I know, that's most of what I have been feeding them, they'll be little sugar monsters" she caressed her stomach "Especially this one" she pointed at her side "Whenever I eat sweets this baby starts kicking"

Catra laughed pressing her forehead against her puffy hair "You know? There are bets placed on the sex of the babies"

"Really?"

"Oh yeah, the whole princess alliance is in it" she teased "Scorpia and Frosta bet they'll be boys, Perfuma and Adora say girls, Entrapta says she wouldn't bet on anything without data even if it was just statistics and probability and Mermista bet Bow would faint. I actually took a piece of that action, he is going to pass out"

"And you?"

"I'm not about to faint over-"

"No! What sex?"

"Oh, a boy and a girl"

"That's cheating! That way you can always say you were half right"

"I'm just calling it"

"Okay then, who will be born first?"

Catra raised a brow "Okay, now that's an interesting question" she leaned in "Can I?" she asked.

"Sure" she removed her hands and Catra rested her fluffy ear over the baby bump, her fingers softly caressing the skin "are you

expecting them to give you a clue?"

"Who knows? I have good instincts" she smirked before laying a kiss "I'll meet you soon, kiddos" she whispered going back to Glimmer's side "The girl, she'll be the older twin"

"You sound very confident"

"Nah, worst case scenario I'm wrong and I still get to play with them, I don't care, I just want to see them already, don't care who's first"

Glimmer giggled, the cake was long gone now, so the Queen turned the slightest bit over her shoulder to wrap an arm around Catra. The feline woman soothed into the embrace as her soft purring took over the silence of the room. A couple of minutes passed before Glimmer dared open her eyes, her grip around Catra's waist tightening, her shoulders tense.

"Catra?"

"Hum?" she opened her blue eye looking at her.

"I…I need to ask you for a favor…" her voice came off faint, frail.

"What is it?" she asked noticing how wary the young Queen had grown.

"When I get into labor…if…if it comes to me or the babies, I need you to tell them the babies"

"What?" Catra felt her skin crawl as she jolted sitting up "What are you-? Why would you say something like-?"

"Catra, I'm having twins, there's a risk that I am aware of" Glimmer answered, her tone steady, even though her eyes differed "My mom had a difficult birth with me, I just need someone to know what my wishes are"

"Why-why me?"

"Because you are the only one that would listen to me" she grabbed her hands "I know that my dad, Adora and even Bow will brush off my concern, they'll say that nothing bad could happen and yes, more than likely they are right but- but in case something does happen, my priority are my kids" she said earnestly looking into her eyes "please" she emphasized.

Catra felt the tears assault her "You are asking me to tell them not to save you"

Glimmer swallowed hard "If it comes to it…then yes. My babies come first"

"What about Bow? What about your dad? You can't leave them"

"I don't want to-! Do you think it is fun to entertain this thought?!" she cried back "But I am a mother now and if I've learned anything from my own mom is that there's nothing I wouldn't sacrifice for my children. Even if I haven't seen them yet, or named them or held them in arms, I love them with all my might! I choose them over myself every time"

Catra felt her ears bend backwards, her tail tightly wrapping around herself, the knot in her stomach made her feel sick because in her core, she knew Glimmer had found her resolve and she knew it was heartedly and absolutely correct "Okay" she mumbled sniffing "It won't come to that, though" she pointed out wiping the tears "but I'll respect your wishes, your loved ones are first" she nodded trying to school her lip from trembling.

"Thank you" Glimmer hugged her tightly. That was probably the most difficult favor she would ever ask for and she knew Catra would come through for her if the decision had to be made. "I'm sorry" she mumbled "I know it's not fair…but I trust you that much" she snugged into her shoulder as Catra held her back. For that moment both wished time could freeze, the future seemed that much uncertain and scarier, but all the same it brought a sense of peace and reassurance.

***

It was probably close to six in the morning when the commotion started. Catra picked up the sound and the rush coming from the hall before Adora could. Her cat ears twitched as several footsteps rushed from one side to another in almost erratic movements. So Catra sat up on the bed trying to discern what the buzz was about. Adora did the same a moment after, still rubbing her eyes trying to make out shapes and colors.

"What's going on?" she asked, her voice husky and uneven.

"I don't know" Catra answered when suddenly the door swung open and Micah stormed inside, his face radiant and excited.

"Glimmer is having her babies!" he announced not waiting another second before running down the hall.

Both women jolted out of bed grabbing a night robe and racing outside of Glimmer's door. The physician was there giving instructions to the guard to fetch him towels and potions.

"How is she?" Catra asked, she hoped the fear in her tone would be mistaken by some other emotion.

"The Queen is doing great, it's just a lot of effort" he explained "now please, wait outside, if there are any news we'll let you know" he opened the door briefly letting them have a glimpse of the scene inside. Glimmer was screaming at the top of her lungs as she pushed and Bow was right beside her, holding her hand and saying reassuring words to her ear. After that, they were left on the other side of the door and that was the first time Catra didn't felt comfortable with the division among them, because in the past she could always be there for her through that closed portal, but now she was shut out by it.

Adora energetically grabbed her hand tugging her to the side.

"I can't believe Glimmer is having her babies right now!" she exclaimed, her face beaming "if we hadn't come back we would have missed it! Apparently my She-Ra feeling was correct. Destiny needed us to be here"

Catra swallowed hard, she hadn't told Adora about her talk with the Queen, about the petition she had to uphold. And the thought of destiny bringing them home beforehand only made her stomach turn, because what if- and only what if- she needed to be there to make sure Glimmer's will was followed.

"We have to send word of this to the other princesses!" Adora said "Come on, if we send a quick message they will be here in time for breakfast to meet the babies" she grabbed her hand to go down the hall, but Catra grounded herself into place.

"No" she said with resolve and urgency "We have to stay here, what if they need something?" she looked back at the door "Let's wait until they are born" she said firmly and quite shaken.

"You heard the physician, if there's any news he'll let us know"

"What if they don't find us in time?"

Adora frowned; her recently named wife was acting out of the ordinary. In past years she would rely on Melog to clue her in into her emotions, showing her aura in the scarlet mane, but she had learned how to read her now, sometimes it was easier to understand Catra's feelings over her own "What's wrong?" she asked directly, but Catra deflected her eyes, unluckily her ears were down casted giving away her uneasiness, her concern, her fear?

"Catra?" Adora stood right in front of her "Tell me what's troubling you" her voice was firm, like a command, but her eyes were begging, a plea.

Catra gazed at the ground, Adora's hand was in her sightline and the metallic spark in one of her fingers reassured her, that was her wife, they had made promises, she didn't have to carry the weight on her own and Glimmer never asked her to. So Catra swallowed breathing in "I'm…I have to make sure that…if there are any complications…that if their lives are in danger…they choose the babies" She explained, hoping Adora would understand the context, knowing sometimes the most obvious things skipped her train of thought. It did take her half a second to connect the dots and the confusion on her face swiftly turned into horror.

"Wh-?!"

"Glimmer asked me to make sure her will would be followed, even if it could be her last, her children come first"

"When did he told you this?!"

"Last night" she admitted

"Why didn't she told me-? Does Bow know?"

"No" Catra exhaled unevenly, as emotions began to bubble inside, she wasn't sure if it was anguish or anger, maybe both.

"But he's their father too, he should-! She can't decide things like that on her own!" Adora was growing furious, probably out of fear and confusion.

"That's why she entrusted this to me" Catra cut her sternly "Because I'll respect her decision" she emphasized "I don't know if this is right or wrong, but I know that she made that decision because she is putting the ones she loves the most first"

"So she's leaving Bow without a cho-?"

"She's making sure he gets to be a dad!" Catra retorted "Do you think he would be less broken by losing his kids?" it was an unfair and uncalled for question, but Catra was trying to untangle her

own feelings on the matter, for the first time standing on the opposite side of the argument.

"Of course not! But he should get a saying too!"

"You didn't let me have a saying!" Catra finally snapped, her eyes streaming rivers "You are always the first to sacrifice her life for others, to take the risk, to rise to the occasion-! You were willing to die so acceptingly and I didn't get to have a say in anything! So from all the people in this kingdom, in this planet, in this galaxy, I thought you would be the one to actually understand this!"

Adora was aback, her mouth hanging uselessly open "I-I…"

Catra sighed letting go of the raw emotion that was growing on her chest "I hate too that she would make me put her life and safety as the last priority, but I do understand why she's doing it" she cleaned her eyes "And hopefully this whole mess will be all for none and soon we'll get to see those kids and forget about this, but until then, I'll stand outside this door and make sure that if it comes to it, the babies are first" she walked back to the door.

"No" Adora said firmly.

"What?" Catra turned around.

"No, I won't forget we had this talk and I won't let this go unacknowledged" she remarked sternly "Because I do understand the sacrifice Glimmer is willing to take and I don't agree with the way she decided to handle this. Her family, her friends, her kingdom, she owes it to all of us to tell us about a decision that could potentially affect everyone" she walked to her "and I probably hate her actions more than anything because they do resonate with my own, with what I have done, what I left unsaid…" she reached for her hands "I…I am sorry, Catra…I know all those years back you only wanted to protect me and while I was trying to do the same, I never allowed you to have even a say in the matter, I thought that if I had to make a sacrifice it would be worth it because you would live but…I didn't stop to

think what kind of life I would be leaving you behind to have, on how lonely and remorseful it could be" she admitted "And I realize that even now, when we go to missions I tend to act the same way, always jumping head first into danger if it means that whatever threat we are facing won't get to you but…but we are a team, we are a family, we are married now and I won't be making these decisions on my own anymore. I share my life with you now and as such, I understand that the impact of my actions won't affect me alone…" she searched for her eyes "So, I'll wait right here with you" she leaned against the door holding her hand "I said I would stay by your side and that means you won't have to do this alone"

Catra felt her heart pang in a mixture of feelings she couldn't label, but as they sat down on the floor and she found the comfort of Adora holding her hand, she began to understand she felt safe. Not less scared of whatever was happening on the other side, but at least reality was easier to face when she could lean into someone, the person she loved the most.

"Thank you, Adora" she rested her head onto her shoulder as her tail swirled around Adora's forearm. She wouldn't ever be left behind anymore.

***

The door opened as the physician cleaned his hands, he seemed exhausted.

"You can go in" was the only thing he said as both bolted inside were only Glimmer was, sweaty and exhausted and with such a lovely smile in face.

"The babies are with my dad and Bow while the nurses clean them up" she said breathlessly.

Catra walked up to the bed just before her knees gave away and she crumbled into her arms, unable to fight off the tears.

Glimmer didn't needed an explanation, her heart ached at the sight "I'm sorry" she hugged her back mumbling "I'm sorry" she repeated stroking circles on her back and pressing a kiss on top of her head. She looked up at Adora, by the look on her face it was evident she knew the favor she had asked for. There was sure to be a talk about it, but not right now.

Catra did her best to compose herself as she let go of her, cleaning her eyes. This was Glimmer's day, she would not steal that away.

"How…how are the babies?" she asked trying to offer a smile and Glimmer's eyes softened with tenderness.

"They are great" she grinner wider than ever before "And annoyingly enough, you were right" she smirked "A girl and a boy and she was first"

Catra chuckled cleaning her eyes "Told you, good instincts"

"That's true" she cupped her face "thank you" she mumbled and Catra nodded, a whole conversation was held with jus their gazes and then the door opened and Bow and Micah entered holding the babies.

"Guess who's here to see their mama?" Bow knelt down at her side putting the baby boy while Micah did the same with the little girl.

Glimmer held them against her chest as the tears roamed freely.

"Hey, little ones" she cooed "my babies" she kissed their heads repeatedly overwhelmed with excitement. The Queen was caught up with emotions as her father caressed her head.

"I can feel your mother smiling at this"

"Yeah" Glimmer sniffed before smiling his way "I can feel it too"

***

Word of the babies reached the other princesses by noon and while the commotion had finally settled a bit, both designated guardians got a few minutes to hold the kids in arms in complete solitude.

Growing up in the Hoard meant that seeing babies was very rare and for the longest of time, their squadron had been the youngest, which made this experience all the more special.

"How can they be so tiny?" Adora said melting over the boy's small hands trying to grab one of her fingers "And they smell so good" she pressed a kiss on his head.

"They are wonderful" Catra agreed gently rocking the girl as she yawned. Her hair resembled Glimmer's but the eyes were definitely Bow's. They were so frail and little and she was just so sure they would grow up to do so many amazing things.

Adora breathed out "I'm…going to miss them"

Catra's ears fell as she came to the same realization. Now that they had called off the wedding, while secretly having one, they were free to travel again, but no longer with Bow and Glimmer at their side, they would have to stay and raise the new rules of Bright Moon.

"We still have a couple of months before leaving" Catra said in a reassuring tone.

"Yeah" Adora tried her best to sound less sadden.

"Plus, with the technology we took from the Hoard, we can teleport from various space stations, we can visit every three months or so" the feline woman pointed out.

"Right, it's not like we are going to miss seeing them grow up" Adora held the newborn close to her chest "We'll be in their lives"

"Yes… we will" Catra snuggled the little princess into her chest. A silence passed them by while each contemplated life in their own way "You know…?" Catra broke the silence "I never considered having kittens but…I don't know, do you think we would be able to?" she asked gently, trying to feel the room.

"Well, I mean we have Melog, that's like a huge kitty, right?" she asked oblivious and instead of calling her idiot, like she should, Catra smirked amused giving the other woman a couple of seconds to catch up.

"Ow!" she jolted up making the boy complain readjusting into her arms. Adora turned completely reddened and embarrassed while looking at her "Kittens, our kittens!" she clarified.

Catra nodded calmly, a smile on her face "Yeah, our kids" she used another word so they would be in the same page "Did you ever…?"

Adora cleared her throat still flushed "I mean…I hoped we would…yes"

Catra smiled faintly "You think…we would be good parents?"

"Why wouldn't we be?" she asked before receiving a knowing look in return "Right, we didn't get good role models to look after" she reached Catra as the exchanged babies to look after "But, we could be better than that, right? Better than her? We'll never do what she did to us, it's pretty much a straight forward path after that"

Catra chuckled dryly, pushing the thoughts of her childhood aside while rocking gently the prince and at that moment she knew she

had found her resolve "I do want this, Adora"

"Me too" she smiled before being the one to be the voice of reason "Just not right now"

"I know, I know" Catra smirked knowing perfectly "We are about to resume our mission, it's pretty awkward timing, we still have a few travels to make before settling"

Adora smiled easing up, they both understood the situation, they both understood one another "But someday…" she left the rest unsaid.

Catra nodded tiptoeing to reach her lips and kiss her "Yeah" she rested against her shoulder as they cuddled the twins "Someday"

Chapter End Notes

I hope you enjoyed it!
And I do take suggestions on the babies names! XD (Thus far I think the girl's name could be Crystal, who has another idea?)

Thank you for the support!

Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora and Catra touched down on Bright Moon's soil, Darla parked at the main gate as several guards approached them to give a proper reception.

As soon as they set foot on the grass, the feeling of being back home washed over them.

Catra breathed in the fresh air letting the breeze run through her hair "I've missed this" she felt like purring.

"It's nice to be back" Adora nodded, her head thrown back, eyes closed "And just in time too" she added.

"You have the presents?"

"Loaded and ready"

"Perfect, we wouldn't want to make it to their birthday party empty-handed" Catra smirked "It's not every day they turn five"

Adora smiled as well "I can't believe it's been so long since they were born" she wrapped and arm around her shoulders as they walked in "I'm really looking forward to this break"

"Me too" Catra exhaled exhaustedly, their travels around the galaxies were incredibly demanding and outrageously dangerous. The collection of scars and bruises in their bodies had only grown since they started traveling as a duo. Now, after several years on the same mission to restore the magic across the universe, they had made enough progress and connections for others to help them in their quest, which meant that for the first time in a long while, they could slow down and touch base.

Just when they were about to step inside two little figures rushed towards, tackling them in tight embraces.

"Aunty Dora!"

"Aunty Cat!"

"Look at you!" They picked up the twins swirling them before hugging them in arms "How can you be so tall already?! You are barely four"

"No! We are five!" they held a hand up with their fingers stretched.

"That can't be true! If you were five that would mean today it's your birthday"

"It's our birthday!"

"Really? Then it's a good thing we brought some gifts, right Adora?"

"That's right" she settled the youngest twin down opening her bag "This is a holographic storybook, not only does it shows stories, but it will also illustrate whatever you tell it to, Saber"

The boy's eyes sparkled just like his mother's "Wow!" he grabbed the device seeing magical creatures appear before his eyes. He jumped up and down with excitement.

"And for our little princess, Angella" Catra knelt down as well reaching for a device that resembled a mirror "This small thing can show you whomever you want to look for, you just need to add their picture and then you say their name and they'll appear on screen. No matter the place, the time or the galaxy, you'll see them"

"I'll see you?" she asked, her eyes filled with hope, she always had the hardest time saying goodbye whenever they had to resume their journeys "Even when you are away?"

"Yeah, no matter the distance" Catra nodded moving a rebel pastel lock behind her ear.

"What do you say kids?" a voice called behind them as both parents walked in.

"Thank you!" they hugged them tight before running back to show their parent their new toys.

"Mamma look!" Angella showed hers while Saber began to describe incredible heroes for the book to show his dad.

"These are amazing" the couple was immersed with their kids' excitement "Why don't you show grandpas and tell them our guests of honor have arrived?"

"Okay!" the twins ran off in perfect synchronization.

"Don't worry, both gifts have parental control" Catra assured while they walked towards them.

The two couples were barely able to hold their anticipation as they reached one another, after several months of being away.

"I can't believe you are already here!" Glimmer teleported unable to stand the distance any longer as she hugged them first, her husband close behind.

"You guys!" Bow held them in arms "You made it!"

"We wouldn't miss it!"

"It's so nice to see you!"

They let go taking in the image.

"Look at you, all settled into the crown" Catra teased Bow, it had been almost half a year since Micah had stepped down to dedicate himself to be a grandfather full time.

Bow sheepishly fixed the ornament on his head "It's been an adjustment"

"You have done amazingly" Glimmer leaned into his shoulder "But what about the two of you? You just traveled hundreds of light years, you must be tired and hungry, we have a feast ready" Glimmer didn't wait for any reply as she popped them into the grand table that had all sorts of dishes in it.

"How I've missed Etherian food" Adora sighed dreamingly taking a piece of cake in the act.

"Let's eat then" they sat at the table ready to catch up, so much had happened and time was of the essence before the party began.

"We are so glad you could come" Bow emphasized yet again, it was good to have the Best Friend Squad back together.

"Are you kidding? We wouldn't dare miss it!" Adora assured taking her fifth piece of baked pastries.

"Yeah, when have we ever passed on an opportunity to spoil your kids?" Catra retorted.

"It's just that with your last mission's report we figured it would be challenging to make it back, especially since you were so far away and you usually can't stay here for too long"

Both shared a look, they had ended up battling a mythical monster that consumed magic, so invoking She-Ra had been out of the cards, so they ended up fighting as they would back in the Horde, just hand in hand which had been both equally fun and problematical.

"Actually" Adora tilted her head "We were thinking…we might stay put for now"

"Like for more than a couple of weeks?"

Adora looked back at Catra grabbing her hand as she nodded "More like more than a couple of months, a year"

Both were struck processing the words before snapping from the surprise.

"Are you serious?"

"We talked about it" Adora began.

"And we think it might be time to slow down"

"You know, retracts the claws, set the sword down, see how it goes" Adora chuckled "So, if you could have us-?"

"That's not even up for discussion!" Glimmer teleported across the table to envelope them in a hug "We'll be more than happy to have you back!"

"This is the best thing ever!" Bow rushed to them "Wait until we tell the kids! They are going to lose it!"

"It's sort of because of them we thought we should do this" Catra added under the embrace "we've talked and we don't want to keep popping up now and then just to leave the moment after, we want to be in their lives, we have missed so much already"

"And after seeing so many things beyond our stars, the thought of coming home was just so comforting, we want to live our life now" Adora continued "If we are needed we'll answer the call, but for the time being, we want to have a little time for ourselves"

"That's great to hear, these are wonderful news!" Bow said earnestly "we should toast to that" he raised a glass "For the Best Friend Squad"

All four glasses clashed as a cheer emerged.

***

"Who wants cake?" Bow chanted as a group of children circled him screaming and asking for a slice. His kids got the first ones as he started to give away the rest of the pastries away.

Adora stood up about to claim a piece.

"Seriously Adora?" Catra asked amused.

"What?" she turned around with her big innocent eyes.

"You just ate a whole cake like three hours ago"

"It's really good" she pouted as Catra rolled her eyes.

"Here you go" Frosta approached them handing Catra a slice with a huff. It was odd to see how much she had grown now, but in her core she was still pretty much the same.

"Thanks" she received it.

"I can't believe I agreed to this" she rolled her eyes.

"You lost the bet five years ago, kid, and you are still paying up" Catra shrugged her shoulders with a mischievous smirk "and this is way better than taking your money" she handed the plate to Adora, who's eyes brighten up at the sight of food.

"Wildcat!" A strong pair of pincers hugged her from behind.

"Hey Scorpia" she greeted with a huge smile while Perfuma approached Adora.

"When Glimmer said you guys were coming I thought to myself, 'now that's dedication', you can be a hundred planets away and still make it to these parties" she brushed her hair making her ears fold back, in the past Catra found it to be annoying but now

had grown fond of the caress, especially after being gone for so long.

"Five years in a row, we were not about to break that streak" She hugged back the moment her arms were free to move around.

"We've missed you guys a lot" Perfuma added taking a seat "How's space treating you? Are the breathing exercises still helping?"

"You have no idea" both nodded, being out there meant to have to face a lot of pressure and stress, so whenever they felt way over their heads they would call Perfuma to guide them through a meditation. More often than not Scorpia would be in the background of the video call waving around and making comments regarding how useful all of Perfuma's recommendations were. Afterwards they would talk for hours to catch up, but nothing could beat being face to face.

"Well look who decided to show up" Netossa teased, arm intertwined with Spinella's "Almost didn't recognized you"

"If you guys don't appear at least 10 times a year, I'll be officially named Sea-Ra, I already have the brand moving" Mermista interfered with a monotone voice, sitting among them, Seahawk close behind.

"You guys make it sound like we are never around" Adora chuckled, the tiniest bit of awkwardness in her voice.

"Statistically speaking we can't use the word 'never', but if we take into consideration a margin of a 5 percent error, then yes, the expression is accurate" Entrapta added taking bites of her miniature food, she would take some home for Hordak.

"Hey, not that we need you to keep the front safe, the alliance is as strong as ever" Netossa smirked provokingly.

"We know, that's why we had the confidence to leave in the first place, because you would look after Etheria" Catra said

nonchalant.

"Wildcat!" Scorpia hugged her again "you softie"

"I'm not!" she scoffed "It's just facts"

"Aw!"

Catra blushed, arms folded. She still felt embarrassed to be called out on her moments of vulnerability and honesty; it was a bit of a struggle not to confuse those with weakness.

"Let them be" Spinella asked softly "If it's not every day we have them here, we should at least make sure they enjoy their time with us, not annoy them"

"Where's the fun in that?"

Catra and Adora exchanged a glance, they ought to tell them about their plans, but stealing away the spotlight from the party didn't felt quite right.

"After?" Adora tilted her head, a brow raised.

"Yeah" she mumbled "Later"

"Aunty She-Dora" Saber ran up to the blonde graving her hand "Help us, help us!" he pointed at the piñata "we want candy!"

"Oh, so you need a bit of muscle, ha?" she stood rolling up her white sleeve "Be right back" she turned to kiss Catra before changing her form after her war cry and a white flash "You'll have to do your part, little Saber" She-Ra picked him up in arms as they reached the animal shaped figure filled with sweets. Saber swung the bat energetically laughing loudly. Adora didn't even have to do anything, just hold the boy and encourage him as he tried his best.

Catra saw how much Adora was enjoying herself and it made her smile, after the stressful missions and non-stop journeys, it was

nice to see her just be, no title to uphold, no world to save, just a moment to have fun.

Saber finally gave a blow that broke the piñata into two and the candy flew in all directions. Adora retransformed letting him down so he could collect his bounty among the other kids.

Soon enough the older twin climbed Catra's lap and extended her a treat "Milk chocolate"

"My favorite, thanks little Sparkle" she grabbed it before hugging her.

"How come we don't get candy too?" Frosta asked, arms folded.

Angella shrugged shyly avoiding their eyes.

Catra stuck her tongue out smugly hugging the little princess closer "Too bad, I have privileges" she kissed her cheek as the girl giggled "go enjoy your party, okay? I'll see you later"

Angella nodded running off to her brother as Adora came back, she had seen the girl single Catra out, it was easy to see they shared a connection. Angella was way less introverted around the feline woman than any other adult and whenever they came to Bright Moon, the girl would do everything in her power to be next to her. Sit by her side at the table, walk her around the halls and even once she had sneaked into the ship in hopes of going with them. After that, Catra had asked Melog to stay with them for the time being, that had been the only way to get Angella to stop crying as they bid yet another farewell.

Adora melted at the way Catra looked at the girl, it came so natural to her, the way she could take care of the younglings and know what they needed, or if something was bothering them and she always had the right thing to say. Adora would always admire that about Catra. She turned out to be everything that Shadow Weaver never could.

"Enjoying the party?" Glimmer asked hand in hand with Bow as they walked towards them finally having a moment to sit down.

"It's great!" Scorpia smiled hugely "Love the decorations and the games, really neat!"

"The bite size of the food is optimal" Entrapta corroborated.

As they sat down stories of the past were told among them, reliving the old days of quests and adventures, while still catching up with whatever each of them had done in their respective lands. Hours flew them by as other guests left at sundown and soon there was nothing but soft music playing, chatter in a few tables and some kids still running and chasing one another.

Catra laughed at one of Scorpias stories as Perfuma turned beet red, then she caught Adora staring at her fondly. The blonde warrior stood up stretching a hand up to her "Can I have a dance?" she asked softly.

Catra smiled as her tail swayed, it had been a really long while since she had last heard that petition "Yes" she grabbed her hand leaving the table as some other couples joined in. Adora hugged her close gently rocking from side to side.

"I've really missed this"

"Me too" she closed her eyes leaning into her shoulder, her purring faintly sounding in the background.

"Do you think it's time?" Adora asked gently "To leave it all behind for good?"

Catra opened her eyes but made an effort not to show too much surprise "What?"

"The whole travels, the missions, the risk…" she continued "I know we agreed on a year but-" she swirled her around catching her back into arms "you've heard them" she tilted her head towards the other princesses "and they are not wrong, we are

hardly here and we are rarely at a same place more than a couple of days. Darla has turned out to be the most familiar habitat for both of us but…I want to grow some roots" she explained "I want to stay in Etheria, for good" she emphasized "because if we leave in a year, then this is just another pit stop and we'll have to say goodbye all over again. It just feels cruel…"

Catra gazed around, Adora's words hit a bit too close to home, especially as she saw the twins approaching them.

"Dance with us!" they interrupted breaking them apart. Their smiles were so contagious the other two agreed to leave the conversation for later as Saber stood over Adora's heels and Angella raised her hands waiting to be held in arms. Both complied as they swirled through the floor for a couple of songs before their parents came in.

"Okay, sweethearts, it's time to prepare for bed" Glimmer chanted with a sweet but commanding tone.

"But mom!"

"No buts" Bow interjected with a smirk "We know it's your birthday, so we'll let you stay a little bit later to play with your gifts in your room, so go and put your 'jamies on"

"You heard the king" Catra messed up Saber's hair "we'll see you in the morning"

"Goodnight, Horde Scum"

"Arrow Saber of Bright Moon!" Bow scolded ushering him towards the hall as the boy snickered "I'm so sorry Catra, he picked it up from my brother Blade, he and his wife Cynthia came last week to babysit and my brother has always had such a sharp tongue..." he shrugged apologetically.

Catra eyed Glimmer as the Queen smiled mischievously "Sure, can't imagine anyone else he could learn that from" Catra said dripping sarcasm.

"Now, young lady, off you go as well" Bow tapped Angella's back getting her to run along, but the little girl kept on looking back.

***

"Hey, I'm going to catch up with Swift Wind for a little bit if that's okay" Adora pointed at the door "I won't take long, I promise"

Catra smiled at the excitement in her face "Go meet your magical horse. I'll be waiting"

"Thanks!" she rushed outside running down the halls.

Catra smirked to herself as she turned around and inspected the room. That had been the same room she and Adora had shared for several years since her first arrival to Bright Moon. Many special memories had been made inside those four walls and now it felt foreign. Like something pulled out from a washed over dream or a faint memory. Had they really been gone so long for Bright Moon to feel less familiar?

She reached the balcony sitting at the edge to gaze at the outside. It was one of her most rooted habits; she liked to contemplate the outside whenever she couldn't figure out her inside. Gazing at the stars she could actually name them, she had visited dozens of the ones in her eyesight. She thought she knew her place in the universe, but maybe there was something else out there that she wasn't grasping.

She sighed leaning back against the wall. The silence was so deafening she almost jumped into a fighting stance when she heard footsteps approach her. She looked back ready to face the intruder when she found a pair of big innocent eyes that gazed at her cautiously, more like…compassionately.

"Little Sparkle?" Catra called as the tiny princess made her way to her. Catra offered a reassuring smile, trying to show she wasn't mad about the intrusion "What are you doing here, kiddo? Shouldn't you be asleep?" she extended her arm for the girl to take and climb to her lap once more.

Angella took out the same device Catra had given her that morning as her present and found an image of herself moments prior gazing at the stars.

"You were sad" she explained.

Catra's ears folded back "Oh, no, hey- it's okay. I was deep in thought, but I'm not sad" she assured wrapping her arms around her belly.

"You were looking at the sky" she pointed at the dark blue horizon "You miss it?"

Catra exhaled "A little but…I think I miss being here more"

Angella turned around sloppily just to splay into Catra's middle wrapping her in a hug "I've missed you too"

Catra felt a frail smile tug at her lips "Yeah, I've really missed you and your brother a lot. Same as your mom and dad and all our friends" she rubbed her back gently "We've been gone for a long time, haven't we?" there was only a nod to respond "I'm sorry" Catra pressed a kiss to her head "I don't want you to feel sad either, Little Sparkle" she snuggled her, her purring becoming present as a self-comfort, helping the girl ease too as she soon fell asleep on her arms. Catra dared not to move seeing how peaceful the princess was and yearning to hold on to that moment.

Of course, not long after a knock called at the door "Catra?"

"Hey Sparkles" she spoke on a soft tone trying not to disturb the kid.

"Hi, um-have you seen Angie? She was supposed to be on her room but only Sabre is there sleeping, I thought I'd ask you"

Catra chuckled gently "Yeah, she's here" she assured "she's sleeping right now so I won't be able to open the door this time" she added "If you want to do the honors, you can walk in or puff inside" she offered, but Glimmer didn't do any of them, instead Catra heard a weight being pushed against the wooden frame as the Queen leaned her back into it.

"Actually, if it's okay, I want to stay like this for a moment"

That caught Catra's attention "Of course" she was quick to say before moving one of Angella's rebellious locks out of the way "Is something wrong?"

A subtle giggle was heard from the other side "Hah, no. Everything is fine, really. I just…I've missed these? Is that such a weird thing to admit?" she asked "I know it all started because I was a prisoner and then it just became sort of a supportive routine we did for one another but…I don't know…it's ours, you know?" she mumbled, her voice longing "It's been so long since I've talked to you through a closed door, I guess…I guess I didn't realized that I still needed you that much in my life. It's been lonely in that regard"

Her words sank deep into Catra's heart with a sting she hadn't seen coming. Glimmer spoke thoughtfully and in such a moving and honest way and it all just made the pang feel all the more present. "I'm…I didn't mean to make you feel that way"

"Oh, no, no" Glimmer intervened apologetically "That wasn't meant to be a jab" she rushed to clarify "All I mean is…it's hard to be away from family, that's all"

Catra breathed in, unsure if tears had slipped past her "I know that wasn't a complain, I just…I'm sorry I haven't been around…I assumed that if we were close though a closed door then the distance of space wouldn't harm much but…but I felt it too" she

admitted "I've felt lonely too,I…I can talk to you in a way I can't with anyone else. Not with Bow, or Scorpia, not even Adora, it's… it's you, I don't know why but…it's easy, it's…familiar"

The silence stretched for a moment too long leaving only the sound of silent teardrops reaching the ground before the flash of light contrasted the darkness of the room.

Glimmer walked towards her gazing lovingly at how Catra was cradling her daughter. She gently caressed Angella's curls before leaning in to kiss Catra's head.

"You can always talk to me, Catra" she assured "And I'll always be happy to hear you, just as I know you'd do the same for me" she looked into her eyes making sure her words were being heard "And know that no matter the time that has passed or the distance dividing us, you still have a home here with us. Those doors are always open, you don't have to feel like a stranger knocking to be let in, you belong now just as much as you did back when you moved in after saving Etheria" she took a set, briefly gazing down "When I see you and Adora here, I don't see you as visitors or guests, I just see you both as being back home. And that's the only thing that matters to me, that you keep coming back, even if it's just a week at a time, you still take the time and effort to come back to us and whenever I hear all the stories of how much danger you are on, my only relief is that you are alive and well under our roof, a place in which I can protect you both, even if just for a short while" she reached for her hand "That's what is important to me. So you can stop feeling guilt over accomplishing a mission Bow and I were also a part of" she said in a gentle tone "You told me once my first loyalty had to be with myself. I think it's time that applies for you too. It's time you also ask yourself, What do you want, Catra?"

The feline woman swallowed the knot in her throat, sometimes it amazed her how much the other woman could read into her, even when words were not coming out of her mouth. Catra could only nod as a response as she sniffed discreetly, but Glimmer had no trouble in wiping away one of her tears.

"I should really let you rest, now" the Queen added in fainter voice taking her child in arms "We'll see you at breakfast, okay?" she turned around ready to teleport when she felt a tug in her cape.

"Thank you" Catra said with a raspy voice "for…for giving us a home to come back to"

"You'll always have us" she assured smiling softly taking a step back, moving her mane back to lay a kiss on her forehead "see you in the morning, Catra" she tilted her head just before disappearing "I love you"

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Adora opened the doors of their room just a little before midnight.

"Sorry, sorry, I know I'm late, Swift Wind and I went for a flight and we lost track of time" Adora began to explain in a ramble, she had some twigs in her hair and mud on her face, but she looked so exhilarated. So of course it took her a moment to notice that her wife had her back turned and was a bit distraught to be caught in the middle of changing her bandages.

"Don't worry, love" Catra said buttoning up her blouse "It sounds like you two had a lot of fun"

"We did" she nodded approaching but Catra shrugged her shoulders hiding away "Let me see" Adora asked softly against her ear, making it twitch.

"It's nothing" she assured "I pulled one of the stitches at the party, I was just cleaning it up" she admitted.

"You should have let me patch you up at Darla" Adora reproached lightly.

"That creature fed from magic, I was not about to ask you to go She-Ra mode just to close a little wound" Catra replied.

"Well, we are far away from it now, so let me take a look?" she turned her around driving to her arms.

Catra gave in relaxing her shoulders "Okay"

"Thanks" she kissed her nose "lay in bed, alright?"

Catra did so facing up as Adora pronounced the five words that turned her into her alter ego. After so many years, Catra still felt her breath hitch at the sight.

She-Ra walked up to her climbing on top of the bed, laying a leg on either side of her wife.

"Does it hurt?" Adora asked un-tucking the red shirt.

"Stings a bit" she said, eyes fixed in the glowing figure.

"Well, we better fix that" she said unbuttoning the blouse pushing it to the side to expose her torso as a scarlet line ran from the side of her fifth rib down to her bellybutton. Adora examined it. It was not a life threatening scar, but it still made Adora feel sick at the thought that she couldn't protect her "I'll be faster next time" she ran her fingers ghostly over the wound.

"Let's not have a next time" Catra cupped her cheek "I'm okay, you were there, you had my back"

"If I had been able to transform it wouldn't have come down to this"

"Hey, She-Ra is nothing without you, not the other way around" Catra pointed out "This is why I don't like you seeing the scars" she mumbled "you are always so severe on yourself. I was the one that was sloppy" her ears bend down "I couldn't jump on time because I hadn't caught my breath, I was way more tired than I

realized and I should have told you that before charging into battle. I just wanted to wrap it up so we could come home"

Adora's features turned gentler at the admission "Me too" she mumbled leaning her forehead against hers "I guess we were both a bit over our heads trying to rush such a fight"

Catra chuckled curtly, her side sore "Yes, what a pair"

Adora smiled softly, she was not going to point out the pain her wife was in, Catra much rather have her ego unharmed "Well, I couldn't do anything then, but I can right now" she placed a hand over the wound looking at heterochromatic eyes "deep breath" she instructed, she knew that most scars and scratches would heal painlessly, but something this deep and not so recent was sure to leave a sting and Catra was no stranger to the after effects. After inhaling calmly to brace for it, Adora quietly mumbled her mantra and a beam of light emanated through her hand. Just as a groan was about to scape Catra's mouth, Adora captured her lips into her own distracting her form the sensation, allowing one of Catra's canines to softly sink into her lower lip and chew on it for a moment before tilting her chin deepening the kiss. Soon Catra arched her back when the last trace of magic ran through her body patching her up, so much time later and she still couldn't get used to the sensation of electricity running through, luckily as soon as it was there, it vanished. A relieved sigh swirled in her insides as she fell back into the mattress but Adora wasn't done kissing her, instead running down her neck nibbling there. It had been so long since they had been in their home, in their room, in their bed.

Catra ran her fingers on She-Ra's long hair indulging into the feeling, something in the back of her head telling her to cherish it, because she was never sure when they could have moments like this again, memories that she could hold on to. But that wasn't what she wanted, she didn't want to collect moments to look back to in hopes of repeating in the future after months in space, she wanted days like this to build her life, not to be the exception.

"Adora?" Catra exhaled breathlessly.

"Yeah?" she kissed her jaw to then steal away another taste of her mouth.

"I want to stay in Etheria like you said" she panted looking at those impossibly clear blue eyes that inspected her with surprise and awe, deep down perhaps asking why she had a change of heart and Catra had the resolve to answer that before hearing the question "I want a kitten"

"A kitten? Our kitten?!" Adora asked, her voice a pitch higher.

"Yeah, our kitten. Our baby" she wrapped her arms around her neck "what do you think?"

Adora sank into her arms hugging her tightly, kissing her repeatedly "Let's have a kitten!"

Chapter End Notes

Okay! List of shout-outs! (from both and AO3 users that commented)

First, I forgot to say that the idea of the bets on the genders and that Catra should collect her earnings was suggested by yurippe15 ! Thanks!

Now, for the names! I tried to use as many ideas as possible (I was so surprised to see so many of you joined in! Thank you!), So that's why I tried to add the names here and there even if they weren't directly the ones of the kiddos, so here goes!

The nickname Little Sparkle goes as a shoutout to Lulu

Bow's brother being called Blade goes to Jkitty_trashcrash

and his wife Cynthia is for DanielCorcoran

Angella is thanks to Dragonfox194, yurippe15 and (nickname Angie) marszbar

Arrow was suggested by both CalvinFujii and yurippe15

And Saber was Dragonfox194 's idea!

Thank you so much for chiming in and throwing your names into the goblet of fire! If I missed someone I'm really sorry! You can let me know!

And thank you for all the amazing comments and all the support!

See you next time!

Process and adjustments

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"We want to stay in Etheria" Adora said bluntly at the breakfast table, if she had hold in a second longer she would have burst "For good"

Bow was left with his mouth wide open half way through eating a piece of toast as Glimmer overflown a cup of tea she was serving.

"You staying?!" Saber slammed his hands in the table sending the silverware flying, his eyes showing sparkles in them.

"Yes" both women intertwined their fingers "we are done with traveling the universe, we've made enough connections for others to help us, our presence isn't necessary, not really, the movement can go on without us, but our lives can't stay on standby"

"Are you sure? I mean-" Glimmer stammered "you are really coming back?" in her eyes ringed hope and illusion.

"We are"

"Best Friend Squad!" Bow jumped up knocking several things over as he rushed to hug them. His kids not far behind as Glimmer slowly allowed the reality to sink in. Her eyes crossed those heterochromatic ones of Catra as they hugged each other. And the feline woman nodded once, solemnly, determined. This is what she wanted.

And Glimmer hugged them as well, just as tightly as she had done the first time they flew outer space without them, their first goodbye. And now, the bittersweet taste would never have to be relived.

"We have to tell the alliance!" Bow exclaimed "We'll call in a meeting, they are all still close by!"

"I'll call the meeting dad!" Saber raised his hand.

"Me too!" Angella seconded.

"Okay, go, tell the messenger to send word to the princess to come, but no pranks this time"

Both gave toothy smiles while shrugging "Yes, dad"

"Off you go!"

Both headed for the door before little Angie turned around and hugged Catra's legs for a brief moment before running to catch up with her brother. The action alone almost made Catra's eyes tear up.

Adora noticed this and provided a soft peck on her temple mumbling something soothing against her ear.

"This is amazing!" Bow continued exhilarated "what made you change your mind?" he sat down again as they resumed breakfast with little success.

"Actually" Adora tilted her head nervously "we have other news to share"

"What is it?"

Adora looked back at Catra, it felt like that should be her announcement to make. Catra held her hand nodding.

"We had considerate this for a long time and…we think it's time" Catra began breathing in, somehow saying this out loud to their closest friend made this all the more real "We want to have a kitten"

The chaotic silence was drowned down by exclamations and cheers.

"You want kids?!" Bow asked beyond himself.

"You plan having a baby?!" Glimmer beamed ecstatic.

"Did you both really understand that on the first try?" Adora asked chuckling at the reminisce of the first time Catra used the term 'kitten'.

Catra chuckled at her wife's expression before focusing on the other two "Yes, we talked about it after getting married, but figured the time was off, but right now…"

"Right now feels like the perfect time" Adora completed wrapping an arm around her shoulders.

"Oh boy!" Bow's face was so thrilled and innocent, he was melting with happiness, showing all his emotions as he always did "Now wait until the other princesses hear about this!" he threw his fist to the air "Wait until the whole kingdom hears about it!"

And in the middle of the laughter a shocked expression crossed Glimmer's face, as the realization of something forgotten once again made itself present in her train of thought, an unwanted passenger she had pushed aside for far too long. But as soon as the expression was showing, she schooled her face to go back into a smile, a slightly forced one… and if someone did notice that, was of course...

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Adora and Catra began to unpack their belongings after moving them back in from Darla with a lot of help from Glimmer's teleportation and her very eager kids that couldn't wait to help them settle in, because to their eyes, this was the first time they would stay on the castle with them. It was not as much a 'welcome back' party as it was a 'welcome in' one.

"We can have a picnic" Arrow said jumping up and down grabbing into Adora's hand "And then we can got to the woods, we can show you around"

Both women couldn't help a laugh "Would you?"

"Yes! It's very dangerous, we'll show you so you don't get lost"

"That would be great, little Saber" Catra boop his nose.

"We can have slumber parties!" Angella chimed in tugging at Adora's hand "Do you like those?"

"Like them? We love them" she carried the girl looking back at Catra in complicity making her blush.

"You can stay in our room tonight" Angella continued unaware of their looks "since yours is a mess"

"Not hat yours is any cleaner" Glimmer's voice cut through the conversation as she let down the last box "That's it, you are officially settled in"

The twins threw their arms up shouting in excitement "We live together now!"

"So fun!"

"Oh, believe me, before these two showed up into our lives, this was a relatively calm place, so rest assure, they'll be quite the partners in crime" Glimmer added with a hearted chuckle "Why don't you go find your dad, see when the princesses are coming?" she asked softly, she had a certain urgency in her tone while still keeping it soft.

"Okay mom!" they ran snickering, pushing one another.

"They are not going to let you have a moment to yourselves now" Glimmer smirked watching them go.

"We have some time to make up for, so we'll be good" Adora wrapped an arm around Catra.

"Yeah" Glimmer huffed dryly avoiding their eyes; she seemed oddly off "Um…I need to talk to you"

"Is everything alright, Sparkles?"

"Yeah, yeah, it's just…" she exhaled "I know you just came back, but I need you to make the announcement to the emissaries and delegates about your plans of staying in Etheria. They'll arrive in half an hour"

"Ow" Adora relaxed "yeah, sure, makes sense"

"Thanks" Glimmer held a tight smile, air stuck in her chest, words caught up on her throat.

"Sparkles?" Catra raised a brow; the former princess seemed so uncomfortable "Is there something else…?"

Glimmer clenched her jaw "I…I need a favor and it's going to sound incredibly contradictory and perhaps rude but…can you please not mention your plans on having a baby?"

Both were aback by the request and Glimmer seemed so miserable on asking it.

"I-I don't understand, it's something wrong?"

"No, not wrong it's just…it's a bit complicated, I can't risk the emissaries from outer space to know that She-Ra-"

"Is having a kid with me?" Catra cut in, her words ringing with hurt.

"No!" Glimmer cut in outraged "Of course not, it's not that" she said firmly noticing the wounded look in Catra's heterochromatic eyes "It's nothing to do with that" she wasn't able to hold her gaze, there was something else in there, a secret, a lie, fear? "I

just don't want them calling your child an illegitimate one since they don't know about the wedding. They have been breathing down our necks on that regard" she said bitterly "and I'll explain further, Bow and I will, right after we talk to the emissaries" she promised but her stance still felt awkward "It's just to protect the interest of Bright Moon" she said.

"Okay" Adora nodded aware of Glimmer's out of character nervousness "We'll see you at the meeting, just give us a moment to change"

"Right" Glimmer nodded starting to close the doors briefly gazing at them, her eyes locked on those of Catra as she shut it close. The door had never been a problem among them, but it usually was the start of a conversation, not the end of the same.

Adora could feel how tense Catra was "Hey" she mumbled into her ear wrapping her arms around her waist "You okay?"

"Yeah" she rolled her shoulders back pushing her lips to the side "Do you think you could go without me?" she asked with faint hope.

"Catra" Adora complained pouting against her shoulder "I need you there with me" she pressed a kiss into her collarbone "I want you by my side" there was certain fragility into the admission.

"Those delegates hate my guts" Catra mumbled hugging closer. It was sad to admit, but Catra was used to people not liking her, but those men truly knew where it hurt and they had no trouble in kicking when she was down.

"Of course they do, you won me over" Adora teased lightly stealing away a peck "you have mighty She-Ra wrapped around your finger" she smirked "they are just jealous"

Catra actually chuckled "Lucky me" she kissed her back. As long as Adora had her back, come what may.

***

Glimmer always dreaded these meetings on the war room because she knew most of the emissaries were just there trying to win her favor to have She-Ra on their side and that particular day it scared her. Especially since Adora and Catra were present to inform that they would discontinue the visits to other systems.

Bow was quietly sitting at her side, reaching for her hand under the table giving a reassuring smile, nothing could ever make his confidence falter and right now, all Glimmer needed was a bit of that.

"And on that account" Adora concluded explaining her intricate red of support expanded through the cosmos "Is that we'll stay here in Etheria, the rebellion doesn't need us to keep commanding in person"

Their faces were serious as the information sink in "Is there any way we could dissuade you of this decision?"

"I'm afraid not" Adora answered with a smile.

"But as you know, a leader leads by example" a man cut in "What kind of message are you sending by leaving the others to their own devices?"

"The message that I trust them to accomplish the restoration of magic, that I think they are capable of making a difference" she responded, her brow starting to furrow. She began to remember one of the few advantages going deep into space had, not dealing with them.

"She-Ra" he stood up "As the strongest force in the universe you still have responsibility to uphold" Catra hated the way Adora's face twisted, because she could read guilt and remorse in her eyes and Adora didn't deserve to be manipulated like that, not again and certainly not by him.

"A responsibility we've diligently followed through since the defeat of the Horde" Catra cut in "And as far as I'm concerned, we've

accomplished it, because now everyone is free and magic expands well beyond the farthest galaxies we've visited"

"This meeting was merely a formality to inform you about the status of the situation, not to negotiate it" Glimmer intervened speaking up for the first time in the session "So if that is all" she stood up ready to conclude, but surely it wouldn't be that easy.

"So now that you are staying, can we assume you'll pick a suitor?"

"Excuse me?" Adora physically recoiled at the question, her face showing revulsion.

"An alliance between planets could prove to be most beneficial" he said.

Adora side glanced at her friends trying to figure out why this topic would be addressed, she had nothing but the title of She-Ra, no real power or influence beyond that, and she had made her intentions clear before, if she was to choose, she would pick Catra every time, indeed she already had.

"I'm already with someone" she said firmly "Someone who is present right in front of you, if you would do the kindness to even acknowledge her"

"The Horde soldier?" someone mused out loud. Catra could feel her claws digging on her own palms as she clenched her fists at the label, no matter how much time would pass, that was a shadow she couldn't outrun.

"I was named Force Captain once as well, I don't carry the title with any pride either, but I won't deny what's on my past as she hasn't either. We were both at the service of Hordak at a time" Adora spoke firmly "And regardless, the decision of who I spend my life with is exclusively my own"

"But to choose someone of her-"

"Careful with what words you are about to say next" Bow cut in with a severe tone, gazing sternly "We won't tolerate this disrespect"

The man backtracked offering a well-rehearsed smile "All I wish to understand is what kind of advantage marring into the same land can offer?"

"Same land?" Adora repeated puzzled "I don't have any power over any land. And contrary to Catra, I'm a First One, my world was destroyed" she stated with a confused frown as Bow and Glimmer exchanged looks, knowing the time to speak up had passed, now it was just an attempt to clarify.

"Adora, Catra" Bow called making them turn in their direction "Glimmer and I made some amends into the state of this kingdom" he began knowing that such an explanation didn't made sense yet, so Glimmer continued.

"When we named you the guardians of our kids, we stipulated that you would advise them in order to rule the land in case they were too young to do so themselves" she said slowly, making sure to walk them through "And while discussing on the matter… we also decided to leave part of Bright Moon for both of you"

Neither seemed to recall how to breathe as they heard the news, forgetting about everyone else in the room as the monarchs kept on explaining.

"The whole princess alliance was called to witness our decree so it would be known what our will was" Bow explained "We wanted this place to be yours just as much as it was ours, so you really had a piece of home" he elaborated "King Micah bounded with magic our agreement"

"You…you did that for us?" Adora tried to fight off the tears.

"Of course, you sacrificed everything for us, what was Bright Moon if not yours as well?" Glimmer answered softly, honestly. It showed in her eyes the deep care and love she held for both. She

wanted to explain more, to say why they had waited to tell them, but the consequences of those decisions were now pressing, right in front of them. So she casted her eyes back to the committee "but by doing so, it also means that She-Ra holds power over Bright Moon, which bounds her to be a desirable ally to win over" she gritted her teeth "That's why they insist on a proposal, to join lands, form a union"

That clicked, that explained why they would try once more to arrange a wedding, because they didn't know about the one they secretly held five years ago, and because now, it wasn't same loyalties bound to the Royal Family of Bright Moon, but a sobering of the land wielding the most powerful weapon in the universe.

The two wives exchanged glances, understanding the situation on a bigger picture, many small pieces still in play.

"So you see She-Ra, deciding to marry one of the suitors from our galaxy can ensure prosperity and protection"

Adora immediately grabbed Catra's hand holding tight as she breathed in, Catra could see she was doing one of Perfuma's exercises "I will always strive to protect the weak and if your galaxy ever needs She-Ra to help, I'll rise to the occasion, but my resolve stays the same, I am with Catra, so don't hold your breath, I'm staying by her side"

Disgust ran through his face "As She-Ra you should-"

"Adora" she corrected "I am Adora" she glared intensely "and as I said before, I can choose how to live my life. In fact, I earned that right and Mara made the ultimate sacrifice to ensure I could, so this meeting is over" Catra felt her chest swell at the resolve on Adora's voice, at the recognition of her own worth.

"Let's go" she stood up still holding Catra's hand, ready to leave them behind.

"So that's it then?" a voice called "You choose to affiliate yourself with a low life that mascaraed hundreds and was at the service of

Prime just because she accommodates your past? That's who you let deceive y-"

"Don't you dare!" Glimmer yelled slamming her hands on the table as she rose up "That's her wife you are talking about!"

The silence after was deafening. The secret was finally out, slowly making it through the room.

Glimmer felt like cursing heavily at revealing the one thing she desperately tried to keep undercover, but there was so much she was willing to tolerate before stepping in. She knew the consequences of admitting to that could potentially affect her kingdom, but at that time, she could only think about protecting her friends. They had already risked so much defending her people, she owed them that and then the world.

"Wife?" a voice echoed "That's impossible"

Bow stood up as well putting a hand over her shoulder "We held a ceremony in our Kingdom, King Micah officiated, it is binding" he corroborated.

Adora proudly pulled into view the chain that hanged around her neck showing the ring in it as Catra revealed her unique piece of First One's jewelry.

"We exchanged tokens, we pledged our vows" Adora left no room for arguments "It was before there was even land to our names, and my determination stays the same. I love her, I swore my life to hers and I won't ever take another suitor, nor would I form an alliance through that bond"

"You did this behind the committee's back?" the man's voice was low and severe while his anger started to buildup "We kept peaceful terms with your land in hopes of one day having a union all the while your champion was already taken?!" he spitted "this is treason!"

"We never made promises, nor was it our place to decide over their life" Bow said curtly.

"You lied!" he continued "consider this truce ov-"

"Listen to me" Adora's voice cut through the room as her sword could slice through metal "You all know well what a valuable ally She-Ra could be, but let me assure you, you don't want to find out how formidable of an enemy she has proven to be" her steely blue eyes were as sharp as daggers "You have said I'm the strongest force in the universe, then let's make this clear, I am unopposed. Now I don't mean to make threats as I am sure you don't want to either, because the moment we leave this room it's your choice is you want to see us as friends or foes and I'll tell you, it's the same to me. I'm done carrying about your opinion, I have a life to live"

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The moments that followed after they left the war room were unclear and hectic. Catra wasn't even sure at what point she made it back into their room. Her head was spinning and her heart was hammering. The only thing that brought her back to reality was when she heard a knock on the door and a pleading voice calling her name.

"Catra?"

It took her a moment to reconnect her thoughts "Sparkles?"

"Catra, listen, I'm sorry" she began earnestly, urgently "About what they said and about what I didn't regarding this whole arrangement and-"

"I need a moment" Catra cut her off rubbing her own face, she could hear Glimmer's shuffling dubiously on the other side "Stay" Catra both asked and offered "Just, let me take it in"

Glimmer breathed in and out calming herself "Okay" she turned around sitting, hugging her knees. They stood like that for what

felt like an eternity as the whole scene replayed in their heads.

"Why did…Why didn't you told us about the arrangement? Leaving us part of Bright Moon? That sounds way too important to skip your mind" Catra asked, perhaps a bit of an accusation in there.

Glimmer exhaled resting the back of her head against the door, gazing at the roof "Bow and I considered afterwards the possibility that you might find a planet you wanted to settle in, a place that wasn't Etheria and we figured that if we told you the power you had over Bright Moon that we might force you take up on our offer, we wanted the decision to be yours but with the guarantee that if you claimed it, part of this kingdom would be yours" she explained "The truth is, you can still refuse it, the magic will only be sealed if it's a willing agreement by both sides" she concluded waiting a beat.

A dry chuckle cut thought with irony flavoring into it "You know? I visited hundreds of places and I still couldn't feel like I belonged in any" she said distantly, looking back perhaps "That's the part I hated most about the travels, that I couldn't fit in… and then we got back to the party and suddenly everyone was gathering around us, talking, laughing and it- it felt like such a relief that… that perhaps this once I wasn't the problem" she sighed heavily "And the first thing I hear as we settle back in is that a whole galaxy was harassing you to present proposal to Adora and you didn't thought to tell us?!" she bite, her tone dangerously close to losing composure as she would when she was younger.

"Why would I want you to know that?" Glimmer retorted with equal stubbornness "Adora was already your wife, they weren't about to change that and I was not letting them corner us into accepting one of their suitors, playing defense was our best bet" she stated firmly "Besides you were light-years away. What was I supposed to say? 'Can you please drop everything you are doing and settle a dispute?' What were you going to do?" she groaned in frustration.

"Help you! Obviously!" Catra yelled back "We would have turned the ship and head back! Get them to leave you and Bow alone!"

"You were already in over your heads with the travels, that was more important"

"Damn it Sparkles! You are more important to us!" she finally snapped "You leave us literally a home and you think we wouldn't have intervened sooner if you had asked us to?!" she felt her eyes dripping as she violently pushed the tears away "That's what hurts the most" she admitted through gritted teeth "Don't you see I would do anything for you?" her voice cracked "you named us your kids' guardians, you planned my wedding in a day, gave me a ring for Adora because you knew I had nothing from my past and covered the truth about our marriage for years at the expense of those men bulling you so we wouldn't have to hear about it and you didn't thought to seek our help?" she felt the tears drenching her shirt "If I had known half the stuff I found out today I would have come back in a moment's notice" she sniffed, a hand pressed against her eyes as she tried to regain some serenity, but she still felt the white flash spark in the room as she uncovered and saw Glimmer knelt before her.

"No" Catra turned her face, she was definitely not ready to be seen, but Glimmer cupped her cheek looking at those mismatched eyes drowned in tears.

"Of course I know you would have done anything for me" She replied, her voice faint, hearted and broken "that's why I couldn't ask you to"

Catra exhaled sharply, frustrated, but before she could reply, Glimmer held her shoulders tight, making sure her words would be heard.

"Tell me that you wouldn't have at least consider entertaining the thought of a union of lands for the sake of Etheria" she deadpanned "tell me you wouldn't have even think of it and I'll back down right now" she dared finding Catra's eyes lost "Adora

and you are so willing to sacrifice everything that I feared you might even go as far as to agree on an arrangement of a sort between the lands" she stated "And I wouldn't risk it" she shook her head determined "Your happiness was my priority" she released her shoulders.

"I know" Catra covered her face "That's what angers me and makes me love you all the more" she uncovered her face "But we didn't yield to their plans, Glimmer" she countered "Adora stood up to them" she added softening her tone "You don't need to protect us as much as you think" she said gently averting her eyes the moment after sighing "We are so painfully similar when it comes to making decisions or asking for help, we rather do everything ourselves because we feel like there's something to prove to someone, to everyone" she ran a hand down her mane "But I thought we didn't have to play that charade with each other" her tone betrayed her as sadness dripped through "You can talk to me- to us. We would have understood, we could have helped, you didn't have to leave us at the sidelines…I don't…I don't want more pain on your life on my account, I…I've already done enough" her ears bended down "You can trust me…" she finally said what she had been afraid to express, an insecurity that still haunt her deep in her core.

Glimmer flinched at those words "Catra-" she felt the air being knocked out of her lungs as she tried to find her eyes "I'm sorry" she threw her arms around her hugging tight "I trust you, of course I do, more than you'll ever know" she said earnestly hiding deeper into her shoulder, unable to find the way to say it so she admitted it to herself first as she sighed brokenly"As much as we'd like to believe otherwise, time and distance have changed things" she mumbled "and I realize we both tried so hard to spare the suffering to the other in our own way that...that we ended up hurting..." she felt Catra's body stiff and shrug, she could tell her words had hit close to home "that doesn't mean we are any less close, it's just an adjustment" she stroke her back gently "I know you love me just the same, that you reacted because you worried and I - I should have told you, both of you, everything...I thought I was keeping you safe" she exhaled "I didn't mean to shut you

out of my life, on the contrary" she admitted "I was trying so hard to keep you in that I...I pushed you away in the end" she felt her shoulders drop exhausted while still holding her tight "I love you, Catra and I just got you back" she felt tears dripping "...I don't want to-"

"You are not" Catra held her back "you are never losing me" she said heartedly and solemnly closing her eyes as she cuddled tightly against her, taking a moment to breath in "All Adora and I ever did was fight, if she couldn't get rid of me then you have no chances" she added jokingly feeling Glimmer relax "I'm…I'm sorry too…" the feline woman mumbled. It was still hard to articulate some feelings, to talk through some issues and Glimmer could see her struggle to find the words "I'm not mad at you or Bow, nor at the whole situation" she said gently "I'm…I'm scared" she lost her voice at the end.

Glimmer let go for an instant trying to see her face much to Catra's dismay as she wiped the tears "Why?"

"I've…I've never had…so much" she expressed "it's so easy to risk everything when you have nothing and now…I have so much to lose" she shrugged feeling small, as vulnerable as when she was a kitten herself.

"But it's worth the risk" Glimmer mumbled "having people, having dreams, having hope... it's better to gamble on the opportunity to live and loose than lose the opportunity of living"

A small smile tugged at Catra's lips at her words as she ran them thought her heart, they ringed right, reassuringly in a way, endearing in others and that only lead to show how Glimmer had grown so much in that time. Perhaps things weren't exactly as they used to five years ago, but that only proved how much their relationship could still blossom, how much later the sparkly princess still meant a lot to her.

"Thanks" Catra mumbled, in her blue and golden eyes there were so many memories and recollections of everything she was

thanking for and while words weren't enough, she could only hope Glimmer could see just how much she appreciate them. And she did.

"Welcome" the Queen corresponded being swiftly embraced into a comforting gesture. The action took her by surprise, but soon she melted into her arms as they used to "Can we stay like this for a moment?" Glimmer asked, cuddling into her chest, her voice showing how tired she really felt, how drained she was from all that involved being a ruler.

Catra nodded resting her chin upon the Queen's head as both eased up; her soft purring took over the silence. Glimmer didn't realize how much she missed it until she heard it once more, until she felt the soft vibration and familiar warmth luring her into sleep. Reality would have to wait a tad longer, because right now she finally had a piece of her home back.

Chapter End Notes

> This was surprisingly a tough chapter to write! I needed Adora to stand tall for herself, resolve that last issue about the secret marriage and show that Glimmer and Catra had been apart for a long while, so some adjustments were sure to be expected.
> We'll go back to kitten talk next chapter! n.n
> Thanks for your support!

Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

After their first night officially back Adora and Catra waked up in a pool of stuffed animals and tangled under many covers as the twins laid in the middle of them taking more than half of the bed.

Adora opened her eyes to meet those of Catra lazily focusing on her.

"Morning, love" she mumbled.

"Hey, Adora" she stretched a bit, unable to fully do her usual routine as she didn't want to disturb the kids "Should we sneak away?"

"Do you think we'll be able to without waking them?" she smirked endearingly.

"I know I could" Catra replied smugly "Good luck to you"

Adora actually stuck her tongue out, seemed like Catra's bad habits of 'indecorum' as Frosta once put it, could rub on her.

Catra did her best to giggle quietly before smiling softly at her "I could actually stay like this for a moment" she admitted hugging Angella closer "when was the last time we didn't have to get up for a mission debrief or prepare for a battle?" she caressed the young princess' bright hair.

Adora smiled sweetly at how tenderly she held the girl "True" she whispered before locking eyes "Are you sure about the decision we made?" she inquired softly.

Catra focused her attention on her, trying to read into every gesture to see if there was doubt or concern but there was only

hope and joy, so she had no trouble in smiling back "I am" she assured "We talked about well into the morning"

"While we were incredibly worn out"

"Yesterday was not the first time we discussed it" Catra pointed out.

"I just want to make sure" she explained, eagerness into her tone.

Catra huffed smiling softly "My resolve stays the same" she nodded "Yours?" she inquired truly considering if she might have changed her mind, but Adora's crescent smile and twinkling eyes erased all doubt.

"Yes" she snickered happily.

"Then it's decided" she leaned in as best as she could while Adora did her part to meet halfway into a kiss.

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The princesses gathered for the meeting they had been called to the day prior. They had made it to the kingdom after the short notice with no such thing as an explanation while Adora and Catra were arriving gallantly late, already hearing all their voices echoing down the hall as they sprinted, racing each other as they did back when they were cadets.

"How can we be last if we literally live here?" Adora asked amused, the fact that she could already say 'live here' made her heart skip with excitement.

"It's part of our charm, making grand entrances" Catra smirked back as they slowed down trying to catch their breath before opening the door. As Catra's hand was reaching the handle, Adora

grabbed her shoulder turning her around to plant a messy kiss on her lips "We are doing this" her eyes sparkled with the promise of a whole new future in front of them.

"Together" she corresponded heartedly, of all the things in the world, the one she wanted the most was to have a family with the love of her life.

"Okay then" she nodded, ready to join the others.

As soon as they stepped into the room, Scorpia had already wrapped Catra into a tight hug, lifting her easily off the ground "Wildcat! I didn't thought I would be able to see you again so soon! Let alone two times in less than two days"

Catra chuckled breathlessly, she couldn't wait to tell her the good news then.

Glimmer smirked at the sight "Now that the sleepyheads have arrived and we are all here, we shall commence" she called order in the room with a smile on her face.

"Ready?" Adora grabbed her wife's arm as they sat down.

Catra smiled "Yes" she snugged closer to her.

"What it's so pressing that you had to call us all back?" Spinella asked with a worrisome look on her eyes "Did something happened?"

"We'll let them do the honors" Bow looked at the couple, all eyes on them.

"Well, after spending the day with all of your at the party and seeing how much things have changed, Catra and I have decided that…we are staying" she said confidently "no more outer space for us"

The shock washed over for the shortest moment before every face lit up, but one princess beat them to it "Wildcat!" Scorpia

suffocated the feline in a hearted embrace "You are coming back?!"

"Does that mean I can keep Darla?" Entrapta interfered.

"So you are not leaving again?" other voices chimed in and soon the room was filled with a chaotic yet eager energy. The two travelers hadn't realized just how much their presence truly meant to them, because in their eyes all they could see was glee and joy to have them stay.

Bow sighed wistfully giving a side hug to his wife "We are finally all back together now" he mused "they look so happy"

"Yeah" Glimmer mumbled gazing at the scene, after the terrible childhood stories Adora and Catra told so casually, she was only glad they could have people that genuinely care for them.

"And there's also something else" they manage to choke out from under all the embraces

"We want a kitten, that's also a reason we want to be in Etheria. Have a place to raise our baby"

"Oh! The cat is out of the bag!" Perfuma clasped her hands excitedly as Mermista rolled her eyes at the pun.

"You'll be moms?!" Scorpia gasped "Do I get to be an aunt?!"

Catra smiled warmly at her, how she managed to keep such a friend was beyond her "Of course, who else would keep them in the right track?"

"I want to be an aunt too!" Frosta raised her hand "you guys get candy from Angella and Saber, I want in"

Adora giggled "All of you get to be aunts, naturally"

"I still can't picture how your kid will be like" Netossa smirked teasingly "The ears are a must, right?" she pointed at Catra's own.

"She'll be such an adorable baby" Spinella complimented.

"She?" Entrapta interrupted "there's not even a fetus yet, we shouldn't jump to conclusions"

"Another bet!" Frosta jumped to say.

"Arrgh" Mermista groaned "Not again, we already lost once and that wasn't even her own kid, we have like, cero chance" she deadpanned.

"I bet girl!" Scorpia raised her pincer.

"Boy!" Perfuma joined in.

"Triplets!" Frosta raised the stakes while they shared a laugh out of it.

"And have you decided?" Spinella added gently "who will carry?"

They exchanged glances, a mutual understanding, a decision they had already agreed on.

"We talked about it last night, actually"

"You guys didn't lost time" Netossa commented with a bit of surprise in her tone as she saw how serious they were about the matter.

"So, who will it be?" Scorpia asked in anticipation.

Bow and Glimmer too were attentive at the response.

After a deep breath the answer left her lips "I will" Adora announced proudly.

The surprised was both unexpected for some and obvious for others.

"Miss, 'I can take on a whole army on my own' is going to stand down from the battlefield?" Netossa smirked and the faintest trait

of awkwardness mixed with self-doubt swam through Adora's eyes at the harmless teasing.

Catra wrapped an arm around her wife "She's stepping into another battlefield altogether"

Adora relaxed under her arm cuddling there "Yeah, I have something else worth fighting for"

"Congratulations" Perfuma hugged the couple "not only do we get you back, but you'll bring us the joy of a baby!"

Soon the meeting that was meant to be a brief surprise turned into lunch as all the princesses talked, made plans, placed bets and finally let their hair down to enjoy the day, their new found normality.

***

After all the princesses had head back home, promising to visit again soon, Adora excused herself saying she needed to tell Swift Wind too, there was something different in her eyes while making the petition to disappear for a bit, but Catra wasn't about to question her relationship with the magical horse as Adora never opposed to Melog.

"Have fun" she kissed her goodbye feeling Adora lean in more enthusiastically than the feline had expected.

"See you later" she caressed behind her ear making a quick exit towards the woods.

Catra smiled to herself "Dork" she mumbled amused by her wife's antiques.

So once alone she walked the castle halls looking around, so much had changed and at the same time it looked the same. She ended up wondering into the garden gates where her wedding had been. The memory alone made her heart race with the same nervous excitement as it did that night.

If she closed her eyes she could replay the scene, she had committed it to memory, the faint night breeze, the music, the dance… she raised her arms and took her position gently swaying herself from one side to the other as she had done that evening. She felt her purring take over as she enjoyed the sensation.

"I didn't took you for a helpless romantic" a voice cut through as she jolted, her fur crawling up as she snapped her eyes open finding Glimmer at the door snickering.

"Sparkles!" she groaned trying to pass her red embarrassment as anger.

Glimmer unfolded her arms raising her hands as in surrender "I come unarmed, Horde Scum" she mocked walking towards with a smug smile "living in the past, are we?"

"No" she grumbled looking away "my present is worth being lived, I don't have to look back as if the best days were behind" she answered offhandedly, but her words struck Glimmer like a lightning, knowing that for a long time all Catra had was the past to look at and even those memories were usually bittersweet with Adora and the Horde in them.

"I'm…I'm glad you have so much to live for" she said honestly in a sweeter tone, without teasing, which caught Catra off guard, she had been waiting to have her bite back, but instead of their friendly bickering, Glimmer reached her shoulder and drove her hand to her waist beginning to sway.

"What-what are you doing?"

"Living in the moment, I guess. Making new memories" Glimmer answered as Catra looked away, her ears folding back in a soft

gesture, she felt comforted in a way "Seeing you both today with all the princess alliance, it felt right, like it was all coming together again"

Catra smiled a bit sheepish "I wasn't expecting them to make such a big deal out of our return, you princesses basically throw parties at every occasion"

"That's because we have a lot to celebrate" she answered back "just you wait until you give us news of the actual pregnancy" Glimmer giggled while Catra took the opportunity to swirl her around before they were face to face again "I'm glad you already took the decision" Glimmer said tapping her fingers softly at her shoulder "Can I just ask …?" she waited a beat seeing those heterochromatic eyes inspect her with curiosity "Why didn't you chose to be the one carrying?" she phrased softly noticing her surprise "I-I know it's none of my business what you discuss with Adora, it's only that…I pictured you more so than I did her and- and of course Adora will be great! I just…thought that was something you wanted?"

Catra huffed tugging a smile at her face looking rather calm, something Glimmer hadn't expected "It's okay, I don't mind the question coming from you" she took a moment slowing down "Adora and I talked about it thoroughly and it's both a rational decision and a hearted one" she explained "She-Ra is basically indestructible, she can heal all wounds on herself and others, with her, our baby faces virtually no danger. It's a big compromise on her behalf, since she promised she wouldn't put herself on the line at all while carrying, but she was completely committed" she shrugged nonchalant "You actually were a huge influence on this decision" she admitted leaving Glimmer puzzled "When the twins were going to be born, you entrusted me to make your will be followed through if there were complications during labor, so we didn't want to take those odds"

Glimmer stopped, taking a step back clasping her hands to her mouth "I'm sorry" she whispered "I'm so sorry, I didn't mean- I

shouldn't have put you through that- is that why you don't want to carry?"

Catra was aback as she saw the Queen crumble "Hey, Sparkles" she reached for her arms driving her close before she could put more distance between them "It's okay" she said soothingly.

"You don't have to-"

"I'm the one that's not ready, okay?" Catra cut her short meeting her eyes "It's-it's a step I wasn't ready to take and Adora was. It-it does have to do with what happened when your kids were born, I don't want to put anyone on that situation and also I wouldn't want to be faced with the decision of losing either my kid or my wife and Adora can take that fear away. It's not a certainty that this will be risk free but she's stronger than me in that regard and she wants to carry for us" she explained "You didn't scar me into forsaking something, it has to do with me, with my own issues of being left behind" she said firmly, making sure Glimmer wouldn't bear with a burden that wasn't hers "You are not to blame" she caressed her cheek with the back of her fingers catching runaway tears "Adora and I are happy with our decision, I'm not missing out, this is exactly the way I want to be involved and the moment I can hold my baby I promise, I'll hardly ever put them down again" she chuckled already feeling her chest swell with pride "I'm not going to be any less of a mother"

"I know" Glimmer hugged her tight resting over her chest "you are going to be one hell of a mother"

Catra's ears actually twitched at her words as a laugh escaped her lips "Careful with the language, Your Majesty"

"Shut it" she replied giggling too before exhaling and going back into soft swaying, still holding into the embrace "I mean it, though. You'll be a great mom" she said "And not because you want to outrun what Shadow Weaver did to you, or to redeem your own past through them, but because you truly care" she said gently, knowing the touchy subject she was navigating through "I

see it when you play with my kids, the way you genuinely enjoy being with them, how they reach out to you, the way they trust you… as long as your kitten has you in their lives…then there's nothing to fear. They'll love you"

Glimmer felt the other woman hug back tighter at those words. At the end, all Catra yearned for was to be accepted, to be loved and not be faced with rejection "Thank you, Glimmer" she mumbled into her hair "makes it a little bit less scary" she mocked although her words held truth in them.

"I'm here for you" she mumbled back "we all are. Just like you told me when I was on your shoes, you won't be alone, nor left behind"

Catra breathed in snuggling while purring rather loudly at those words, her tail sliding from side to side.

Glimmer felt the change and laughed sweetly and just before another exchange could be said, the door swung open revealing the small princess that raced towards them.

"Sweetie" Glimmer let go of the embrace, keeping a hand on her shoulder.

"Hey Little Sparkle" Catra smiled kneeling down to be on her level.

"Can we go for a walk into the woods with Melog?" she asked hopeful.

Catra turned to the Queen "Would that be okay?"

"Sure thing" she patted her daughter's head gently "but stay close to Aunty Cat, alright? And don't go too far from the castle"

"Promise!" she jumped to say, her rosy cheeks puffing with her huge smile.

"Very well then, off you go" she planted a kiss just for the princess to grab Catra's hand the moment after driving her to the

exit where Melog waited with an excited aura.

"Enjoy the practice hours, Catra!" Glimmer yelled from the garden as they were already strolling down the hall.

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"Look, look!" she tugged at her hand walking through a path to a very large tree that had some boards in them constructing a small structure "It's our base" Angella said proudly pointing at it.

"It is?" Catra whistled looking up "Did your dad help you build it?"

"Yeah, with all our grandpas, it was really fun" she walked to the trunk to reveal some improvised stairs "Mom doesn't know about it" she added.

Catra considered the missing safety measures "I wonder why" she mused to herself as Melog replied to the thought.

"Come" she urged.

"Lead the way Little Sparkle" she followed closely making sure to help her climb, keeping a hand hovering above her to prevent a fall but no so noticeable so the girl would think she didn't trust her skills. The princess always tried to prove to her parents that she too was a grown up.

Once on the top Catra was glad to find the structure was sound, after all she knew a thing or two about handmade installments, the skill set she learned at the Horde was both awful and incredibly useful at times.

Angella sat down waiting for Catra to do so as well, once face to face she dig into her pocket stretching a candy bar to her.

"You brought me chocolate?" Catra chuckled accepting it "You want to share it?" she offered as the girl's eyes sparkled taking her half as Melog curled into itself at the girl's side. Catra was used to it now. Her 'emotional support space cat' as some of the other princesses had described, had bonded with the girl as well after spending months looking over her while Catra and Adora were in outer space. And now more often than not, Melog responded to her instead which provided a strange sense of comfort for Catra, knowing that in a way, a part of her had stayed behind in Bright Moon.

"This is a really nice base, you all did great" Catra praised seeing her overflow with excitement.

"We can sleep were tonight" she said enthusiastically.

"Perhaps another time, we didn't came quite prepare except for the snacks" she smiled back "Besides Aunty Dora and your mom don't know where we are, we don't make them worry, right?" she reasoned gently "Plus we wouldn't want to leave Saber out of this. We can plan it for next week"

"That's too long" she pouted and Melog seemed to compel to her argument.

"I'm not going anywhere" Catra answered chuckling lightly "I'll be here next week and the week after and the month after. We are really staying, Angie"

"So we can come here every day?"

"If you'd like that we could try, at least until Adora needs me more" she offered.

"Aunty Dora already had you" she complained in such a childish way, her frown reminded Catra all the times she had annoyed Glimmer when they were younger. Riling up the princess had been incredibly easy and outstandingly amusing at the time.

"Well, Adora will need me by her side because now that we are moving back, we are planning on having a family" she said, finding the time perfect to tell her the news as well.

"You already have us"

"I know" she smiled endearingly at her remarks "But Aunty Dora and I…we want to have a baby" she said brightly "A kid of our own" as the silence stretched Catra noticed Melog wasn't mimicking her excitement but showing sadness instead. So she took a closer look at Angella's face "Little Sparkle?"

Teardrops fell down her cheeks "Then you won't be with me anymore" she choked out between sobs "You won't play with me, you won't want me"

"Hey, hey, no" she picked her in arms cuddling into her chest feeling her tiny hands tug at her shirt "Of course I will, I will always want to spend time with you"

"But you will love the baby more" she said fighting the hiccups.

"Sweetie" Catra pulled apart just enough to cup her face wiping the tears "That's not how love works" she said gently.

"You'll replace me"

"No, of course not" she kissed her forehead reassuringly "It took me a long time to learn this, but love is not something that you trade or try to divide among the people around you, it expands, it grows" she explained one of the most valuable lessons she had learned "When your Aunty Dora became friends with your parents I was just as scared as you are right now, because I thought she would love them more, that she had replaced me but she never stopped loving me, she just learned how to give before I could" she rocked her in arms into a soothing rhythm, her tail wrapping around her tummy "And yes, a baby will take a lot of my time and of course I will love my kitten, but they would never take away my love for you, I will love you both equally just in a different way"

she purred gently, feeling her ease up a bit "It's like your parents, they love you and your brother just the same, right?"

The little princess nodded sniffling "Yeah…we are both their favorites" she repeated a phrase she had heard from them.

"See?" she rubbed her back gently "And I was hoping you would help me with my kitten" she added with a playful tone "Who is going to show them the woods? Or were they hide the cookies in the kitchen? Or all the fun things you and Saber do?"

Angie shrugged her shoulders thinking about it "I could show them how to build a fort with covers and pillows" she looked up hopeful.

"Now that's something neither Adora nor I could teach them" she smirked at her bright eyes "See how much I'll need you, Little Sparkle?" she loosen the embrace feeling her shift into a sitting position looking at her.

"I can help you, Aunty Cat" she offered forgetting about the tears that were now drying "I can show them the castle, so they won't get lost and we can play in the gardens, have picnics together"

"I would love that very much" Catra smiled moving her rebel lock out of her face to reveal those innocent eyes looking brighter and clearer after the tears "And I'll always love you, Little Sparkle. You are my family too, that won't change, Angella"

"I'll always love you too" she collapsed into her arms and didn't let go.

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The sunset was already bidding farewell as Catra gazed outside the window from the bathtub. The water was still warm enough

even though the afternoon breeze was blowing a chilling howl inside.

Luckily she had made it back to the castle before sundown as Glimmer was already at the entrance expecting their return. Catra had been carrying the sleeping princess through all the way back as Angella had once again fallen asleep in her arms. The Queen smiled at the sight and took over noticing Melog's colors were somewhat moved, but Catra assured it had been a great walk. Still she was in all honestly a bit worn out, so when she told Glimmer she would head to her room, the Queen made sure a bath was ready for her arrival.

And now Catra was lying there, head way above the liquid. As long as she didn't feel the pressing sensation of being drowned she could handle water in small amounts. Spending time in Mystacor had helped her work through the trauma of being mind controlled by Prime and the ritual it involved, and now, several years later she was able to relax into the experience.

"And to think I used to beg you to join in" Came Adora's voice from behind as a kiss tickled the back of her ear.

"Hey Adora" she said, her voice low and seductive.

"Enjoying the peace and quiet?" she teased sitting at the edge of the tub behind her.

"Maybe" she admitted tilting her head back to meet her eyes. Adora took the opportunity to tangle her fingers in her long mane caressing softly as Catra purred in response "That feels nice" she all but melted against the touch.

"I'm glad"

Catra forced her eyes to open again "But I know that's your signature, 'I'm sorry' gesture" she replied smirking smugly noticing Adora turn beet red "What took you so long to make it back to the castle?" she asked allowing Adora to still run smooth

fingers down her scalp "Did you escape to have one last call to adventure before pregnancy?"

"Of course not" she answered with a firm tone in an almost scolding manner "I did went to meet with Swift Wind but…" she exhaled "I asked him to take me to Madame Razz"

Catra turned around at those words "You could have told me, I would have gone with"

"I know" she framed her face between her palms kissing tenderly at her lips "I just needed to ask her something, to shake off a feeling"

"Are you having doubts about our baby?" she asked softly, but her tone did carry worry.

"No, not about carrying, about not being able to, that I wouldn't be fit for it, that I might fail"

Catra gazed at her with concern "Adora if this is too much for you we could wait, I don't want you to pressure yourself either, you tend to carry the weight of the world on your shoulders"

Adora walked to her side to be face to face, kneeling there "We both have our demons to slay when it comes to our fears and flaws, and I think we feel them more present when we talk about our baby, I'll admit to that" she said sheepishly "I know it will be an adjustment and not being able to transform into She-Ra and fight worries me, not fighting at all is kind of unsettling, it's all we ever did, it comes as second nature"

"It's not that you'll do nothing, on the contrary, you'll be doing so much more, just not in the way you are used to" Catra leaned forward reaching for her hand.

"I'm coming to terms with that" she nodded intertwining her fingers "And I'm ready for it" she said genuinely and thrilled, her resolve unwavering.

Catra was aback by how openly she proclaimed that, how self-assured and calmed she seemed, it managed to sooth her, perhaps Adora would have to hold enough confidence for the both of them. So she smiled and took a peck at her lips "I'm glad" she felt Adora kiss back, a hand carefully placed at her neck "What did you ask Madame Razz? Something about the First Ones?" Catra asked in the brief instant they pulled apart, feeling Adora's growing yearn to show affection as she leaned in tasting her lips more thoroughly.

The blonde shook her head, her smile taking over "Didn't have a chance to ask anything, Madame Razz was mixing timelines again" she tilted her head to a side, nothing new about those odd exchanges. Catra rolled her eyes chuckling, suddenly feeling ghostly caresses going down her features as Adora ran her fingertips from her earlobe to her collarbone "And she asked why I had come alone" she added settling her tiara aside "Why weren't you with me on this visit"

"As she should ask" Catra smirked back, her voice hitching a bit when she felt Adora's hand trace down her arm sinking under the water as well to steady herself, her lips hovering above the expectant ones of her wife

"She asked if you had stayed home…" she slowly climbed inside the tub not minding her dress as she saw those heterochromatic eyes focused on her lips, cheeks turning a deep shade of red "-if you had stayed…with our daughter"

Realization hit Catra as Adora smiled knowingly noticing her surprise and excitement "Our daughter?" she repeated astonished as her hopes and illusions seemed to materialize before her.

"We'll have our kitten, Catra" Adora said overflown with joy as she finally captured her lips into her own, splashing around, exploding in laughter.

"You should have started with that!" Catra bumped her shoulder with a fist unable and unwilling to sit up.

"And pass on the opportunity to see that face? I don't think so" she tapped a finger against her wife's lips "It's not every day I'm one step ahead of you" she embraced her, cornering her against the edge "Now, let's have that baby" she leaned down closing her eyes, giving into her arms.

They were going to be mothers, it was no longer a question of 'if', but 'when'. And both were longing for it.

Chapter End Notes

> I know a lot have asked if Finn would be part of the story, but I'd like to stay in this line and develop the character in the same way the others have been introduced, so let's see how it goes!
>
> Thank you so much for your support! See you soon! (Most likely next friday!)

Chapter 10

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"No fair, you already know! Tell us who won the bet" Frosta insisted.

"Sorry not can do, kiddo" Catra smirked smugly as she took her third cup of coffee.

"And are you sure you can trust Madame Razz predictions?" Perfuma asked gently.

"Oh, you can trust her" Glimmer chuckled "She was right about us" she picked up Saber preventing him to hide under the table, probably were he was hoarding all the cookies he could.

"And that prediction was given offhandedly" Bow added sitting Angella on his lap to clean the frosting off her face "We should have believed her sooner"

"You all sound so sure, but you are barely going through your first trimester, Adora" Netossa turned to look at the blonde "You don't second guess it even a bit?"

It took Adora a second to realize the question was aimed at her, she shook her head trying to focus and get her thoughts out of the drowsiness she felt "I'm sorry?"

"Second guessing?" she repeated.

"I love being pregnant!" she replied heartedly and perhaps wounded at what she thought was the question as she placed a hand on top of her stomach.

"No, honey, second guessing what gender the baby will be" Spinella reached putting a hand on her knee.

"Right, sorry, I'm sorry" she rubbed her face tiredly offering a weak smile "I trust Madame Razz, she hasn't lead me astray in all this time, she might have odd antiques, but she has always directed me to the right path"

"Are you alright, Adora?" Scoria asked gently but out front "You look kind of tired and I mean, once you fought a whole army in a day and still helped reconstruct that same night and didn't seem as worn out as right now"

"Subtle" Mermista jabbed.

Adora sheepishly smirked "It's okay guys, honest, I just haven't been able to sleep very well" she readjusted her position in the chair, she had been sliding off.

"Isn't it too early for baby kicks and elbows?"

"It's not the baby, I just…I have been restless, it's all" she flashed a smile that accomplished to overshadow the growing dark circles under her eyes.

Catra gazed at her wife frowning, she knew Adora was under selling it. It was not restlessness; it was plain nightmares that woke her up in cold sweats and soft whimpers. Most of the nights when she woke up close to tears, Catra would already have her wrapped in arms rocking gently, mumbling soothing things into her hair. When they were particularly bad they would end up in the kitchen, some evenings even Bow and Glimmer would join them after hearing the commotion and shared a cup of tea to talk over.

Whenever Adora tried to express what the nightmares were about she became tongue tied. It was not even that she didn't want to address the night terrors; it was that she couldn't place what they were about. At first she thought it was her fear of not being able to protect anyone if she couldn't transform into She-Ra, but it wasn't quite it. Then the thought of the shadows of her past hunting her down were once more presenting themselves, but she

knew how those felt and neither the Horde or Shadow Weaver were in her dreams. And now Adora was out of ideas almost as much as she was out of sleep.

"I could make some herbal mix, that could help you relax" Perfuma offered.

"That would be great, thank you" she nodded, at that point she was really considering going to Mystacor or being put down with magic for even just a few hours. Glimmer was half minded to perform the spell herself but her father had asked her not to, sensing that Adora's current state had something to do with her own magic, and that was a process in which they couldn't intervene.

"I can help you make it" Scorpia offered enthusiastically "We do a bit of gardening, and I'm getting quite good at it, if I do say so myself. These bad girls are great to pull out ivy" she opened and closed her pincers to demonstrate.

"They'll be really helpful to extract some roots we'll need" she praised.

"Oh! I can do that right now!" she stood up "which ones do you need, the purple ones or the yellow?"

Perfuma discreetly eyed Adora "Purple"

"Okay" she grabbed Catra's arm "What do you say, Wildcat? Feel like digging in the dirt with me?"

Catra raised a brow, she was used to Scorpia's randomness, but that felt a bit odd "Sure" she stood up "be right back" she laid a kiss on Adora's hair heading out of the common room and into the gardens. Once outside and under the sun Catra arched her back breathing in to then slouch her shoulders. Scorpia was already at it, kneeling next to a bush moving the mud.

"So what do we have to do to extract this thing?"

"Nothing much, I'm basically done"

Catra raised a brow "Then why did you ask me to come?"

Scorpia didn't answer, instead she pulled the root out of the ground "The purple one is super strong, it could knock you out almost as fast as my stinger" she commented before looking back at her with a knowing smirk "you could use a cup of it too, huh?" she asked gently.

Catra folded her arms looking away in embarrassment "I do not!"

"Nah, I don't fall for it. Remember I have seen you work extra hours and be sleep deprived before" she patted the dirt out of her clothes "So…What gives?"

Catra huffed, her ears twitching, but those calmed eyes didn't gave up and her insides turned, it felt a bit too much like the old times, and not in the kind way.

"It's…Adora" she mumbled dropping her shoulders "She doesn't sleep, so I don't sleep. She's carrying our kitten and suffering through nightmares and I can't do anything for her, so I just stay at her side all night" she explained, her own expression showing how drained she felt as well.

"That explains the coffee, not even as Force Captain you dared touch a mug"

Catra chuckled dryly "Yeah, we are running out of options so I do hope this soothing tea works" she pointed at the plant.

"It will, Wildcat" she settled it aside for a moment "You know? I think it's great you are looking out for Adora, just don't forget to take care of yourself. You won't be any help if you can't function properly"

"It's not like I am being any help anyways"

"That's not true and you are missing my point on propose... I think, maybe you are just too tired"

"No, no, I get it" Catra offered a faint laugh, too worn out to elaborate further.

Scorpia tilted her head gazing at her and did a gesture Catra had grown to love, she opened her arms for her "Come here" she offered a hug that made the feline look up "It will be just a quick one, promise"

And Catra smiled as she slipped into her arms allowing herself to be held and for the burden to be lifted form her shoulders even if just for a moment.

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Catra couldn't quite figure out why Scorpia's embrace had sparked such a memory form her past, but if nothing else, she was glad it had. At least now, instead of standing around helplessly trying to calm Adora, she could actually try to do something to stop the nightmares. It was a long shot, but it was a plan, and at that point, she would have tried anything.

That afternoon Adora was going to visit Madame Razz in hopes of figuring out what was giving her such wrenched dreams, Catra had offered to go with, but Adora insisted that she stayed and caught up on some much needed sleep and Catra agreed to stay put, but not to rest. She wouldn't if Adora wasn't able to either. So she set her plan into motion. She packed a few bars to eat later and a lantern. Then she carefully laid the cape she used to steal from her wife on the chair and removed her boots, she was going to need as much mobility as possible. And then with her bag at the shoulder, she reached the hall where Melog waited.

"Ready?" she asked the other feline that answered with a somewhat distraught tone.

"Well, the faster we go, the sooner we'll be back" she replied.

"You leaving?" A soft voice called from behind making Catra turn around in a jolt finding Angella there. She should have guessed that were Melog was, the small princess was sure to follow.

"Hey, Little Sparkle" she leaned down "I'm going to take Melog for a long walk, okay?"

"Can I go too?"

Catra felt her heart ache "I'm sorry, not to this one"

"But why?" she asked showing hurt in her round eyes.

Catra exhaled unable to figure a way to say it, to explain it "I'm going to a place that's not suited for kids" she tried to reason "I will be quick about it, that's why I need Melog to come with me"

"You'll come back?" her voice quivered with sadness.

"Yes, of course I will" she grabbed her shoulders looking at her eyes "I promised I wasn't leaving you, I just need to do this little trip, I'll be back before you know it" she smiled "tomorrow we can sit together at the breakfast table, how about that?"

Angella gazed at her trying to prevent tears form forming "Okay, Aunty"

"Thank you, Little Sparkle" she hugged her, kissing her temple as Melog rubbed his head against both comforting them. Catra caught her breath and pulled apart caressing her head "If…um, if Aunty Dora comes back before I do, can you tell her I went for a walk? A long one, but that I am coming back" she added determined, stressing on the fact she would return.

Angella could feel something off about the petition, but didn't hesitate to nod "We'll have breakfast together"

"Yeah, we will" she smiled tenderly at her before standing up "Why don't you go play with Saber meanwhile?" she offered, trying to make her exit as discrete as possible.

"Okay" she hugged her legs before turning around.

Catra exhaled hearing Melog immediately intervene "I didn't ask her to lie" she replied stubbornly before groaning at the response "It's not a place I would ever want her to be near of, or even know of" and then Melog's mane became blue, his ears dropping, feeling her emotions "Let's just go" she asked and the lion like creature began to turn them invisible while reaching the door to leave, just as a bright flash of light stepped in their way and a very upset looking Queen materialized out of thin air.

The surprise was so great Catra broke the link with Melog stumbling backwards at the sight "Sparkles!"

"Mind telling me where do you think you are going?" she asked severely.

Catra jolted her shoulders up at being caught "For a walk" she answered forcedly.

"Yes, I gathered that from what I could hear you tell my daughter" she replied.

"You were spying on us?" she asked turning her shock into anger.

"I was looking for Angella! And what I found wasn't exactly reassuring" she folded her arms defensibly "You have a bag thrown to your shoulder and were trying to sneak out while invisible, so please tell me how this is supposed to play out?!" she walked forward "A quick visit to the Crimson Waste? Get in a few punches to let out all the frustration? Come back with a black eye and a couple of broken ribs?"

Catra was aback by that conclusion, in all fairness it did sounded like something she could do, but that was not the case "I'm not running to get into a fight!" she refuted "I'm going back to the Fright Zone!"

Glimmer felt her mind go blank at that, her thoughts scattered and all the fury became confusion "Why?!"

Catra regretted opening her mouth, her explanation wasn't exactly sound, it was at best childish, and if it were anyone but Glimmer, she would have probably kept it to herself and make a gran scape through the window "There's…there's something I want to recover from there" she began getting the Queen's full attention so she shrugged and continued "Adora…used to have this blanket, the same she was tucked in when Hordak brought her to this dimension, and when we were younger she used to sleep with it but as soon as our training began Shadow Weaver took it away, that's when I started to sleep at the foot of her bed, because she couldn't fall asleep without that thing" she averted her eyes feeling her face grow warm "and…and I want to give it back to her because maybe…having that would help her with the nightmares" she admitted, her tone growing weak and self-conscious.

"And you think it's still there?"

Catra rubbed her neck grumbling "I caught glimpse of it one time at Shadow Weaver's bunker, she tended to keep all things related to Adora and casted charms on them so they wouldn't get tempered with, perhaps she harvested magic out of them, I have no idea" the thought made her guts twist, but didn't entertain it any longer "I know it's stupid and somewhat risky, but I'm tired of uselessly sitting on the bed unable to help her, so I might as well feel like I'm doing something" she picked up her bag again and walked past Glimmer, but the Queen grabbed her shoulder stopping her. Catra was about to groan and explain once more why she needed to do this when she heard her say-

"Then I'll take you there"

Catra felt her ears twitch "What?"

"You were planning on having Melog take you, right?" she asked "That would be about three hours to get there and three more for the way back, I can save you that time, make it back before Adora does"

Catra gazed at her surprised and perhaps suspiciously "Why aren't you trying to stop me?"

"Because I do understand what feeling helpless is like and if this is something you need to do, then I'm going to be there for you. You don't have to go back to that place alone" she rested a palm on her shoulder "So…shall we?"

Catra smiled back and hugged her tightly "Thank you, Sparkles" And the white flash took them away.

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After several jumps across the land, they finally reached a place that not even She-Ra's magical power was able to completely overthrow, the Fright Zone.

It still looked like the mechanical dystopia that it was several years ago, but now with a coat of plants and greens growing over and into the structure, but the grey skies and rusty colors couldn't be outmatched. The soil had been so exploited it would still take it several more years before nature could truly take over the land.

Glimmer flinched at the sight, her palms sweating and her chest pressing down. She felt her hands clench into fists and if that was her reaction to it, she couldn't begin to imagine how Catra must had been feeling.

"This way" the former soldier instructed walking through the wreckage as if nothing ever happened, knowing exactly how to move around the destroyed base.

"It's…quite something to be back" Glimmer mumbled walking a step behind her, allowing Melog to be the one at her side meantime. Its mane was tamed, it didn't show the scarlet colors it usually did when Catra felt ire or fear, on the contrary it was… calmed. Perhaps a bit too calmed "Catra?" Glimmer called softly.

The taller woman stopped on her tracks, not turning around "I'm okay" she said, her voice faint but stable "It's not being here what unnerves me it's…walking away from it again" she explained before clearing her throat "And…thank you. For-for not assuming I was running away, back in the palace" she said gently "It's not like I haven't done it before, you had every reason to jump to that conclusion" she was about to take another step when she felt a hand on her shoulder forcing her to turn around meeting determined eyes.

"I would never assume that, Catra. I know how much you love Adora and your kitten, even if things are a bit tough right now, I know you would never walk away" she released her arm.

Catra smiled moved by how effortlessly she claimed that, how genuinely she trusted and believed in her "Thank you" she repeated.

Glimmer nodded encouragingly, knowing her words had been heard "Where to now?"

Catra inspected the place, a few collapsed walls meant they would need to take a different route "Can you light a spark?" she asked "I can see in the dark, but you might have to watch your step, some of the traps might still be active"

Glimmer conjured a small ball of light.

"Good, now under we go" she stretched her hand and Glimmer took them inside the wolf's mouth.

It was pitch black except for the warm light the Queen's magic offered.

"Stay close" she guided her through, not letting go of her hand as they walked across forgotten memories.

Catra could almost hear the mechanical sounds that used to fill the place, or the ghost of instructors waiting at every corner ready to scold them. The thing that made her skin crawl was being surrounded by so much darkness, feeling like the shadows could materialize into the figure that had hurt her most in her life.

Glimmer gazed around at the empty bunkers, the beds were untidy, the corridors empty, all abandoned in such a rush it looked like a scene frozen in time "I…never asked you this before but… how did you ended up in here, Catra?"

Glimmer noticed a faint change in Melog's colors at the question, but Catra didn't let go of her hand, nor did she held tighter "Shadow Weaver always told me I was left in a box. For a long time I thought she was just being mean but at a point I did believe it because…why else would I wind up here? My parents or whoever was taking care of me just left me" she chuckled dryly "How bad did they had it that the best option seemed like to abandon me in a place called the Fright Zone, right?" the sarcasm dripping like venom from her words was her most earnest attempt to keep the hurt from reaching her heart once again.

"I'm…I'm sorry" Glimmer squeezed gently at her palm.

Catra shook her head, glad that the poor lighting prevented Glimmer to properly see her face "It's okay" she breathed in "I mean, it clearly it's not but…if I hadn't been here then I would have never met Adora" she concluded "I might not know who my family was before, but I do now" she cut herself off, knowing that if she said more, her voice would crack "Sort of a count your blessings and all that" she avoided digging deeper into the wound and Glimmer decided not to press it.

"I guess that's true" she mumbled as they reached a blocked hallway. Then for the first time, Catra seemed to hesitate "Are we lost?" she inquired.

"No" came the answered with a hint of indignation, she knew that place even better than the palm of her hand "We just have to take another route…"they walked to a stretch hallway that lead to a painfully familiar room full of bunker beds lining one after the other.

"Not much privacy granted, huh?" Glimmer commented casually taking a good look at it as they reached the farthest side of the room and came to a sudden stop. Catra's eyes seemed lost in thought as she gazed down.

"Is something wrong?" she asked gently but Catra didn't hear her words, so Glimmer followed her eyesight finding a destroyed mattress and on the wall a couple of drawing, one of which was scratched by her own claws "This…this was your room" she mumbled and Catra finally snapped out of her thoughts.

"Yeah" she looked away "our room"

And Glimmer understood just how much those words meant, it was like standing in front of a memorial of a sort, so she knelt down taking a look at the drawings tracing her fingertips against them "You each drew yourselves?"

Catra felt a bit aback by the question, by how casually she took in the image, oddly enough it made her feel better. The fact that she didn't acknowledge the marks, that she didn't needed to hear an explanation as to why Adora's face was scratched with lines she would later inflict in real life. She understood the pain behind those parallel strokes running on the metal.

"Yes, we each did our own"

"I'm afraid to say you are both better cooks than artists"

Catra chuckled kneeling down as well "Give us a break, we were about ten years old when we did them" she caressed the wall longingly "we weren't allowed to damage property, but we wanted to leave proof of who would rule this place, that they knew where we had been, that we existed, that we mattered…" and her smile faltered.

Glimmer saw the troubling thoughts her mind raced to, so she stood up offering a hand "And now, there's not a person in the nearby galaxies that doesn't know who you are"

Catra looked up at her, gratitude in her eyes "Yeah, I guess that's about right" she took her hand standing up.

"Come on, we still have a mission to accomplish" she smirked encouragingly.

"Down this way" they walked away from the scars of the past and into another hallway where a solitary door stood.

"Well, this is it" she announced "mind doing the honors?"

Glimmer nodded and after a blink, they were inside the demolished room. The ceiling had fallen over in some parts and the oxidation in the walls was making them thin, that structure was not holding for too long.

"Let's try not to move too many things" Catra's ears twitched picking up all the little sounds the screeching metal did.

"Okay" she let go of her hands as each inspected an opposite side "Do you remember were you saw it last?"

"Under her bed" she pointed at the corner that was below debris.

"Okay, that's an easy fix" she held on to the biggest piece and teleported far away making a swift return panting in the slightest.

"Hey, don't wear yourself out; we still have to make it to Bright Moon"

"Please, I'm a grown woman, I can throw sparkles for hours" she teased, hands on her hips and a self-satisfied smile.

Catra smirked back "Whatever you say, Sparkles" she turned around and suddenly the image became a bit too real as she reached the mattress. Her hands hovered hesitatingly.

"Hey" Glimmer knelt next to her "Even if it's not there, you came all the way here, you did it for Adora, that's what counts"

Catra exhaled unevenly, a bit more comforted, nodding at the princess before turning back to the task at hand. She moved the bed revealing a little chest. She carefully opened it as if it might be an illusion and then…there it was. Neatly tucked into the box, not a day had passed by that piece of cloth. Catra held it in arms and clenched it against her chest as the air she had been holding in her chest escaped.

"It's there!" Glimmer cheered shaking her shoulder in excitement "I can't believe it's actually here! Catra you found it!" she turned to celebrate when she noticed the feline sobbing against the fabric "Catra?" she gently rubbed her back.

"I just-just need a moment" she chocked out hiding her face.

"…Okay" Glimmer removed her hand eyeing her carefully.

Catra bit down into her lower lip trying to force herself out of it, when suddenly she felt the slight pressure against her back, as Glimmer sat right behind her and suddenly the warm feeling, the comfort it always provided to have her there made itself present and it eased a bit of the pain that was eating her insides.

Melog cuddled, resting its head over her lap purring softly as Catra kept on crying, tears dripping into the blanket.

Glimmer waited there in silence, knowing that whatever demons Catra was fighting, she needed to do it without prying eyes over her. As a few minutes passed them by, Catra was able to suck in a breath and let go of her iron grip on the cloth. She gazed at it

with nostalgia running her fingers through the soft texture "I…I thought it wouldn't be this overwhelming" she mumbled "I assumed that after all this time, none of this would be able to affect me but…" she clenched her fist unwilling to break down again.

"No one was expecting you to shove all this aside, Catra" Glimmer answered quietly "it's still part of you, of your past. These walls say you grow up, you built yourself in this base, of course it still has that power over you"

"But I don't want it to" she clenched her jaw "I'm finally looking ahead, I thought I could leave this behind for good" she mumbled "and the whole time we have been here I've only been thinking in one thing, that…that I don't want my kitten to ever feel the same way I felt while growing up. Like not being enough, not being worthy of affection, or deserving of love…" she traced back hugging herself "out of all the wounds and bruises they inflicted, what Shadow Weaver did was…was far worse than all the broken bones and punishments" she shut her eyes hard "and then she just sacrifices herself and expects that to make us even and…and she finally says what I always wanted to hear and…and" she pressed a hand against her mouth muffling another cry.

Glimmer turned around laying a hand on her back rubbing delicate circles "You are not her" she broke the silence "and your baby will be lucky to have you" Glimmer wrapped her arms around her resting her head over Catra's back, her arms holding her tight over her chest as the next sob broke through her, shaking her violently "I can't pretend to understand what you went through but I can tell you that you are one of the strongest people I know because of what you endured and how you thrived form it" she said in all conscience "You are enough, you are worthy of being loved and you deserve your happiness. Whatever ghost from the past you see here, they can't harm you anymore. You are not that defenseless little kid they hurt" she mumbled "you don't sulk in the shadows or hide when you are upset as you used to because now you know you have people that care deeply for you, people you can reach out to. Adora, the princesses, Bow, the twins,

me..." she pressed a soft kiss against the back of her ear "and part of it is letting us see the scars so we can help you heal" she sighed softly "No matter how broken you feel, we'll always love you"

Catra hung her head allowing the final tears to slide down her face as she reached for her friend's hands that still held her tight, protectively. And just as her light was dimming down-

"Glimmer" she mumbled, her voice quivering "Can we go home?"

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"And you don't know where they are?" Adora asked Bow, her tone showing her distress.

"Angie said Catra went for a walk with Melog" he explained.

"How long ago?" she insisted when suddenly the white flash exploded in the middle of the room as Glimmer panted with a victorious smile.

"See? I told you I could run sparkles around you"

"Catra!" Adora reached her wife who seemed to have the slightest bit of trouble settling her stomach.

"Glimmer" Bow went to her side "Where were you?! I was so worried"

"I'm sorry love" she apologized "we needed to make a little expedition, it was a bit farther than I recalled"

"What are you talking about?" Adora held into Catra helping her stabilize.

Glimmer exchanged gazed with Catra knowing that whatever conversation was about to take place needed to be private.

"Come on Bow, I'll explain everything, but let's give them a minute" she grabbed his arm leading him to the exit as the two women were left alone.

"Catra, where have you been?! I thought you were going to rest! You know how disconcerting was to not only not find you at our bed but not finding you at all in the palace? I thought you might have fainted in the middle of the woods!"

Catra allowed her to get it all out of her chest, she had wanted to avoid this part as she didn't consider Adora might beat her back to the castle "I'm sorry, I didn't want to make you worry, I was trying to do the opposite" she admitted, her ears tilting down.

Adora saw her vulnerable gesture and decided to go easy on her, after all she wasn't the only one on edge from exhaustion "You were supposed to rest" she softly caressed her face.

"How could I if you haven't?" she retorted dropping her shoulders defeated "You haven't been able to get a moments rest for days now"

"And neither have you, you deserve it just as much"

"I'm not the one carrying" she folded her arms averting her eyes.

Adora then noticed that guilt glimmering in her heterochromatic eyes "Is that what this is about? Make it even? Catra, not because of what I'm going through you should put yourself through the same. We agreed I'd carry, I never asked you to compensate anything"

"I know, it's not just that-! It's all of it! When I get nightmares, when I get a panic attack you are always there, you know what to do, what to say, you calm me so easily and I…I haven't been able to help at all. I just sit there and watch you struggle it…it hurts that I can't take care of you as well, neither of you"

"...Catra" she pronounced her name so softly it sounded like a lullaby "Don't you see? The fact that you stayed by my side, hugging me, soothing me, purring ... the fact that you never left or made me feel like I was a burden or weak...you made every difference" she cupped her face "When you are next to me I don't feel helpless, because no matter how bad the dreams can be, the moment I wake up and see your face, I can reassure myself that my reality right now is just amazing" she took her had driving it to her stomach holding it there "That we are having a baby together, that the war is over, that we belong to a place we can call home..." she smiled sweetly.

Catra answered with a genuine gesture, Adora's word ringed with a beautiful truth in them "That's true" she mumbled caressing Adora's stomach carefully "And we'll always protect our little one"

"We will" Adora leaned in kissing her "That's...sort of the reason the nightmares are there, actually" the blonde admitted making Catra's eyes snap open questioningly "It's a sort of a defense mechanism" she shrugged "that's how Darla described it. Madame Razz and I had a detour while I visited her" she added.

"How can your dreams be a defense mechanism?" she asked trying to tie the loose ends "it's not-it's not premonitions, is it?" she inquired, concerned of what the future might hold for their daughter.

"No! No, nothing like that" she rubbed her arms up and down reassuringly "it's...it's just the fact that I'm having a descendant away from my homeland" she tilted her head averting her eyes "since it's a danger to settle in 'unknown' lands, my magic it's trying to warn me, keep me on my toes, sort of speak"

"Sleep with an eye open" Catra concluded "That...sucks"

Adora laughed dryly "It does" she gazed down "I'm trying to find a way to reassure the primal thing in my being that I'm not with the First Ones but that I am home" she exhaled "So seems like I have been fighting my insides all along"

"I know a thing or two about that" Catra said gently cupping her cheek "and speaking of…" she dig into her bag pulling out the blanket "Here's…a little piece of your actual home"

Adora's eyes went wide at the sight, her mind racing to forgotten memories, to soft and vulnerable parts of her upcoming.

"Is that-? I thought it was thrown away, how did -?"

"Shadow Weaver kept it" she said timidly, the admission drew the last conclusion.

"You went to the Fright Zone?" she asked shocked "Catra, you hate that place"

"But I love you. I told you in our vows I'd go to the end of the cosmos for you" she countered softly seeing that worry look in her wife's eyes "I wasn't there alone, I had Glimmer and Melog at my side and…and in a sense it helped me to be there after so long…" she mumbled "because I too could see just how good our present is and just how ready I am to welcome our kitten into our lives" she gazed at the fabric "I just had to salvage one last thing before moving forwards" she gazed up "our baby deserves to be wrapped in the welcoming embrace of her mother's blanket"

Adora hugged the piece of clothing against her chest as she used to when she was younger and inhaled deeply. If she closed her eyes she could still smell the sweet scent impregnated into it.

"After she took it away you would sneak to my side at night…" she whispered remembering part of their origins.

Catra nodded softly "Yeah" she held into a corner of the blanket as well "I wanted to give you the same sense of protection you felt when you had this next to you"

Adora leaned in pressing their foreheads together "I feel the safest when you are with me" she looked at her eyes, her clear blue ones showing traces of exhaustion.

"Same" she tilted her chin kissing her, allowing her own body to let go of the tension and for the tiredness to settle in, leaving her defenseless "Hey, Adora?" she mumbled "why don't we put it to the test?" she suggested with a small grin "We both could use a bit of sleep"

Adora giggled softly "I'd like that" she grabbed her hand driving her back to their room as the nightfall tucked in the sky in a gentle way.

They didn't change into any nightgown or robes; they just laid on the bed embracing each other. Soft breathings cutting through the crickets' lullabies, Catra's purring as a chorus to their songs.

And just as the first stars were splashing the horizon, they finally drifted into a peaceful slumber. From that night forward, no bad dream could reach either of them and even if they did, as long as they had each other to wake up next to, wrapped in a warm embrace, nothing bad could really happen.

Chapter End Notes

I wanted to wait until the end of the series for this, but might as well I'll just say it... ¡Hands down this is one of the nicest fandoms I've ever written for! You are all so polite, encouraging and supportive! When I first posted this fic (planning in only making it a three chapters long) I thought I would get a lot of backlash for centering on these two characters (in a platonic way) but I was pleasantly surprised when so many of you connected to it, and gave feedback, kudos/likes, bookmarks/follows, all of it!

And I like that even when some chapters and events didn't go as some expected, all the comments about it were incredibly supportive and it made me feel comfortable to keep writing the story I needed and wanted to tell.

And I don't intend for this message to discourage you from writing any constructive criticism, on the contrary, I really

appreciate when you point out the little errors so I can go and correct them so you can all enjoy a smoother reading (t's a bit self evident now that english is not my first language, huh? XD).

And I deeply enjoy when I read your comments and ideas regarding the story, it makes my day to see how much it has connected to some on an emotional level and that you all are still bearing with me to see what adventure might come next.

I might not know how much story I have left to tell, but for what is worth, this has been one incredible ride. So thank you. Sincerely your author thus far, Zetara.

Chapter 11

"Okay sweethearts, time for bed" Glimmer announced closing the storybook Adora had given Saber almost a year ago, after telling one of their adventures in the younger days."Can we hear one more story?" both pleaded with big round eyes.

"I don't know, what do you think, Bow?" she looked at her husband while he threw more wood into the fireplace.

"Come on, Bow!" Adora called form the sofa cuddling under Catra's arm as a hand rested on her perfectly round stomach feeling one strong kick form her baby "Our kitten wants to hear one more too"

"Alright, alright, one more but then it's bed time for all of us" he emphasized "we don't want to keep Aunty Dora up, she needs her rest since the baby seems to be getting anxious to meet us all"

"That might as well happen pretty soon" Catra added kissing Adora's temple.

"Will you tell us if the baby is going to be a girl or a boy?" the twins turned to them.

"Yeah, will it be on my team or in hers?" Saber inquired jumping up and down in the cushion.

"I guess will have to wait and see"

"Mom, can you tell us?" they looked over at Glimmer who smiled charmingly.

"Sorry dear, but they haven't said a thing to me either; it will be a big surprise"

"And a pretty interesting bet" Bow added "Frosta said triplets, who knows? Maybe she was right" he teased lightly.

"Please, remember how my baby bump was? Adora is not at that level, that's just one kitten right there"

"That we can assure" Adora chuckled "One kitten for us" she turned to Catra.

"Yeah" she smirked "no sibling since we already have both of you to keep our kid some company" she leaned in capturing both kids in arms sitting them in the couch as well "Now, what story are we going to hear before heading to bed?"

"Can you tell us about uncle Seahawk?!" Saber raised his hand.

"Or the one where you met the Star Siblings?"

"My, my, both sound like really interesting stories" Glimmer opened the book once more "Which one should it be?"

"Space one!" Saber changed his vote, eager to see the holographic images of the far away planet.

"Very well" she began telling the story from the point they had touched down at the foreign planet in search of crystals. By the time they told how Adora kept the tunnel from collapsing by regaining some of her powers and how Bow and Glimmer had trusted each other once more, both kids were already at the edge of their seats seeing their grand scape to the surface.

"That was amazing!" Saber stood up jumping from the sofa being caught by his dad before he could hurt himself.

"Yes, it was" he settled him down "Now time to sleep"

"Did all those things really happen?"

"Of course they did" Glimmer answered with a confident smile.

"Why weren't you on those stories, Aunty Cat?" Angella turned around looking at the brunette as all eyes fell on her and an awkward silence took over.

"I was somewhere else at the time" she admitted unwrapping her arm from around Adora to sit properly, leaning in to look at the girl "when you both get older I'll…tell you my full story" she said honestly.

"Promise?"

Catra gazes at those round eyes and couldn't help but wonder if they would still look at her so lovingly if she knew the whole truth "Yeah, I promise Little Sparkle. Someday" she finally said letting another pause pass them by.

"But that's not going to be tonight" Bow interrupted standing up "Come on kids. Say goodnight and head to bed"

"Goodnight mom, goodnight Aunties" Arrow leaned down at Adora's belly "goodnight kitty" he rubbed gently making the blonde smile fondly as he skipped away down the hallway.

"I'll tuck you in, in just a minute" Bow called before offering Adora a hand to stand up, knowing that alone was now a feat for the warrior.

"Thanks" she said once standing on her own "Goodnight, Bow"

"See you tomorrow" he raced to catch up with his kids.

"You okay?" Adora mumbled to Catra as the feline swayed her tail cautiously.

"Yeah" she nodded "I owe them the truth" she gazed up at Glimmer "I will tell them everything myself, once they are able to understand"

"No one will force you to" Glimmer answered softly.

"It's something that falls on me" she stated "they deserve to know, it is my responsibility and I will be accounted for it"

"But as Bow said, not tonight" Adora grabbed her hand "let that rest on the future, no point in dwelling on it right now"

"Adora is right" Glimmer chimed in "and when the time does come, I'll sit with them as well, we can explain everything together, the four of us"

"Yeah, we all share that past" Adora hooked her arm into her wife's "you don't have to do it alone"

Catra felt her face run warm allowing herself to be cared for "Thank you" she said.

"Anytime, love" Adora kissed her cheek "now, seems like our kitten is ready for me to lay down because that tiny elbow is pushing down hard"

Catra chuckled "Okay, let's get you both to bed" she held her arm as they walked out, leaving Glimmer a couple of steps behind. When Catra gazed over her shoulder to bid farewell she noticed Glimmer had turned her back to gaze privately at the storybook she held in hands, the image of her mother displaying in it.

Catra owed more than the truth to those kids…she owed them a grandmother too.

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"Our daughter is going to be a terrible sleeper, I can sense that already" Adora huffed lying down in bed with a lot of effort "she kind of sleep-fights like me" she mocked noticing Catra's eyes were lost in thought "Love?" she called in a soft voice that was easily caught by cat ears that twitched at the sound of her tone so vulnerable.

"Yeah?" she turned around focusing on her "do you need another pillow?"

"No, I'm okay" she held a soft smile before tapping at the mattress next to her "Join me?"

Catra smiled back, crawling to her side, cuddling into her shoulder and offering tender caresses at Adora's stomach smiling at the thought of holding her baby in a near future.

"Did Angie's question upset you?" Adora asked against her hair, combing her long mane.

"No" she mumbled averting her eyes.

"Catra" Adora scolded lightly knowing fully well she was trying to hide it away.

"It's not the question" Catra answered "It's…what I've done"

"Everyone has forgiven you"

"That doesn't mean is forgotten, that doesn't make it right"

Adora exhaled softly "I guess you are right" she wrapped her arms around kissing her forehead "but you are not that same person and the twins only know this version of you, you have never been deceiving towards them, you have been true and loving and they'll understand, once they are of age" she emphasized "Right now they are barely turning six, so please… don't torture yourself"

Catra sighed nuzzling into Adora's golden locks "Okay" she mumbled "I have other things to worry about anyways" she opened her eyes "like the fact our daughter doesn't have a name yet"

Adora giggled openly, how lively she did so made all the worries melt away. Whatever conversation needed to be held, would still be years into the future.

"I can't believe we knew way before I was pregnant the sex of the baby and still didn't considered choosing a name"

"I thought I was good at procrastinating, but I must admit, we took this to the next level" she smirked teasingly.

"Well, you are welcome to suggest a name as well, you know?"

"I already suggested Calico is she gets spots of different hair colors"

"That's not going to happen"

"Feral then"

"And now you are just messing with me" Adora retorted kissing her lips before looking into her eyes "I…actually have an idea?" she said gently.

"Really?" Catra raised a brow "let's hear it"

"It's…sort of how Glimmer named her kid after her mom?" she mentioned trying not to go into depth on the previous conversation.

"You…are not going to call her Light Spinner, right?" Catra actually frowned, ears tilted down.

"No! Of course not!" she replied in a hurry, her tone shocked at her words "That's not who I was thinking of" she clarified "I was thinking about Mara"

"Ow" Catra exhaled relieved before giving it a thought "Mara" she repeated

"Well yes and no" Adora shrugged.

"Which one is it?"

"I wanted to honor two people that helped me through my journey, Mara and Madame Razz"

Catra stayed attentive as her wife circled back to what she wanted to say "So…I thought Marazz?" she knitted her brows expecting her reaction.

"Marazz?" she rolled it in her tongue, it was foreign for sure but not unwelcomed.

"We can call her Mara or Razz for short or whatever nickname Bow comes up with and… I don't know, I kind of like it" she admitted shyly.

"Marazz" Catra said out loud trying to picture it, so instead she leaned back down pressing her nose to Adora's belly "Hey Marazz" she smirked "Mini Mara, Rascal Razz" she chuckled as Adora poked her side "You know what? Yeah" she looked up "Marazz it is"

"Really?" she asked dubious, managing her excitement with little success.

"Yes, really" she got face to face with her "I like it" she nodded "plus, if she hates it she can solely blame you" she stuck her tongue ready to get a reaction out of her.

"You are the worst!" Adora grabbed her face and unceremoniously kissed her lips with little regard of catching her breath, that until her recently named baby made sure to cut the moment "Ow" she rubbed at her hip "okay, okay, darling, sleepy time, I got it" she huffed letting go of Catra "She's moving a lot more lately" she laid on her side making sure to have a pillow to support the weight "Can you… purr?" she asked innocently "she really settles when she feels it"

"Gladly" Catra wrapped an arm around cuddling close to her wife and unborn child "Hey little Marazz, your mommies are going to sleep now, okay Kiddo? Let's stay still for a bit" she requested before closing her eyes and allowing her natural sound to be the lullaby to lure her baby into quietude. At least for a couple of hours…

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Adora turned, whimpering in the slightest until she finally gasped, jolting awake, sweat running down her face. Catra's ears caught on the events the moment her wife made a sound. She had hoped the nightmares would be long gone now.

"Hey Adora?" she sat down rubbing a hand on her back "You had a bad dream?" she asked, her voice drowsy.

"Catra" she turned to look at her with urgency "It's time" she said and those words alone kicked the feline with pure adrenaline.

"What?!"

"Catra, she's coming" she emphasized.

"Okay, okay" she untangled from the covers helping her seat as Adora began to breathe as Perfuma instructed her to. All that militarized training to follow orders under pressure was finally going to be useful for something practical.

Catra knelt in front of her grabbing her hand "You are doing great, I have to run fetch the medic, okay?"

"No, no, stay" she said a bit panicked.

"Adora, we need the physician, he's two hallways down, I'll be back before you know it" she tried to reason, but Adora didn't let go of her hand.

Their door opened a crack as Melog walked in incredibly agitated looking at Catra, perhaps sensing her distress.

"Aunties?" Angella's voice called form the entrance.

"Angie" Catra turned to her relieved "I need you to tell you parents to come here, okay?" she asked "Aunty Dora is having her baby right now"

Her eyes went wide as she bolted down the hall not minding to scream at the top of her longs the news.

"Oh good, now the whole kingdom can know" she smirked trying to win a grin out of Adora as her wife nervously laughed along.

"Hey Catra?"

"Yeah?"

"I love you"

Catra smiled back, she could see the fear in her eyes, the uncertainty of facing a new experience washing over her "I love you too" she answered "And soon we'll be able to say that to Marazz as well" she said encouragingly "just hang on"

She nodded, heavy sweat dampening her night robes as the contractions got stronger and she pressed down onto Catra's hand. Oddly enough the feline felt better that at least she could share even a small portion of the feeling, so Adora could unload herself into her.

Suddenly a white spark interrupted as Glimmer appeared in the room alongside the physician.

"He's here!" she announced letting him go so he could prepare as she raced to the side of the bed taking one of her hands as well "Adora, hey, how are you feeling?" she asked looking at her face.

"I'm okay" she said through clenched teeth feeling the next contraction hit too close to the last "she's just really excited to meet us" she tried to laugh but soon felt the pain again as she pressed both palms with might "really excited"

Glimmer rubbed her hand soothingly trying to keep her talking "H-hey you said she" she pointed out "baby girl?" she asked successfully managing to keep Adora's attention as the blonde smiled.

"Yeah, we'll have a daughter" she chuckled looking at Catra "Marazz"

"Marazz?" she avoided flinching as Adora pressured her hand "Your idea?"

"Too obvious?" Catra chimed in with a short anxious laugh.

"Please, you would have chosen something like Lionela"

Adora laughed "Close enough actuall-y!" she doubled back as a scream escaped her lips.

"Okay, I'm ready" the man stepped in giving instructions as more staff came into the room bringing everything he needed.

The moments that followed were as eternal as they were incredibly quick. Catra just kept on holding Adora's hand and saying soothing things as her wife kept on searching for her eyes, seeking comfort and strength as she went through labor. And just then, in the middle of the confusion and commotion, they heard it, a soft whimper, a cry that forced them to leave everything else aside and focus on only her…their baby.

The physician quickly wrapped the baby presenting her to their mothers as both breathlessly gazed at her "Congratulations, it's-"

"A girl" Adora mumbled as she laid eyes on her for the first time, holding her against her chest "Catra…she's beautiful" she barely managed to look away to find Catra contemplating the kitten with mesmerized eyes.

Her fluffy ears were bent down, eyes tightly shut as her little fists tried to rub them. She was as pale as Adora except for the pard lines that ran on her arms and legs and her short mane was

radiantly golden but for the sides of her face in which the locks were dark brown, framing her face as Catra's old face guard did.

"Hey, darling" Adora mumbled "Hi Marazz" she cooed "I'm mom" she snuggled close carefully, as she realized how tiny and frail she seemed.

"H-Hey, kiddo" Catra carefully reached to caress her face and at the touch their little girl opened her eyes showing her own miss-matched orbits. One radiantly blue as Adora's, the other a deep shade of the same color with a golden spark on it.

Catra excitedly turned to Adora "She has both our eyes" she smiled widely, her tail swaying as her wife laughed sweetly.

"She's perfect"

"We'll clean her up and then you can stay with her all day long, okay?" the physician

said softly taking the baby.

Adora reluctantly let go as Catra carefully combed her hair back cleaning the sweat from her wife's face "You did amazing, love" she mumbled.

Adora sighed looking up at her eyes "We both did" she reached for her hand "we did that, we have a daughter"

"We do" she smiled leaning down to kiss her.

A knock from the door announced some visitors.

"Hey, guys" Bow appeared next to his kids "Glimmer told us the baby was born?" he smiled expectantly.

"Girl" Adora smirked.

"Yes!" Angella jumped with her arms stretched to the sky.

"I'm still the only boy!" Saber cheered.

"Excuse me" Bow laughed.

"You are an adult, you don't count, dad" he explained as they reached the bed.

"Can we see her?" Angella sat on Catra's legs.

"She'll be here any minute" she nodded.

"Are you okay, Adora?" Bow asked softly.

"Just tired" she nodded.

"What's in the water that the two births in this palace happen to occur in the middle of the night" he joked.

"That's Bright Moon to you" Glimmer said from the door walking next to physician that carefully laid Marazz back in Adora's arms as the twins eagerly tried to take a peek at the newborn.

"She has your ears, Aunty Cat!"

"And your tail!"

"She does" Catra laughed softly caressing one of the ears in question while Marazz yawned leaning into the touch.

"She's so cute!" both kids turned to their dad as he melted over the image.

Adora snorted remembering how he made that same expression when Catra first joined one of their missions.

"What's her name?"

"Marazz"

Arrow wrinkled his nose "Why?"

"It's the combination of two names that mean something to me"

"To us" Catra interjected "I'm in debt with those two as well" she tilted her head and Adora smiled.

"Just like your sister has Grandma's name" Bow explained patting his shoulder "It's to honor them, since they were so great, they have some big boots to fill"

"But she's so tiny" Saber whispered looking at her.

"Don't worry, we'll take care of her" Angella assured "We'll look out for each other"

"Thank you" Adora smiled at how heartedly and confidently she proclaimed that, she knew once she had made a similar promise and after a long journey she had been able to uphold it.

"Okay, we should really let your Aunties rest now" Glimmer cut in softly "The sun won't come up for another couple of hours or so"

"Can't we stay? What if she needs us?" Saber intervened

"Well manage the fort for now, don't worry" Catra said ruffling his hair "we'll see you later, I'm pretty sure Adora will need a hearty breakfast"

"I'll let the chef know that" Bow smirked as he tapped his kids on the back gently driving them to the door before looking back, a genuine gesture on his face "Congratulations"

The new mothers smiled back "Thank you"

Glimmer knelt down planting a kiss on Adora's forehead "You did amazing during labor. And you did it, you brought your baby into the world, cero risks, she's save, sound and in perfect health"

Adora released the tension she had been carrying for so long once she realized Glimmer's words were true. She knew that she would still worry about her baby, about her safety and upbringing, but for now, the greatest victory was to hold her in arms.

"Thank you, Glimmer"

She grinned happily before turning to Catra and holding her tightly in an embrace, no words needed as she cuddled her. They knew how to say so much through just that action alone.

Then she let go "She's lovely" the Queen said "I can't believe your kitten is finally here. I'm happy beyond words to describe it" she gazed at both "Now enjoy this moment and if you need anything just call" she smiled.

"Thanks, Sparkles"

And in a swift motion, she was no longer there and the three of them were for the first time alone together.

Adora laid a kiss on top of Marazz head and then her nose and another on her cheek. Tears of joy dripping to her chin as she showered with all her affection their newborn. She then gazed up at Catra "Ready to hold her?"

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Adora carefully tucked Marazz into Catra's arms as she, not for the last time, kissed her forehead longingly.

"This trip couldn't come at a worst time" Adora complained stretching her finger for Marazz to grab as she happily giggled making her mother smile at the sight.

"It will be less than a day" Catra said soothingly, rocking Marazz gently, tickling her little stomach.

"I know" she grumbled "I just wished someone else could take care of it" she dropped her shoulders pouting "she's barely three months old"

Catra chuckled "Who would have thought that you'll go from being eager to turn into She-Ra again, to complete reluctant to do it"

Adora blushed embarrassed but didn't allow her the satisfaction "I wouldn't mind if it weren't so far away" she countered before exhaling "I know it's ridiculous that I am so upset for not seeing her until tomorrow but… It's just… it will be the first time I'm away, even from you. We usually take on the world together and now I'm going on my own…I don't want to make a habit out of this, to put She-Ra above our family"

Catra leaned in minding not to squish her daughter as she kissed Adora's lips "The fact that you realize those feelings makes it perfectly clear that you won't" she said softly "It will be awkward to find a balance between answering the call and raising a kid, but you aren't doing it alone, neither are you walking away from us" she emphasized showing her wedding token "remember, you are my home, no matter the distance, I know you are by my side and Marazz's. Today we got unlucky that only you can fix this plague that's taking over the valley, but Bow is going with you and Perfuma and Scorpia will be there to help. As soon as you wave your magic sword and a rainbow comes out of it or whatever, the mission is done and you get to come back to Bright Moon. Simple as that"

Adora sighed a bit more calmly leaning on her shoulder gazing protectively over her daughter "You are right" she said "and… thank you" she mumbled knowing Catra understood fully well the deep fears that laid underneath and had put those doubts at ease. She wasn't leaving, she wasn't abandoning them and she wasn't going to be She-Ra before being Adora "I'll call tonight before you put her to bed" she added.

"We'll be waiting for it" she smiled knowing the time for her departure had arrived "Now go save the day. The sooner you leave, the sooner you can be back. I bet Bow already finished packing his tech, he must be waiting for you already"

Adora giggled softly "Right" she leaned down pressing a kiss to Marazz's nose "I'll see you tomorrow little one" she said softly looking up at Catra before pressing a tender kiss, one that meant to say all the things she couldn't and Catra understood each of them perfectly as she kissed back. No farewell needed, because that was no goodbye.

So when they walked to the gates of the palace and parted on different ways, as Glimmer and the twins waved energetically back and forward at Bow, the two women just exchanged glances and nodded.

***

Catra sat down at the chair in the corner of her room as she held the bottle of milk for Marazz to lazily drink from it, half asleep already.

Melog walked in, ears tilted down as if asking permission, Catra smirked tapping her leg for the feline to rush at her side and sniff the baby, turning its mane a radiant shade of blue as it licked behind Marazz's ears snuggling her. Catra giggled before looking up at the entrance knowing fully well who was waiting on the other side.

"You can come in, Little Sparkle. Mar-mar is about to take a nap"

Angella emerged from behind the door with a huge smile, rushing to their side kneeling down to gaze at the baby "Can I help you with the bottle?" she asked eagerly.

"Of course, come sit down" she made room for her as Angella carefully took over looking lovingly at Marazz.

Then a second head peeked in as Saber joined, not minding to ask or anything, he just walked up to them and sat next to Melog

in the floor looking up at them.

"Why does she sleep so much?" he asked caressing Melog.

"She's still too little, babies need a lot of sleep" she explained "Well, in your case you were a bit of a riot, while one slept the other cried and then you would switch it up, so your parents were usually up all night every night"

Both snickered finding that incredibly funny exchanging looks, sometimes it appeared as though they spoke a language of their own.

"Hey Aunty" Arrow gazed up looking at her with questioning eyes "We are Marazz's cousins, right?"

"Cousins?" Catra repeated, she had heard the term before but couldn't quite recall which relationship by blood it explained "I… I'm not sure what that one means" she admitted tilting her ears low. She always tried to be as open as possible when she talked to them, so she wasn't embarrassed to receive those incredulous looks that soon turned understanding.

"Cousins are…" Angella traced back "the babies of your sibling" she tried "like if Great Aunt Castaspella had had kids, then they would have been mom's cousins"

"Ow" her ears spiked back up as she considered it, thinking of how she felt about Bow and Glimmer, a smile spreading on her face "Then yes, you are cousins" she nodded "Not by blood, I guess, since neither Adora or I are related to your parents, but cousins nonetheless"

The twins smiled brightly among them "Yes!" they cheered to themselves "we can have our own club!"

"Our own alliance!" Angella cheered as well.

"We'll protect her, don't worry" Saber added scratching gently behind her tiny ears.

"I know you will" Catra smiled sweetly "and I'm really glad she'll have you to grow up with" she added "As a kid all I really had was Adora…and that made all the difference" she admitted.

"You've know Aunty Dora for that long?"

"Yeah, sometimes it felt like I knew her better than I knew myself" she tilted her head looking back "Having her meant I wasn't alone, it was us against the world"

"Mar won't ever be alone" Angella grabbed Catra's hand "Promise"

***

Catra hated to admit how awful it felt to be alone in bed. She missed having Adora by her side, the warmth of her body pressing into her own, their small conversations before drifting to slumber, the lazy caresses Adora would provide petting her gently, evoking her purring.

They had talked a few hours ago to say goodnight and by the update on the situation, her magic had been successful on curing the land, they just had to make sure that by early morning the plague had stopped spreading and that everything was back to normal so they could head back home. In a matter of hours Adora would be back in Bright Moon.

Catra exhaled and then heard the slight movement that began to increase until eventually Marazz began crying. Catra stood up immediately going to the crib, taking her in arms and wrapping her in Adora's blanket.

"Hey kitten" she mumbled rocking her ever so gently "what's wrong?" she asked checking if she needed a change or if she was hungry, but neither was the case. So she just kept on swaying her in arms to absolutely no avail. Marazz kept on moving, looking

around and crying again. She was usually a rather calm baby and a bundle of joy, so seeing her so upset was nothing short of alarming.

"Your tummy hurts?" Catra rubbed gently only successfully calming her for brief instants before she sobbed again "Sweetie, what is it?" she held her closer to her chest leaning down, pressing her forehead into her own, there was no temperature. As they were face to face, Marazz mismatched eyes looked into the ones of her mother and transmitted a kind of sadness that ached deep into Catra's heart.

"Ow" realization hit leaving her breathless "I miss her too" she mumbled whipping away all the tears in her face as a new batch started to overflow her eyes.

Catra couldn't do much but keep on walking from one side of the room to another, mumbling reassuring things, hoping Marazz would fall asleep eventually. She was half minded to call Adora but something in her entrains stopped her. Adora felt guilty enough about going to that mission, seeing how upset their baby was would only make her feel worse and more reluctant to go on future occasions. So she might as well have to solve this one on her own…or not.

A knock caught her attention, a voice barely above the level of Marazz crying "Catra?"

"Glimmer?" she asked turning to the door walking towards "I'm sorry, did we wake you?"

"It's okay, I remember how the twins were" she assured as Catra opened finding the Queen wrapped messily on a robe, her puffy pastel hair chaotically styled to a side. Catra wanted to make a comment but was sure her own appearance wasn't better.

"How's the little one?" Glimmer asked as Marazz kept on sobbing "I've never hear her cry so much"

Catra held a timid smile "I know"

"Does she needs medicine? I can call the physician to check on her" she said ready to puff out of there.

"No, it's not that, I've checked" she assured, she knew perhaps a little bit too well about symptoms and sickness, she had learned how to recognize them to keep herself safe "She…misses Adora" she said gently turning around back into the room inviting Glimmer in.

"Oh" the Queen shut the door behind, understanding there was not much she could do about it "Have you called her?"

Catra shook her head "That's my last resort. I don't want her to worry. Adora being herself might actually run all the way here if she knew" she chuckled to herself "she crossed the galaxy to reach me, she would definitely try to make it back home for Marazz to stop crying" she gazed down at the baby with loving eyes "So, I'll handle this, so she doesn't have to carry the weight of the world on her shoulders"

Glimmer sighed, she wanted to refute, but knew Catra had a point. She was at least reassured that Catra knew she could reach out to her wife, not afraid to ask for help, just concerned to overwhelm the blonde warrior.

"Neither should you" Glimmer offered stretching her arms "May I?" she asked with a tender smile.

Catra gazed at the gesture before understanding "Of course" she carefully laid the kitten into her aunt's arms.

"Hello, little lady" the Queen said with a feigned formal accent rocking her in arms but the crying did not subside "Why I know you miss mommy Adora, but she'll be back soon" she cooed walking in short circles "It breaks me to see you so sad, little one" she leaned down to kiss her nose, managing for the first time that night for Marazz to ease up, not ceasing the crying, but dimming it down "Aww, is that what this is?" Glimmer chuckled to herself

cuddling the baby against her face laying another kiss on her forehead "You big softy" she caressed her cheek.

"H-how did you calm her?" Catra asked aloof, her browns furrowed. Glimmer turned to her with a teasing smile.

"Don't get jealous because she likes me better" she mocked carelessly before noticing a shimmering reflection in Catra's eyes. Glimmer dropped the smile and walked towards "It's nothing to do with me" she assured "She just misses Adora's affection"

Catra felt her frown grow deeper and Glimmer realized Catra really couldn't tell.

"The kisses" she explained gently "Adora kisses her all the time" she said "whenever she has her in arms she kisses her nose, her cheeks, her head…" she listed "it just calmed her to feel the familiar gesture" she assured "Come on, you try it" she walked towards.

Catra took Marazz looking at her tired reddened eyes and felt rather nervous and a bit helpless "What if it doesn't help?"

"Then…you purr, I guess" she offered smirking "that's your way to show affection" she shrugged nonchalantly.

Catra smiled back before looking at her baby "Hey kitten" she whispered leaning down, pressing her lips to her head and resting there, laying soft kisses as Marazz slowly calmed down, breathing in in small hiccups and curling into herself. Catra smiled and began purring for good measure, the combination seemed to be the thing she needed to finally start closing her eyes, tail curled around herself, a gesture she tended to do when she felt comfortable enough to sleep. Then she gazed up at her and began to slowly blink, the clearest sign of trust a feline could offer, she felt safe… and that alone could make Catra's heart overflow with love.

"Sorry it took me so long to know that's what you needed" she whispered swaying her placidly, luring her to sleep.

Glimmer smiled keeping her tone low "See? You managed perfectly" she rubbed a hand on her back "she just wanted some love, she's such an affectionate baby" she chuckled "it's kind of surprising how much she likes to be held and cuddled"

Catra shrugged shyly "I wish I could blame that trait on Adora but…" she left the rest unsaid, instead soaring through other thoughts as words escaped her mouth "I'll make sure she never cries over wanting to feel loved ever again" she mumbled holding her close, her tone more vulnerable than she would have like to show.

Glimmer gazed at her knowing something deeper was troubling her "Is…is that how you felt?" she ventured to ask "as…as a kid?" she added careful to perceive her every reaction.

Catra shrugged uncomfortably "Something like that" she avoided Glimmer's piercing eyes by keeping her own attentive at her daughter "as kids whenever I got hurt Adora would try to kiss it better, all the bruises, cuts, burns…but…as soon as we began training, displaying any kind of weakness was severely punished and the little gestures of affection began to cease and we started to only show care through roughhousing" she shrugged "But sometimes I really missed them, the kisses" she admitted before thinking back to other events, an amused chuckle escaping her lips "I think the first show of affection I ever received past my childhood was when you kissed my cheek at the ship"

Glimmer was speechless, she recalled that event of course, but couldn't dare imagine that would be it "W-Wait, but what about Adora?" she interjected, her expression confused and conflicted "you spent your teenage years together"

Catra shrugged casually "We were probably about the twins' age when she last tried to heal me through a peck in the cheek" she scoffed focusing on Marazz "And tonight I couldn't even tell that's what my daughter wanted because during the worst of times, I would have to check over my shoulder to make sure no one was around before daring to hold Adora's hand" she concluded with a

silent sigh "So, I'll make sure that she doesn't have to cry over it ever again" Catra repeated kissing her nose as now Marazz was calmly snuggled in her arms.

Glimmer smiled softly seeing how much Catra deeply cared about her daughter, how she was willing to go through whatever change and growth to be the best version of herself for the sake of her baby.

And just then a yawn cut through her purring as she covered her mouth, she hadn't slept up to that point, previously because she was awkwardly lying in bed without Adora there and then because Marazz felt the same way and decided to express it. And now both were right about ready to call it a night.

"You should try to sleep now that she's calm" Glimmer mumbled patting her back.

"The moment I put her down she'll cry again" Catra shook her head "she's not that heavy of a sleeper, unlike Adora" she added with a scoff.

"Okay then, how about you just sit in your bed with her?" Glimmer asked.

"Is-is that safe?" Catra tilted her ears down "What if I fall asleep and drop her?"

Glimmer smiled knowing the jitters of a first time mom "Come on, I'll keep you some company until she's deeper into sleep" she sat down on the opposite side of the mattress.

Catra laid on top of the covers making sure to keep a secure hold on Marazz as she sat down "It's this okay? Should I put a pillow down in case-?"

"Catra, you are fine" she cut her short with a grin "Besides, don't all cats land on their feet?" she teased winning a smile out of the other woman.

"If it were purely my genetics then sure, but have you seen how often Adora face plants?"

Glimmer had to drown down her laughter to keep it from waking up the baby "Fair" she admitted "Well, if you fall asleep, I'll make sure to set her in the crib" she offered "honestly, my kids were far worse at sleeping through the night, I can stay up for hours, you don't have to worry"

Catra actually exhaled a bit more relieved "Thanks"

"No problem" she readjusted into the bed knowing she still had the better part of the night ahead of her, so might as well get comfortable.

Catra kept on purring for Marazz to know she still had her in arms, an occasional yawn cutting through her rhythmical sound and every time that happened, Marazz tried to open her eyes to look up at Catra, making sure she was still there, once seeing her, she would close her eyes again.

Catra didn't mind that, she loved the way her daughter would look at her as if thought nothing bad in the world could reach her as long as she was by her side, she guesses that was the feeling a mother should provide.

Once sure she had drifted back to sleep, Catra turned towards Glimmer who was considerably more alert and awake than her.

"Hey Sparkles?"

"Yeah?"

"Do you…miss Bow?"

Glimmer raised a brown.

"Tonight, I mean. Not having him next to you…?" she traced back, her voice growing faint at the end, perhaps a bit self-conscious. Other princesses tended to point out she could be clingy towards

Adora, they meant it as playful teasing, but once the joke came two too many times, Catra had begun to feel embarrassed about it.

Glimmer sighed looking up, a smile on her lips as he crossed her thoughts "I do but I know he's safe and doing something important. Besides, I'll see him tomorrow by lunch, so it's bearable" she shrugged coolly "there are days in the kingdom our schedule is so full that I don't see him for hours and hours, even when we are in the same place, so this is actually not that different"

Catra hummed a response turning back to Marazz.

Glimmer smiled softly "You miss her that much?"

Catra felt her face go warm "No" she shrugged averting her eyes making it all the more obvious. Glimmer rolled her eyes knowing how prideful she could be but decided not to call her out on it.

"The first times I had to leave the kingdom to visit other lands and settle treaties however, I missed him terribly" she commented noticing her ears spike up "I would call him and talk for hours until we both fell asleep. It became easier later on and it was kind of exciting to get to see him again after a bit of time, it made our reunion just a tad more special" she chuckled running fingers through her short hair "Sometimes it's harder to be the one that stays, though, because you can feel the empty space, the missing piece, contrary to when you are the one that leaves and everything is new and you have something to do or accomplish" she stated "So yeah, today I did felt his absence more so than other times. How can I not? He's always right there next to me. He is primordial to my day-to-day" she turned to her "Just as Adora is for you"

Catra allowed the empathy in her gesture to comfort her "Thanks" she noticed the knowing smirk and looked away "Just don't tell Mermista"

"Please, she once cried when Seahawk went to a trip and set a boat on fire without her"

"Seriously?" she smirked widely "Are you sure it was not Seahawk who cried?"

"Oh, he cried alright, after Mermista was done dealing with him"

Both laughed in the quiet of the night, perhaps a bit too loud for the tiny cat ears that picked on the sudden shift.

"Ow, sorry, sorry, cutie" Glimmer mumbled hoping to ease Marazz as she shifted trying to cover her ears in an impossibly adorable fashion.

And then Catra just smiled down at her kitten and softly tuned into a sweet melody, singing for her in calming tones, in a soothing lullaby. Marazz quickly calmed down turning towards her mother enjoying the harmonious display, already used to hearing her chant for her. Glimmer however, was rendered speechless as she heard Catra sing for the first time. She hadn't imagined the Horde soldier had such a hidden talent, one she never publicly displayed. How she had gone so long without Catra at least performing once in the livingroom or next to the fireplace was beyond her.

When her voice struck the last cord, Marazz was already into deep slumber. Catra smiled pleased and carefully settled her in the middle of the bed deciding that night she would sleep right next to her. When she gazed up at Glimmer she found the Queen dumbstruck.

"What?" Catra asked before chuckling "Cat got your tongue?"

"I've-I've never heard you sing before"

Catra shrugged nonchalant "I'm sure I hum once in a while"

"No, Catra I mean…you can sing" she said earnestly "You sounded lovely" she admitted "I guess I didn't know this side of you. So

much later and you still have tricks up your sleeve. I wish I had learned this sooner, you should sing more often"

Catra suddenly felt flushed "I-I just do it to help her sleep and occasionally for Adora" she shook her head "I'm not really up for shows"

"Pity" Glimmer smiled softly knowing her resistance came from her upbringing, she could imagine singing would be banned in a place called the Fright Zone "Because it's a real delight"

Catra felt her ears bend down showing her embarrassment "Whatever"

Glimmer chuckled redirecting her attention to Marazz "Is she settled for the night?"

Catra gazed at the sleepy figure "I think so" she laid over her side, rubbing Marazz back gently.

"Are you putting her back in the crib?"

"No" she smirked "I pretty much wake up in the same position I slept in, so I'm sure I won't roll"

"Then make sure she doesn't either" Glimmer grabbed a pillow putting it on the other side, deciding to stay a moment longer until she was sure they would be okay for the rest of the night.

Catra was soon giving into sleep but kept on fighting it, opening her eyes with a lot of effort every time Marazz would shift or exhale too loudly.

"It's fine, you can rest now" Glimmer assured in a soft tone.

"I just want to make sure she knows I'm here"

Glimmer sighed amusedly stretching her arm towards Catra, taking her palm and softly placing it on top of Marazz's back "There, she can feel that you are right here and if she starts to cry

or moves to much, you'll be able to tell" she tilted her head "Better?"

Catra smiled, hiding her face into the pillow "Yeah, better"

"Good" she was about to remove her own palm when Catra gazed at her with those iridescent eyes, hoping or perhaps pleading mutedly to keep her hand there, holding hers.

Glimmer smiled weakly and obliged with a faint nod allowing the end of the night to pass them by as the wee hours began to creep through the horizon. It was probably an hour past midnight now by Glimmer's calculations and in the quiet of it all, she could hear their passive breathings, knowing that the chaos had passed and now only peace ensured. She was about to slip away and head back to her room when she felt Catra's hand tight around her own, her blue eye tiredly trying to focus on her as her drowsy voice cut thought the silence.

"Stay" her tone faintly carried through the room. Glimmer noticed that frail hope in her demeanor and notice just how much it meant to her not to feel such loneliness.

So she leaned in kissing her forehead "You don't have to dwell over wanting to feel loved ever again either" She mumbled caressing behind her ear before laying back down offering a smile and looking into her eyes before closing her own.

Both were alone in a way that night, but neither had to feel lonely, not ever and not again.

Chapter 12

Chapter Notes

I did an effort to check the grammar and spelling with a program XP
Hopefully it will be a smooth reading!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Bull's eye!" Saber shouted victorious "That's three in a row"

"You are getting better every day," Bow said impressed by his son's talent.

"I mean, we did name him Arrow and you're teaching him Bow, so what else could we expect?" Glimmer teased.

"His second name is Saber, might as well hand him a sword" Catra added sited at the picnic blanket while Marazz tried to crawl to the grass with Angella following her every move.

"I could offer some classes" Adora added mockingly taking a bite out of her sandwich.

"Can I learn?" the boy asked missing out on the jokes, his eyes round and sparkly.

"Maybe when you are a bit older?" he suggested nervously, Bow had learned behind his dads' backs but couldn't quite bring himself to agree to the dangerous activity.

"You let him shoot pointy projectiles and are worried about a sword?" Catra teased.

"What-? Well, that's different!" he pouted.

"We'll turn six in two weeks!" Arrow countered "That's old enough, right? Please?"

Bow turned to his right to where the others were enjoying the meal "Glimmer?"

His wife snorted "Are you seriously playing that card with me?"

"You are the Queen" he shrugged pleadingly.

Glimmer rolled her eyes before using the voice she usually saved for meetings and treaties "It's a big commitment. You'd start with the basics and wooden swords and you will have to do what you are told, no shortcuts and no doing anything risky, if you disobey, then it's over, deal?"

"I can do that!" he said eagerly.

"Another crisis avoided by Bright Moon's righteous leader, Sparkles" Catra laughed before Glimmer threw a bread roll at her.

Adora turned to Angella "Do you want to learn as well?" she offered, but the girl shook her head casually.

"No thanks, Aunty" she kept on playing with Marazz.

"Okay, if you change your mind you are welcome to join us" Adora smirked before dropping the topic.

"Your Majesty?" a messenger walked in "the preparations are ready but we still have to discuss the logistics" he handed her a rather large scroll and Glimmer did her best not to sigh.

"Thank you, I'll make sure to run it by my dad" she put it away "for now, I'll enjoy my noon"

"Of course" he bowed apologetically taking his leave.

"Is there anything we can help you with?" Adora asked frowning at the to-do list, she recalled her first experience with royalty formalities when she made a battle plan for Frosta's Princess Prom.

"Yeah, after all, it's because of us you are doing this" Catra added.

"It's under control" Glimmer assured "It's just planning" she waved her hands around "so enjoy this for now because as soon as you rightfully accept part of Bright Moon you'll have to take part on all the diplomatic decisions and meetings"

"Hum, too late to get cold feet?" Catra smirked self-satisfied of getting a reaction out of her.

"You are impossible"

"We'll be more than happy to take part" Adora threw an arm around Catra "once the ceremony officially bounds us with magic to Bright Moon"

"We are really excited," Bow said earnestly. The two monarchs had allowed them to take time and space to think through the impact of accepting the land, but now that Marazz was here, there was no point in dwelling over it, they would stay to raise their daughter next to their friends; to their family.

"I just need to do some sigils with my dad, it's a whole ritual that takes about a day, but it's basically the only thing missing before you oblige in front of the kingdom to take your responsibilities"

Adora shrugged nonchalant "It can't be that different from being a public figure as She-Ra"

"Pretty much the same thing" Bow nodded.

Catra swallowed the knot on her throat, she still feared a backlash, that maybe there would be uprisings and riots because she was taking over the land she once tried to conquer. But as she looked around she had to remind herself that all those nasty looks and rumors behind her back were in the past. People had grown to know her and despite all, like her. After all, she had spent the better part of the decade traveling the space to restore magic and whenever she was able, reconstruct Etheria. Besides, having the

whole princess alliance vouching for her gave her case legitimacy. Bright Moon and its people had become her new society, her kin.

"Well, it's just three days until then" Bow sat down next to his wife kissing her "should we make a decree before losing all our power?"

"Like no raiding the kitchen after midnight?" she teased looking at them as they blushed.

"You know about that?" Adora shrugged embarrassed as she was typically the one leading the expeditions.

"Please, you are not nearly as discrete as you think" Glimmer turned to her kids "and we know you have partners in crime"

The twins snapped their eyes wide open gazing at each other as if saying 'if you don't say anything, neither will I'.

Bow chuckled loudly "I mean, it's our bad, we taught Adora how to avoid the staff the first week she came here"

"And Catra didn't need any training, she basically sniffed out where they stacked the cookies"

They all shared a laugh out of it as they continued to enjoy the rare event of a day to themselves. After diligently working, they had managed to earn a bit of free time and they were going to make the best out of it.

"Where's Marazz?" Angella covered her own face "there she is" she peeked out again winning a giggle out of the baby that marveled at the trick.

"You are not tired, Little Sparkle?" Catra inquired "You have been taking care of her throughout lunch, do you need a break?"

"It's okay, I like it" she smiled back at her "and she likes the games too"

"You are really good at babysitting" Bow ruffled her pastel hair that was now longer than her mother's.

"I'm not babysitting, we are spending time together" Angella answered matter-of-factly, which only served to melt the grownups' hearts.

Adora sighed wistfully "I hope we raise our little one nearly as good as you raised your kids" she mumbled "you must be really proud" she gazed at Bow as well.

The couple exchanged a glance sharing that knowing look "We are honored to call them ours" Bow smirked softly.

Glimmer answered the gesture leaning in to steal another peck with her eyes close which proved to be the wrong move as she lost her balance clinging into his shirt.

"Whoa there, you okay?" Bow asked helping her steady herself.

"Yeah, sorry, I just…my head went spinning for a moment"

"I know the power of a kiss like that" Adora smiled smugly turning to Catra as she avoided eye contact folding her ears down embarrassed.

Glimmer chuckled shortly "I must be just a bit tired" she waved her hand dismissing the little mishap.

"You need to go lay down?"

Glimmer shook her head no "We are all together, I don't want to miss out on this" she leaned against his chest.

But the moment was going to be cut short anyway, just not by something they would have expected.

"Where's Marazz?" Angie asked once again hiding behind her palms and while the baby was waiting with excitement to see her

once more, the only thing that appeared before her eyes were the dust of sparkles as Angella disappeared into thin air.

All eyes fell on where she had previously been, but the first to react was Marazz as she began to cry at the absence of the older girl. She had teleported for the first time. And she still hadn't come back.

Bow turned to Glimmer with huge worried eyes, he didn't even have to say a thing, his wife was already half the way gone "I'm on it" she teleported too, jumping across the castle in search of her daughter. She knew she couldn't have gone far, as her magic was still young, but she didn't want the girl to go through the experience alone, she recalled her own and she just knew she had to be by her side, no matter what.

"Where's my sister?" Arrow asked at the verge of tears noticing how aback the adults seemed.

"She just used magic, she must be in the castle" Bow took the time to kneel down and make sure his son was alright.

Adora picked up Marazz trying to soothe her as well "We'll help you look"

"She probably went to a familiar place," Bow said "she wouldn't go to a room she doesn't know"

"Saber" Catra called "Do you remember the gift we gave your sister last year?" she asked "the tracker, do you know where it is?"

"Good idea" Bow caught her drift "come on, let's go look for it" he grabbed Arrow's hand going to their room.

Catra tilted her chin up closing her eyes trying to find a scent "I'm going to look too, okay?" she said to Adora "Can you stay with little Mara?"

The blonde nodded "As soon as you have news" she left the rest unsaid.

"Yeah, I'll keep you updated" she gazed around "why don't you stay here? She might come back"

Adora nodded, it was a sound plan "Go"

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Catra turned left, then right, walked down a hall just to find another dead end. It was not that she wasn't able to find her niece; on the contrary, every trail was the right one, the problem was that the girl was still popping in and out of every room. Angella wasn't able to control when to stop each teleportation and that alone would make it hard to track her, even with the device.

Catra ran as fast as she could once she found a strong trail to follow and just as she reached the door, she saw Glimmer in the middle of the room as a lightshow carried on.

"Mom!" Angella cried as she jumped from one side of the room to another, tears running down her face.

"I'm here, sweetheart, don't worry"

"I'm scared"

"I know, sweetie, I know" her voice was frail as well while trying to sound soothing as she followed her trajectory, predicating her next move to then embrace her tight. Both teleported just a couple of more times before ending on their knees cuddled right in the center of it all.

Angella hugged her mother with might, crying helplessly against her chest "I couldn't stop" she sobbed "I don't want to disappear again" true fear ringed in her voice.

"I'm not letting go" Glimmer assured "I've got you. Where you go, I'll go and I'll bring you right back" she promised "I'm right here with you"

Angella muffled another cry into Glimmer's shoulder "I tried, I really tried to come back"

"I know" she stroked her hair lovingly pressing kisses.

"I'm sorry" Angella hiccupped between sobs.

Glimmer hugged her tighter "You didn't do anything wrong, sweetie" she let go just enough to cup her face whipping the tears "your magic just bloomed" she smiled tenderly "It's truly a beautiful thing"

"I don't want it to," she said brokenly biting into her lower lip to prevent crying further.

"I know it's scary" Glimmer mumbled "but you won't have to learn it alone" she cuddled her back in arms rocking her gently as she would do when she was a newborn "I'm going to help you every single step of the way" she gazed down at her reddened eyes that looked at her as if she was the only light left in a dark world "Besides, imagine how thrilled your grandfather is going to be when you tell him!" she smirked "He'll love to teach you, all the things he couldn't show me himself" she tickled her stomach softly earning a faint giggle "We'll have so much fun together"

Angella smiled weakly, her eyes didn't have utter fear in them anymore, and a glimmering hint of hope took its place instead. She breathed in more calmly closing her eyes to rest under her mother's chin, where she felt protected. The magic had consumed all of her energy, now she was just exhausted.

Glimmer hummed a lullaby easing her daughter, luring her to sleep. On the opposite door, Bow and Arrow appeared rushing to the middle, both breathless and with worried expressions.

"Is she okay?" Bow knelt next to them.

Glimmer made a motion for him to keep his voice down "She is but so many jumps left her sleepy" she noticed Angella was already breathing evenly "she needs her rest"

"When is she waking up?" Arrow asked frowning, he seemed uneasy.

"In a couple of hours, maybe" Glimmer mumbled back reaching a hand to cup his cheek "Are you okay, sweetheart?"

Saber sniffled whipping his nose with the sleeve, standing straight "Yes"

Bow ruffled his hair "He was really determined to help me look"

"That's our little knight" Glimmer smiled at him noticing he still fought the tears "It's okay if you were scared, sweetie. It was a scary thing. It's alright if you need to cry"

Arrow nodded letting his façade slip away as the tears did the same.

Bow hugged him tight "There we go champ, we all worried about your sister" he kissed his head "She's going to be alright" he turned back to her "I'll put her to bed"

Glimmer nodded allowing him to take her in arms, she was so worn out she didn't even move at the sudden shift.

"I'll be right there," Glimmer said standing as well "I just need a moment; I did a lot of jumps too"

"Do you need help?"

"No, I'm okay, love. Take Angie and Saber, I'll be right behind you"

"Okay," he leaned to kiss her gently before turning around. And just then, when they were out of her eyesight, she felt the first teardrop down her chin, then the next and then a whole flood.

She crumbled to her knees holding her sides with one arm tightly wrapped around and the other hand muffling her cries.

Just then Catra felt herself coming back to her senses. She had stayed behind the door, unmoving, mutedly, just gazing as one of the walls would, perhaps paralyzed by the whole scene up to this point. But seeing Glimmer break down like that snapped her back to reality. She had been intruding and her insides turned at that thought, she had no right to have been spying but leaving her now didn't felt right either. So she walked to her as she was facing the other way, unaware of her approach, so Catra stood awkwardly there before kneeling down "Sparkles?" she called softly laying a hand over her shoulder, startling her as she washed away the tears.

"Cat-Catra" she didn't turn to meet her eyes and Catra knew that was something she herself had done in the past when she wasn't ready to be faced. So she wrapped her arms around her and held her tight, allowing her to cry it all out, she wasn't there to stop her from it.

Glimmer slowly ducked her chin as each breath hitched in her throat until she was full-on crying again, wrapping her arms over the ones that held her close.

"I-I was so scared" she chocked out "I couldn't find her, I didn't know where she was" she admitted brokenly hiding her face.

"You found her" Catra offered in a consoling tone "she's okay, she has you"

Glimmer pressed her eyes shut until they hurt "The-the first time I teleported away I ended at the base of the Crystal, dangling at the edge of it" she traced back "My…my mom flew all the way there and took me in arms, cradling me as I cried. She promised me she would never let me fall" she felt her heart sink deeper as she clenched a hand to her chest "I miss her so much"

Catra felt her heart ache and torn in unimaginable pain. Guilt and remorse washed over her in ways that haven't in the longest of time "I'm sorry" she whispered, feeling her throat go raspy and dry as those feeling that boiled inside "I'm sorry" she repeated, before shutting her jaw tight, preventing tears from forming, she was not about to break down, she had no right to. She felt like fleeing, her arms loosening the grip as she tried to let go, but Glimmer held on tighter into her, still facing away.

"Don't go" she pleaded "Stay"

Catra inhaled sharply and found her resolve to stand her ground, hugging her once more, as tightly as she could, wishing she could be the armor to shield her friend from all the pain, from all the hurt, especially the one inflicted by her own hand.

Nothing else was said.

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Marazz's ears were twitching now and then as she inspected her surroundings while bubbles drifted near her. She was still getting used to the idea of the tub, but Catra had the patience and determination to stay with her in it for as long as the kitten could stand it.

Adora walked in "How is it going?"

Catra looked over at her with a smile "Hey Adora" she waited for her wife to sit close by "We are doing great" she nodded gazing at their baby rather than looking for Adora's eyes.

"Glimmer and Micah are doing the ritual right now; it should be ready for tomorrow's ceremony"

Catra shrugged sinking down in the water to minimize the gesture.

"Are you nervous?"

"Yeah…, something like that" Catra answered trying to avoid the topic, but Adora leaned in kissed her head.

"It's okay, we'll be there together"

"I was thinking…" Catra traced back trying to sound casual and indifferent "can't you be the one to accept it?" she inquired barely managing to make eye contact "you are She-Ra, so it would be more meaningful that way, I'll just be the right hand"

Adora frowned, not out of confusion as it usually was the case, but she seemed rather…furious "They didn't give the land to She-Ra, they are giving it to us, both of us" she emphasized.

Catra wanted to backtrack but knew that she had struck a nerve in there "forget I said it"

"No" Adora sentenced severely "you just willingly proposed the two things you have fought against for several years" she held her gaze with her intense blue eyes; if Catra wasn't mistaken they even burst pure magical blue for a moment "I am acting as Adora and you are not about to put yourself as second best"

Catra swallowed hard "I just…I don't know if I can do this"

Adora shook her head, now genuinely confused and somewhat frustrated "What part?"

"Accepting Bright Moon"

"Catra…we talked for almost a year about it, what changed?" she insisted.

"Nothing has changed!" Catra snapped unable to fight it off any longer "That's the problem! She's still gone!"

Marazz jolted at the sudden yelling, forcing both mothers to leave their own feelings aside to make sure to tend to her.

"There, little one, It's okay" Adora caressed her ears softly, provoking her tiny purring as Catra made sure to keep her close.

"Sorry for yelling, kitten" she mumbled doing her best to stay in control, to keep her voice from shaking, knowing that she had to talk next. She felt her stomach tighten "Queen Angela isn't here, Adora" Catra finally said "so much longer and we weren't able to bring her back and now…now I'm taking over her kingdom, the land I once tried to conquer I…I feel…I feel worthless by doing it" her ears bent down flat against her head as her shoulders dropped.

Adora closed her eyes taking in a deep breath realizing where her resistance was coming from "I didn't…I didn't think… it didn't occur to me…" she exhaled "I'm sorry, Catra" she gazed at her "we should have talked about it"

"We did" Catra ducked her chin, "I thought I was in peace with it but…" she couldn't bring herself to admit to the events the day prior, of how broken Glimmer had been "I…I- I'm still the reason she's gone, and that won't change"

"You are right," Adora said firmly "but you have"

Catra dropped her shoulders, she didn't want to listen, but Adora held her chin and forced her to look up "I was the last person to see her, Catra" she said "she was at peace with that choice. She saved us all, she knew the price she was paying and accepted it" she leaned in pressing he forehead into hers "the last thing she asked me was to take care of Glimmer" she tangled her fingers on her long mane caressing sympathetically "so I think the best way that you could honor her wish is by doing exactly what you have done all along; looking out for her, being her friend, making sure nothing bad happens" she smiled softly "you've both grown close because at the end you weren't even that different" she leaned in to kiss her nose "And what better way to keep protecting them

than stand by them?" she tilted her head "they chose to make us this present, Catra. Not because they were forced to but because it was their way to give us a home, a place we could really belong to, because in the end, they want us near" she caressed her face gently "you are not taking anything away from anyone, I know that much"

Catra felt her lip trembling as she ducked her chin fighting the tears. Marazz splashed her hands on the water as if trying to get her to look at her, to cheer her up. Catra managed a smile as she cuddled her close kissing her head, making Marazz giggle.

Adora fell prey to her charm as well, tickling her sides to keep her melodic laugh ringing in the room.

After a moment, both women exchanged glances a bit more at ease, offering tender smiles that meant to comfort each other.

"I'll be standing by your side tomorrow," Catra said with unmovable resolve. She was going to accept the present, she was staying. No more running away.

Adora leaned in kissing her with equivalent passion as Catra's statement "And we'll be together, through it all" they broke apart in the slightest, lips still tentatively within reach.

"Thank you, Adora" Catra mumbled, her tone sincere and vulnerable.

"I'm always going to be here for you" Adora whispered back before another splash reminded them they weren't alone "and for you of course cutie", she reached for a towel to wrap Marazz in "time to get you in your 'jammies" she began to gently dry her golden mane with special care around the ears.

Catra smiled at the sight. Not in a million years, not even in the utopia she had tried to create with the rift she could have picture something as perfect. All she ever wanted was this kind of happiness, without knowing it didn't come from power or recognition.

She would never take for granted what she had in her life.

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Adora bounced Marazz up and down in her arms trying to keep her from pulling on her earnings.

"No grabby hands" she took her little palms planting kisses on them "I need to look presentable for about three more hours, so please, let mommy pretend she's used to this much jewelry"

"As far as I'm concerned the only jewelry you need is the ring" Catra walked in wearing a suit almost as gallant as the one from their wedding. And of course, she had the tie carelessly tossed at her neck.

"And as much as I agree, I still asked Spinella help to get ready" she countered "speaking of; can you fix your tie?"

"Why? Don't you like it? It certainly brings memories" she offered a wide smile that showed her canine.

Adora did her best not to blush "Don't" she warned "we are dangerously close to running late" she had to keep Marazz from yet again reaching for the earrings "and our little one is getting impatient"

Catra chuckled "Scorpia said she would look over her during the ceremony, why don't you go meet her?"

Adora felt the tug at her long blonde hair and had to lean in to prevent Marazz from pulling it "Okay, I'll see if she's around" she agreed "meanwhile, get ready"

"Yeah, I'll meet with you in a moment," Catra said nonchalantly turning to the mirror to try and fix the tie. There was perhaps

more than one reason she had rebelled to the idea of wearing proper attire at Princess Prom and as she undid her handiwork for the third time she recalled why. She huffed trying again; it had to feel just right, like every piece fitted in. Today it had to be perfect, she couldn't offer any less. Not after everything they had gone through.

"Come on" she groaned taking it all the way off gazing down at the piece of cloth. Maybe it just didn't fit in with the rest…maybe it was best if it wasn't there...maybe that was the hint the universe was giving her…

She shook her head pushing that thought aside; she was not about to sabotage herself like that, not again.

"Need a little help?" came a voice that carried through the room as summer's breeze. Catra turned around finding Glimmer at the threshold, wearing a royal gown with elegant embroider in it. She looked like the rightful queen she was.

"Looking sharp, Sparkles" Catra smirked turning back at the mirror to avoid her eyes, feeling uneasy. Since the picnic, they hadn't really seen each other or talked about it. It just made it all the more awkward for Catra to try and figure out what her train of thought was.

"Here, let me give you a hand" Glimmer reached her side taking the tie from her fingers and putting it around her collar as they met face to face. They exchanged glances and read each other. Glimmer noticed the somewhat furrowed brow, the way her shoulders were shrugging up in the slightest, how she timidly meet her eyes… and Catra could see the faint dark circles under Glimmer's eyes that were concealed with makeup and the way her posture was dragged down. They broke the spell almost simultaneously.

Catra shoved her hands into her pockets as Glimmer cleared her throat taking over to fix the tie "Sorry I haven't seen a lot of you

lately, painting the sigil was a lot more complex than I thought" she offered a smiled that tried to ease the mood.

"It's okay" Catra answered, her words got a bit lost in the room "Was Angie okay?" she asked raising her shoulders "she must have loved spending the whole day with you and Micah"

Glimmer smiled more naturally now "Yeah, she kept on asking questions, following the patterns, trying to do her own" she traced back chuckling "It had been a long while since I spent some quality time with her. Just some mother-daughter bonding time" she said lightly before her words hit home for both. The silence took over as Glimmer stopped her actions.

"Glimmer-"

"I'm sorry" The Queen beat her to it "the other day…I… just left without another word and…I kept thinking it through. It must have stung to the guts to see me like that and…feel like it was your fault"

"It was my fault"

"No" Glimmer cut her short tightening the knot emphasizing her statement "No, it wasn't" she gazed up at her eyes "The way I felt-or feel, doesn't fall on you"

"I'm the reason your mother is not here," Catra said brokenly looking down in shame "she should have been at your wedding, at the birth of your child and at every birthday after and instead-"

"Instead I had you," Glimmer said "I had the most reckless, loyal, empathetic friend. Someone that fought for my kingdom, the person I asked the hardest favor ever when I went into labor, the most loving aunt to my children, the friend I can talk to through a close door and feel the closest to" Glimmer felt tears running down her cheeks "Catra, you are one of the most important people in my life. You are my family" she cupper her face "Of course I'll miss my mother now and then, she was-she is- a big part of who I am, but I know she wants me to be happy. She did

what she had to because she loved me. The best way to keep her memory with me is being as happy as I was when she was next to me" she whipped a tear that had slipped past Catra's defenses "Because as I told you so many years ago, she never truly left me. I have her here in my heart and in every part of Etheria, all at once. I feel her touch running down my hair when the breeze reaches me, every sunset and sunrise I see her smile… she's always looking over me as she always did" she looked down at the tie as she made the final adjustment "so you don't have to feel a burden. If you feared I hadn't forgiven you, then let me look you in the eyes and assure you, I hold nothing but love in my heart for you" she said earnestly "that hasn't changed and it never will" she flattened the wrinkles in her shirt before sliding her hands down, a peaceful smile held in her lips.

Just as her eyes were traveling up to meet heterochromatic ones, warm arms wrapped around her embracing her yearningly.

It took Glimmer a moment to react, as she heard short controlled sniffs coming from the other woman. So she answered the gesture cuddling into her shoulder and resting there, reassured that she could always lean into her if she ever needed to, as she always had.

They held each other for as long as reality allowed them before a messenger rushed in unannounced.

"Everyone is ready!" he all but shouted noticing a moment too late he had intruded.

Still, Glimmer took her time before letting go of Catra, looking for her watery eyes to get confirmation that she was ready. Catra collected herself within a couple of breathings before nodding.

Glimmer smiled widely turning to the messenger.

"Let's begin"

***

Through the high balcony, they could gaze at all the people that had gathered, which pretty much the entire kingdom and then some folks from close lands, including those that traveled with the princesses to witness the unprecedented event.

Catra stood right next to Adora as they held hands on one end and waved around with the other. They could easily spot Scorpia in the front row holding their baby as she pointed for the kitten to look up at her mothers.

After a brief moment, Micah raised his arms commencing the ceremony, giving a well prepared and meaningful speech, recalling all that Bright Moon had gone through and how now posterity and peace had prospered. He recognized the labor Bow and Glimmer had done and exalted all the missions Adora and Catra had partaken to ensure magic throughout the galaxy and how now that they were about to celebrate the first year back into Etheria, they would do so by claiming part of the land under their protection, to finally have a stable home they could stay in. And all the people cheered for them. It felt almost surreal to have all the approval and acceptance from them. The past was now behind them. They belonged.

"And as such!" Micah raised to the sky a golden rope "we tie them to this lands, so they can grow their roots here with us" he turned to the four of them "now, if you could all hold hands" he instructed as each stretched an arm to the center "we bound you to Bright Moon" he tied around the rope thought all their wrist making something that looked close to a mandala "and therefore I say, Bright Moon has won two brave protectors to uphold its freedom" he inhaled closing his eyes before snapping them open with a burst of light as he recited ancient words and the sigils in the ground lighted up shooting upwards and into the sky like fireworks. The remaining sparkles showered down different color

lights that reached their hearts "all raise a glass for our new royalty!"

And the cheers echoed throughout the land.

***

A party was held afterward, the music, the folklore, and the food all mixed together as everyone celebrated the ceremony. Adora and Catra were hand in hand as they reached the alliance.

"There they are!" they were greeted by hugs and congratulations.

"Here you go" Scorpia carefully handed Adora back her baby.

"Thank you, I hope she wasn't much trouble"

"She behaved perfectly" Perfuma assured.

"How do you feel?" Spinella asked with a smile.

They gazed at one another "At home" Catra offered.

"Finally" Adora smirked leaning into her chest.

"Oh my!" Scorpia suddenly jolted "Wildcat! Do you know what this means?!" she asked about to explode.

"That…we are staying?" she tried to guess while keeping the sarcasm out of her tone.

"This means you are officially a princess!"

"What?!" she jumped, her fur crawling as the others laughed falling into the same realization "It does not!" she countered stubbornly.

"It does! You are Bright Moon royalty now!"

Adora laughed the hardest "You turned into the thing you swore to destroy" she teased.

"You did it first" Catra crossed her arms sticking her tongue out at her before Marazz tried to reach it.

They continue to share a lovely evening sharing laughs at the expense of Catra's reactions most of the time, which she gladly fired back when given the chance. By the time the sun was going down, Glimmer, Bow, and the twins joined as well after closing all the formalities. They easily took part in the conversation as their kids decided to go play around with other children. Angella would now and then race back to the adults and grab her mother's hand for a moment or two before going back to playing, knowing her mom would be her anchor if she feared she might teleport again.

"The moon is almost upon us," Glimmer said eagerly and Catra felt electricity run through her body, she recognized the feeling, she was nervous.

"It should be a beautiful sight; it's going to be full"

"Makes tonight all the more special"

"Speaking of special…" Glimmer raised a brow.

The musicians ended the piece they were playing as they changed the music sheets they were reading and prepared something else.

Catra breathed in throwing her head back before turning to Adora "I'll be right back, love" she leaned in to kiss her "just remember that you agreed to marry me in the first place, you are stuck with me"

"What?" she chuckled unsure of what her wife was talking about "where are you going?"

Catra huffed mockingly "About to give the whole alliance enough leverage to embarrass me for eternity" she answered heading to the stage where the musicians were.

Glimmer reached her side giving her a pat "Ready?" she asked with an outrageously sly smile.

"Too late to back down?" she asked almost pleadingly.

"Too late indeed" she handed her the device that would carry her voice throughout the place.

Catra groaned as she grabbed it and walked up the stage as a spotlight focused on her.

"Um, hello" she started testing how loud it would be, pretty loud indeed "Goodnight everyone I…hope you are enjoying yourselves and…this special occasion" she held a tight smile "for which the Queen asked me to do a gesture and I agreed" she gazed at Glimmer, hoping she would jump in and save her, asking for a small toast or anything but. Instead, the Queen boasted a huge smile and did a 'go-ahead' motion for which Catra almost groaned into the microphone "So here we are. Thanks, Sparkles" she turned to the laughing crowd as she noticed her slip of tongue "I mean Queen Glimmer," she said truly mortified, which only made it funnier.

"Way to go!" she could hear Netossa teasing from the crowd, whistling loudly.

Catra twitched an ear wishing for it to be over. Her hands were sweaty and her heart was hammering, how she wished she had to fight a battalion instead of this.

So she closed her eyes blocking everything else, waiting for the music to begin a slow-paced tune and then…

"We are warriors" her voice broke free from her lips "Unstoppable" suddenly all the side talk was forgotten and all eyes fell on her,

but Catra didn't know this because she kept her own closed and her voice steady "We feel the evil coming"

As she kept on singing, the whole kingdom was drawn towards her performance and as the words kept running free, Catra felt more comfortable, relaxing her shoulders, allowing herself to flow through the lyrics.

Every princess in the alliance gazed as if this was nothing but a dream while Adora proudly watched her wife at the stage finally showing all of her colors to everyone, chipping away more of her protective shell.

"That's your mommy singing" she mumbled to Marazz's ear kissing her head as they kept on enjoying the show.

By the time Catra reached the end of the song, she could feel something burning inside, a raw excitement mixed with nervousness and…freedom.

"We must be strong" she pronounced the very last of it, finally daring to open her eyes to find hundreds of others placed on her. Her ears bent down feeling kind of intimidated by having that much attention drawn to her, but then the first clap came, most likely form Adora, and the other's followed as an expanding wave, and soon all she could hear were their cheers. She felt her face go red as she did a little bow and headed down the stage at incredible speed.

Glimmer received her into a tight hug laughing energetically "I can't believe you actually did it!"

"What do you mean?! You asked me to!"

"I honestly thought you wouldn't go through with it" she admitted whipping away the tears that escaped through her laughter.

Catra felt like fainting "You mean I could have avoided that?!"

Glimmer caught her breath and laid a hand on her shoulder "You would honestly take that back?" she smiled softly "You were amazing, everyone loved it and you looked just so…so genuinely happy. I'm glad you went through with it"

Catra sheepishly shrugged "I told you before; I would do anything for you"

Glimmer held her gaze tenderly, she truly knew Catra meant it "Thank you for the present"

Catra nodded "Thank you for yours"

"Catra!" Adora launched forward kissing her messily "I'm so proud of you!"

The feline blushed "You already knew I could sing"

"Not in front of hundreds of people"

Her knees became a little wobbly after that statement "Well, first time for everything, you can thank Sparkles for the show"

"I don't know what you did to convince her, but you are my new personal hero" Adora smirked as Catra grabbed Marazz from her arms ready to cuddle her.

"Well, we are part of Bright Moon now, might as well let them get to know me" she smiled openly, not having to fear showing her true self in all its forms; the soft parts, the broken ones, the hurt from the past and the hope for the future. She could finally let her guard down, she was truly home now.

Chapter End Notes

> Low key it felt like this should be the last chapter...but I still have a couple more to get out of my chest XP
>
> So I guess the end is getting near...

As always thank you for your support and see you next week!

Chapter 13

Chapter Notes

> I literally just finished this chapter! One week later than I expected but here it is nonetheless! I hope you enjoy it and...hold on tight!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra tried her best not to lean into the cane as another wave of pain swirled through her leg. She didn't want to show any discomfort, especially not while Adora was in her She-Ra form talking to them through the screen.

"I've taken care of their fleet, they won't dare to make another threat" the blonde warrior sentenced severely, her steely blue eyes showed nothing but determination.

"Let's hope you can come back soon" Glimmer said, arms folded and analyzing the status report. It was not often someone dared to bring trouble to their front door, but a former member of the committee had tried his luck challenging She-Ra through an ambush, which only lead to Catra getting hurt and for that, they paid dearly under Adora's wrath.

She-Ra softened her demeanor turning to Catra "How are you feeling?" she asked concerned "I'm sorry I sent you home like that, I couldn't risk it" she apologized. After the attack on their ship and seeing how Catra was definitely out of sources, she had teleported her out of there, not putting it up for debate, to then really take on them.

Catra couldn't blame her, from a strategic point of view, it was a liability to have her there helpless, especially since the committee knew what she had figured out long ago, to get to Adora, you go for her heart and at that time and moment, Catra was said heart. On the other hand, it was simply the instinctual decision that if something bad was really to happen, then it couldn't be to the

both of them, they had Marazz back home turning six, and they couldn't leave her alone.

"I'm okay, love" Catra assured, even though her expression failed to suppress a wince as she leaned into her injured limb.

Adora flinched at the sight "As soon as I am back home I'll take care of that" she promised.

Catra smirked "Don't make me wait, Princess"

Adora chuckled back, she knew Catra would be alright "How's our little one?" she asked.

"She's with Saber right now" she informed before tilting her head "She's asking about you, though"

"Tell her I'll be there to tuck her in tonight"

"That confident about their surrender?" Glimmer joined in at the comment.

"I'll make them yield" She-Ra said coldly "They threatened and attacked our home, I'll make sure they don't ever dare to try again" although her voice sounded full of resentment, it was not in Adora to inflict pain, she was not out for blood "I'll leave them out of supplies, their options will be to retreat or surrender. Depending on the result, you can open a channel to talk, if diplomacy fails, this will not" she wielded her sword.

Glimmer nodded, first and foremost they tried to preserve peace and prosperity throughout the galaxy, but she knew that if they couldn't, Etheria would have to face yet another battle "Let's hope they choose wisely" she sighed.

Adora nodded "I have to go now, I'll call when there's more to update"

"Take care, love" Catra smiled sweetly "Come home to us, okay?"

She-Ra gazed at her lovingly "I will" she pressed fingers to her lips and then to the screen before it went black.

Catra sighed and bent down to rub at her sore leg.

Glimmer teleported at her side in less than a second helping carry her weight "You should take it easy"

"I'll be way more at ease once she's here tucking in Marazz" she answered allowing the Queen to teleport her out of the meeting room and into the hallway, right in front of her door.

"For now keep your leg up and try to sleep" she borderline begged her "The physician said you were lucky it didn't struck a nerve"

Catra huffed "Am I getting too old to keep doing this?"

"Not quite, you just had a really early start" Glimmer smirked back.

"Didn't we all?"

"Good old times" she wrinkled her nose smirking before turning her eyes softer "Rest" she insisted.

Catra pursed her lips upward apologetically "Can we go to the kids instead? I promise to stay still"

Glimmer rolled her eyes sighing, but didn't refute, so she teleported to where Saber was showing Mini Mara how to build castles with some wood blocks.

When they looked up at them their eyes became radiant.

"Mom!" Marazz ran in all four before jumping to her arms as she always did. Catra had to do her best to catch her with one arm and keep the balance on the cane. Luckily Glimmer placed a hand on her back helping her stabilize, but a wince escaped her lips nonetheless.

The radian mismatched blue eyes noticed the pained expression and her own ears bent down worriedly, her tail rolling up into her mother's wrist "Mom?"

"I'm okay, kitten" she kissed her forehead "I just…twisted my ankle while in the ship" that was under selling it and although it slightly calmed Marazz, Saber frowned. He had seen his aunt reach the top of the castle by climbing it from the outside without even breaking a sweat and take falls half that height to just shrug them off. So a 'twisted ankle' just didn't add up to him.

"Is the mission over?" he asked, his voice starting to get deeper as he had grown to become a teenager.

"It will be soon"

"Hopefully" Glimmer added folding her arms "what we are trying is to prevent future trouble"

"We can call an extraordinary meeting, make sure other allies won't follow their footsteps" Saber said, he had become sharp with words as he was with swords and arrows. He was quick on his feet and was dexterous when it came to reaching compromises. He was shaping up to be a capable leader.

Glimmer smiled proudly at him "We are waiting to open a channel to contact their ship, if they don't answer we might proceeded with that plan"

"Can I be present?"

"As an observant, yes. Soon enough you'll have to take part in the meetings as well"

He radiated a huge smile; he was ready to prove himself.

Catra settled down Marazz before taking a seat, unable to hold herself upright any longer "So, what were you up to?"

"Building castles and fortresses!" Marazz said excitedly handing her mother some of the figures Bow would now and then craft of themselves. Catra smirked playing along.

She noticed a block had some marks in them and raised a brow at her daughter "Are your teeth still bothering you?"

Marazz held her shoulders up to her bent ears "A little"

"It's okay" she stretched her hand inviting her close "Which ones?"

Marazz opened up, tilting her head and tapping with a finger her sharp pearls "The pointy ones"

"Canines, yes" Catra hummed "I too chewed on everything when they started to grow. It hurt but made the sensation feel better" she booped Marazz's nose "I might have bitten mommy's hand once" she admitted with a laugh "luckily it didn't leave marks"

"You bit Aunt Adora?" Saber intervened amused.

"We were kids" she clarified smirking "after that I got a warning that if I kept it up they would pull my teeth out"

Saber's gesture turned concerned "Who told you that?"

Catra felt her posture shift "Some…grumpy old lady that used to watch over us"

Catra felt a hand on her shoulder as Glimmer rubbed gentle circles with her thumb comfortingly. She knew Catra would rather refer to her as something phonetically on the lines of witch but kept it quiet for the sake of the younglings.

"They didn't, right?" Marazz asked sitting on her mom's lap, it was almost instinctual for her to grant her a hug just when Catra was about to feel down.

"No, they didn't took them away" she chuckled moved by her daughter's concern "and no one is going to take yours either" she added.

"But if they still bother you, sweetie" Glimmer intervened "I can give you some remedies to numb the feeling" she offered sweetly "I can even make it cake flavored"

"Yes!" she bounced up and down.

Catra giggled "Yep, that's mommy's part of the genetics alright" she kissed her head "Now tell us, what were you playing?"

"We were trying to infiltrate the castle!"

"That's your game?" Catra arched a brow amusedly.

"We were learning about that in our last lesson" Arrow explained sheepishly "did we really didn't have any cells for prisoners?" he turned to his mother.

"We did!" she refuted energetically "they were just dignified versions of them" she puffed her cheeks just as when she was younger.

"No, they really didn't" Catra huffed smugly "either they were outrageously confident that peace would prevail or too naïve to think they would have to keep enemies inside their own walls"

Glimmer turned to Catra shooting a glare that tried to show annoyance, but her pout didn't help her look threatening "Thanks"

"Hey, I'm just giving him a round education"

Glimmer sighed amusedly before turning to him "Speaking of education, is your sister still in class?"

"She went to do a bit of independent studies" he arranged the words as their teachers used to "She said she would catch up-"

And then, a flash of light exploded in the room and Angella stood in the middle, her usual radiant smile was missing and instead a raw expression of anger and pain was rooted deep into her face. And those eyes were there to meet only the ones of Catra.

Even before reality could land with a punch, the feline woman knew exactly why she was there.

Little did it matter how she knew or who had told her, all that mattered was the way her bright brown eyes were looking at Catra with such hurt and betrayal in them.

"Sweetie?" Glimmer called "What's wrong?"

"You did it" the words were spitted with difficulty "You were the force captain that opened the rift"

Catra didn't flinch, nor did she tried to make an excuse; her voice didn't break as she spoke "Yes" she admitted a truth she had withhold for 13 years.

Saber snapped his eyes wide open processing the information; catching up to what his sister was implying "But the Horde-"

"She was the Horde!" Angella spat.

Catra took a deep breath standing up with difficulty "I was"

"What?!" Saber jolted up as well.

"You lied to us!" Angie cried, tears running down her face.

Marazz hid behind her aunt's skirts frightener by all the yelling. Her ears folded down trying to drown out all sounds as she timidly hid her face into the Queen's gown.

At the sight, Glimmer laid a hand over her head before looking up determined "That's enough!" she commanded looking at her own daughter with reproach "I won't allow you to talk like that to-"

"It's okay Sparkles" Catra mumbled, her eyes still focused on the ones that had always gazed at her with admiration and love "let her talk"

"No, Catra-" she was about to intervene when Angella grabber her shoulder and teleported them to a hallway forgotten by many, a place no one could interrupt them, the memorial of the previous Queen.

They stood in silence as Catra gazed at the mural with an aching heart, of course of all the placed to confront her, she would do so in front of the victim of her actions.

"You took our grandmother" Angella's voice was breaking as the words left her lips, perhaps deep down she was hoping Catra would deny that by throwing new light to her discoveries and refute, but that was not the case.

Catra gazed at the wall and exhaled brokenly "Because of what I did she was never able to come back. So, yes. I took her away from you, from all of you"

"Why?!"

"I can't even begin to explain it-"

"No, why are you here?" Angella cut her short "you nearly succeeded in destroying everything" she emphasized the last word knowing it would drip red ink.

"Because I found a home here" she answered honestly "in Bright Moon with…all of you" she took a step forward "I know what you must think of me right now, Angella-"

The teen shook her head stepping back "Don't" she warned "Don't you use that name, you doomed it long ago and now I wear it like a badge, a memorial" she clenched a hand to her own chest "Is that what this has been all along? You were just redeeming yourself though us? Thought me?" she gazed at mismatched eyes through her watery ones.

"No" Catra said without missing a beat "That was never it" she wanted to take a step and lay a palm on her shoulder, but she didn't have the right to, she knew her hand would be pushed away if she tried and she couldn't face that rejection "All that I have been and done ever since I joined the rebellion has been true. I didn't look out for you because I felt like I owed it to her" she briefly gazed at the wall.

"Then why?" Angella defied her.

"Because you are my niece and I love you" she stated heartedly, firmly.

"You took my mom's mother" her voice broke further, sadness dripping.

"I know…the list of things that I would change from my past is so long" she ran a hand through her hair feeling the sting in her eyes, but she didn't broke down to it "there's so much you are yet to learn about me and still, that one act haunts me the most. There's not a day in which I don't wish to go back in time and fix that" she admitted bitterly "Your mother has every right in the world to hate me, but instead, she showed me compassion and throughout the years she learned to forgive me, because she's that much stronger than I'll ever be" she swallowed the knot in her throat "I haven't forgiven myself for that mistake, An-" she cut herself short, knowing she had lost the right to call her that name "And I understand if you can't forgive me either. But know that all the moments I've shared with you and your brother…that wasn't a lie. I love you both and your parents with all my might. But I won't ask you to reciprocate"

The flash blinded her as Angella left, not a word spoken. And Catra finally allowed the air caught in her chest to run free as the tears roamed.

***

Adora leaned in, her head hanging low as she looked at her through the screen with sadden eyes "I'm so sorry, Catra. I should have been there, I-"

"How could we predict this would happen today?" Catra cut her off with a huff that fell short as she readjusted her leg to keep it up "I just…I just needed to tell you" her ears folded down.

"I'm glad you called, love" she smiled at her with fragility "I am always here for you"

"I know" she smiled faintly before dropping the gesture "I haven't spoken with Saber yet and Bow is taking care of Marazz right now to let me collect my thoughts, I…I just…I don't know what to do, Adora"

The hero exhaled as well taking a seat, it was obvious she too was over her head "Give it time. They need to process and… whatever happens we are together and you know Bow and Glimmer have your back too"

"I know, but I …I don't want them to feel as though they have to move pass it just because others tell them to, if they decide to forgive me, it has to be their decision" she sighed before looking up a She-Ra's worn-out expression "speaking of deciding on their own terms, how is the mission going?"

Adora pursed her lips to a side shaking her head slowly, her always determined blue eyes showed something that haven't been there in the longest of times "I don't know" she admitted.

Catra leaned in attentive, forgetting the pain that swirled through her leg as she did so "What's wrong?"

"They won't surrender and they have other members of the committee in their pocket" she explained running a hand through her long golden hair "I know I can take down their battalion right

here and now, but then they'll just call another and another right at Etheria's front door…"

"Should we gather the alliance?"

"I was hoping not to go that far but…" she sighed "I'll run some ideas by Bow and maybe even Hordak" she offered a twisted smirk knowing the irony was uncanny "Right now I'm the only thing standing between them and our home planet" she mumbled "I don't know how long this will be dragged" she finally met her eyes.

Catra bit into her lower lip "What should I tell Marazz?" she asked softly, knowing that was the topic the blonde was concerned about.

"I…I might not tuck her in for a little while, Catra"

"Are things looking that bad?" her ears perked up a bit alarmed, just hour prior the blonde was confident she'd be home by sundown.

"They could be" Adora sighed "I can't leave until they retrieve, someone has to stand the frontline, even if there's no battle, we can't give them a chance to move forward"

"Then…you come home and I'll stay guard"

"What?" she gazed up aback.

"I can handle that, we spent the same amount of years on that ship, I will manage"

"But Marazz-"

"You will be with her"

"Catra, being up here means to leave-" she cut herself understanding why Catra would decide that.

The feline shrugged "Maybe it's best if I leave Bright Moon for a little bit. I…I don't know if the twins would want me here after today"

"Catra" Adora's voice was soft and broken "you don't have to -"

"I know I have a tendency to run away from my problems, from the people I've hurt but…but this time I stood to look her in the eyes and…this is their home. It will make it easier for everyone if they can work it through without me intruding"

"You are not intruding, Catra. It's your home as well; none of the past can change that"

"Adora-"

"No, listen to me, you are not isolating yourself over this, you are worth more than being casted to the shadows"

"But I can't stand it" she cut her short, her voice cracking "I can't stand to face them like that I…I love them too much to hurt them this way" she sniffed looking away managing a small smile "besides, you would be here with our kitten. You are always the one having to answer the call. This time I will fill in"

She-Ra exhaled pressing a hand to her forehead "Catra..."

"It's okay, Adora, I-"

"No, it's not okay" she saw her face, wishing to be there in person "please don't…don't decide anything yet" she begged "Let's see how this plays out and talk about it. For all we know this whole mess could end tonight" she gazed at her eyes hopefully, more of a desperate plea to the universe "Once I'm there, we can all sit down and talk to the kids like we said we would. We will explain everything, that we were both Horde, that we've changed"

"You didn't take away their grandmother, Adora" she mumbled weakly.

"And you are not going to take away their aunt either" she said with resolve "just wait for me, okay? Stay"

Catra felt her shoulders drop before gazing up, leaning into the image and stretching a hand towards "I will"

Adora let out a relieved sigh "Thank you" she smiled fighting off the tears "I love you"

***

Glimmer made sure to check on Marazz, relieved to see Melog was comforting her in soft purrs and cuddles, so now she could go and try to find her elusive kids. They both had such different ways to cope with their feelings. When it came to happiness and excitement, her son would shout to the winds and express himself unapologetically but at the same time Saber would bottle up so much for the sake of others around him or just to accomplish whatever task was at hand. Angella on the other hand tended to wear her heart on her sleeve around the people she knew and shielded it closely to those she didn't, and although she was just as energetic and tactful as her parents, she rarely had outburst of anger or sadness, so today was by all means a new scenario for everyone.

Glimmer explored every single hallway up and down until she came to the conclusion that they weren't inside the castle. So she teleported to a place she knew they would take refuge in, their old tree house.

She appeared at the base of the oak, knowing that if she wanted to reach out to them, then she needed their permission to be there, not force them into opening up.

"Angella, Arrow?" she called "are you here?"

There wasn't an immediate answer, but she heard the wooden boards squeak.

"Listen I- we need to talk, please"

"There's not much to talk about" a voice replied, Angella's.

"Believe me, there is" Glimmer answered hugging herself "Can I come in?"

Another pause before a faint affirmative came through. Glimmer blinked herself inside, finding Angella hugging herself.

Glimmer approached her carefully, knowing she could easily teleport away as well "Hey" she looked around "Is Arrow not with you?"

"He needed to practice by himself" she answered. That sounded like him, he would deal with his frustration through silent shooting, hitting bull's eyes every time no doubt. She would have to look for him in the forest later.

Glimmer stood in front of her "Angella-"

"You didn't tell us" she cut her bitterly "Of all the things she did, all the hurt she brought our family"

"You are right, I didn't" she exhaled sitting across from her daughter, trying to find those watery tired eyes "I thought I would spare you the suffer, I wanted to tell you when you were older, but I guess you were always a bit more inquisitive than most kids your age"

"When? When did you find out?" she asked whipping the tip of her nose with a sleeve.

Glimmer took a deep breath "I…I've known Catra since before she joined the rebellion. Since she was Horde,… along with Adora"

"Aunt Adora as well?!" she whipped her head in her direction completely confused "But-but she's She-Ra!"

"One's past doesn't define them, the constant decisions they make, does" she tried to explain, wisdom ringing in her voice as it used to be on her mother's own "We were all enemies before we were friends. Aunt Entrapta and Scorpia too were once helping the Horde, Hordak himself was more than a mere clone, he was the ruler of the Fright Zone"

Angella held her head as it went spinning "This doesn't make sense"

"I know it doesn't, not on a rational level, at least. That's why I wanted to explain this to you myself. We were all going to talk this through"

"What's there to talk?!" she snapped "They were part of what destroyed Etheria"

"And they were also key to save it, despite all the wrong that came before that"

"How can you even say it so calmly?" Angella incriminated heartbrokenly "If someone had taken you away from me I would never forgive them! You lost your mom because of Aun- of what Catra did"

It pained Glimmer that her daughter would strip the other woman of her title just like that, as if the last 13 years hadn't happened "It's not about all the others, is it? It's just her you are wounded about"

Angella avoided her eyes as she sniffed "She hurt all of you the most"

The Queen couldn't deny that, a long list expanded under Catra's name and she had spent the better part of her life trying to right all those wrongs "Did she told you what I did?" Glimmer countered "That I brought the whole Horde's armada into our

earth because I was a stubborn child? Because that was all we were, we were just kids wrapped up in a war" she remarked sternly seeing Angella aback by the revelation and sudden dark aura her mother's words carried "If you think I effortlessly let Catra into my life, you are wrong. It took time and circumstances for me to realize we were not that different. If she had grown in Bright Moon or if I had been as unlucky as to be raised by the Horde, I'm pretty certain we would have turn out to be like the other" she sentenced "I got to see that when we were both held in Prime's ship. Up there we only had each other, that's when I began to understand her, because despite having nothing but resentment and hate as enemies, we were also the only company we had, the only piece of home and… then I saw she was just like me. Even though every time I pictured the face of evil, her features where the once to pop into my mind, I soon understood she was just someone doing her best to thrive and prove herself as I did in my kingdom" her heart was pounding as so many words of realization were said out loud for someone else to hear "And when it came down to it, she was the reason I was freed from Prime's prison, she saved me at her own expense because she was trying to keep Adora from getting captured or worst, because at her core, all she ever did was to try to gain love in that way, because no one showed her how to express it otherwise. She didn't chose to be raised by the Horde, but it was her decision to leave it, just as Adora had" she breathed in "And she loves you so much" she shook her head "since the day you were born she was one of the first people to ever hold you and your brother. The first person I ever talked to regarding the idea of having kids" she pressed her lips into a thin line "Sometimes it hurts worst to learn the things done by the people we love the most" she cooed "I understand that, but you have to know that she never lied to you"

She looked into her daughter's eyes before feeling they weren't alone anymore, or perhaps they had been there all along.

"Why hasn't anyone rescued grandma?" came a third voice, as Saber climber the final step of the stairs, making himself announced after quietly being eavesdropping.

Glimmer inhaled softly "Come with me, someone else can give you that answer" she stretched her hands towards her kids, waiting for them to accept. And they did.

***

Glimmer sent a signal and waited a few seconds before Entrapta popped into the screen, she was busy fixing a piece of tech, barely noticing the Queen was on the other side.

"I'm close, I'm just trying to figure a frequency to-"

"Entrapta" Glimmer cut her short.

The other princess gazed up surprised "Oh, I thought Bow was in charge of this assignment"

"I'm calling for another reason" she explained, her face unreadable "Can you tell me about opening another portal?"

Entrapta looked up aback "Another portal?" she questioned "well that's impossible"

"Why?" Angella leaned in attentive, her insides burning up.

"Because it would risk another fracture of time, space and continuity, especially now that we are not secluded from the rest of the universe" she explained matter-of-factly "the only reason this reality hasn't collapsed it's because Angela is holding it together"

"That's why we have to get her!" Saber insisted.

"Oh! You are talking about project 'save the bird!' I see" Entrapta moved around with her hair pulling out blue prints "to reach her into that dimension of empty eternal existence would mean to

fracture several layers of probability. Not only is it incredibly dangerous but based on all my observations it's also impossible"

"There has to be a way, you must have missed a scenario in which we could help!" Saber said eagerly.

"Well, why don't you talk to Catra?"

"Catra?" the twins frowned "why would we ask her?"

"Because we spent several years trying to come up with a plan, we searched through all variables, from simple things as the phases of the moon, to special kinds of magic or even astrological cataclysms that could give us the energy to open the rift again, but it's just not possible. Our last trial involved the chance of making a switch, tear a small part of fabric of space and time to pull Angela out and leave her in her place"

"Leave who?"

"Catra, of course. That was her plan, but even such a small variation could end up imploding reality"

"S-so, Aunt Catra tried to-?" Saber traced back.

"Yeah, she came up with the operation! She was an okay lab partner but her insistence was at the end what made us close the project. Hoping to obtain different results out of the same experiment is the definition of insanity" she waved a hand around dismissively "it wasn't even theoretical anymore, it became purely hypothetical"

Glimmer sighed, dropping her shoulders "Thank you, Entrapta. We'll let you continue, call when you have an update in how to stop the fleet"

"I'm on it!" she beamed before the transmission finished, leaving the room momentarily dark.

"That's why we haven't been able to reach her, not because we forgot about her, but because there's no way to bring her back without endangering the whole planet, perhaps even the universe" Glimmer said faintly "I so desperately wanted this plan to succeed that I was willing to risk it all to bring her back but…at the end that would have meant to risk everyone I still have, including you" she mumbled "And I already had made that mistake before, when I broke the seal that kept us from the rest of the cosmos. I put in danger and used as bait my closest friends… I'm not better of what you think of Catra when it comes down to it" she gazed away "there's no such thing as labels of good and evil, it's not as simple. We are the sum of experiences, beliefs, of the people that surround us and so much more" Glimmer said softly "And all of us have tried to do what's best for you and I'm sure your dad and Adora would like to talk to you as well, tell their side of the story. But in the end, it will be your decision how to respond to what we have told you" she said gently turning around.

"Why…why do you come out to their defense, mom?"

Glimmer looked up smiling frailly "Because they are my family too"

***

Angella teleported Arrow, knowing they both needed somewhere they could talk privately, so the interior garden seemed like a good place, perhaps she just naturally chose it because that was the first place she had teleported from.

As soon as they knew they were alone, Angella began to pace around as her mother would and Saber tried to focus on the small details surrounding them, just as their dad.

"It's…it's a lot" Angella said out loud "all this time basically half our Aunts were Horde"

"Yeah" he answered barely audible, his head roaming somewhere else.

"And we didn't know" Angella continued, running a hand down her long hair.

"But…does this really change things?" Saber questioned more calmly than he felt.

"It already did!"

"Yes, okay, it changed things, but it didn't changed them, right?" he reasoned.

"I don't know"

"So what? Now we just pull apart?" he challenged "are we going to cut off Marazz as well?"

"No!" Angella said in a hurry, distraught at the thought of losing their cousin.

"Then what do you want?"

Angella felt the air trapped in her lungs "I-I don't…" she sighed sitting on the floor, hugging her knees to her chest "I don't know" she sniffed "I wish things would go back to how they were" she admitted "I…I don't want to be…grandma's shadow…" she mumbled faintly "they…they always say I was named after her so…am I just…was I an attempt to…?" she sniffed "Did Aunt Catra was paying a debt with me?"

Saber softened his demeanor sitting by her side; throwing an arm over her shoulders "I don't think so" he shrugged a shoulder "she loves us"

"What if…that was another lie?"

Saber understood were she was coming from. If something as important had been kept a secret, what assured them nothing

else had been deceitful?

"Do you honestly would think that?" a strong but gentle voice cut through, both looked up finding their dad looking at them.

They jolted up, Angella whipped her eyes as Saber regained composure, but Bow only shook his head gently placing a hand over their shoulders.

"I know today has been really confusing for both of you" he said delicately "we never wanted things to play out like this" he said sincerely "but now that you know most of our past, we can only hope you will understand our actions"

"Dad you…you always told us the truth" Saber said with a thin threat of voice, perhaps wounded.

"I always tried to be honest, yes" he nodded "but there are things that are not my place to say" he reasoned calmly "and sometimes people will have secrets because they think it's the best way to protect the ones they love from the truth" he tilted his head to a side "It took me several years to tell my dads that I wanted to be an archer" he smirked "I didn't want to disappoint them"

"But you are such an excellent archer!"

Bow chuckled "maybe so, but that was something that was different to what the rest of my family did, so I feared I would disillusion them by who I was" he looked for their eyes "and if my secret was as innocent as that, can you imagine what your Aunts must have felt regarding their own?" he questioned pointedly "Adora and Catra often hide the past because the scars from it still hunt them" he explained "it's not something they like to remember, not something they feel proud about. But most of all, they didn't want you to look at them differently" he sighed "now that you know who raised them, can you see how all the little pieces fall in place?" he mumbled "whenever they talk about their childhood, they tiptoe around certain topics, they avoid answering some questions, because they don't want you to know about

those days, about how awful it all was. When they say that all they had was each other, they really mean it" he gazed down saddened "they didn't have a home, parents or someone that loved them. And yes, that doesn't exempt them from the things they did, from the troops they commanded or the hurt they brought, but they never denied any of it. They owned it up and worked hard and driven from that point forwards trying to amend all the damage" he leaned down making sure his words would be heard "we will all make mistakes in our lives, it's what comes after what can define us. We can repeat, learn, ignore, crumbled and grow from them. Right now, it's your turn to decide"

Angella gazed at her brother as she extended a hand towards him, he offered a smile and they teleported away.

***

Catra stood in front of the mural, gazing up at the immaculate image of Queen Angela. She didn't know her like the others did. She could only piece it together by the stories she heard, building her own mosaic of how she had been. Catra had wondered more than once how would it have been to be raised by someone like her. Then she looked at Glimmer and knew that was pretty much the result; someone fearless, carrying, kind and determined.

She owed the mystical woman a great deal without having even met her face to face, but Angela had given her so much more than she could ever imagine.

Micah laid a hand on her shoulder squeezing softly "Dwelling on the past is not going to make anyone any favor"

"I know" Catra mumbled leaning into the cane, exhaling longingly, gazing up at the man that had stood by her side for the better part of the last hour "Thank you for your company"

"It's okay, kiddo" he smiled. To his eyes all of them were still his kids one way or another "I like to come here once in a while as well" he wrapped an arm around her shoulders "you know we've all forgiven you, don't you?"

"You really shouldn't have" she huffed trying to pass it of as a joke, but the sting in her tongue gave away how much it still haunt her.

Micah patted her back gently "Then it's a good thing we came to that decision on our own" he pressed one final time before letting go "I will give you a moment, I hope to see you at dinner"

Catra nodded absently, thinking that perhaps this night should be the last she spent on Bright Moon before taking over Darla.

She was so absorbed taking in the image that she didn't notice the moment a cloud of sparkles had materialized behind her. She just felt the gentle push on her back as Glimmer leaned in, facing the opposite direction.

"Hi" the former princess mumbled.

"Hey" Catra smiled faintly pressing her back, the feeling of reassurance of having her there was beyond what words could describe.

"How are you feeling?" Glimmer mumbled.

Catra chuckled dryly "I'm not the one to be concerned about" she sniffed "first of all tell me how you are" she requested gently, her ears tilting down "we've been digging on a lot of the past, are you…are you alright?"

Glimmer leaned her head back, resting on her shoulder "It feels like a lifetime away…" she traced back "Like waking up from a dream and trying to remember some of the parts of it" she sighed "but at least I know most of my dreams are happy ones, you on the other hand…" she hanged the rest of the sentence "I think it's fair that I worry about you"

Catra huffed trying to diminish the pang in her heart "You are so annoying, Sparkles" she said trying to keep her voice from breaking "even in the day you have every right to crumble down and rage, you are worried about me" she offered a small laugh that soon caught up in her throat, threatening with tears "I wish you'd yelled at me, hit me, make me feel your wrath so I could at least share the pain, because nothing I do could make us even"

"That's because I don't want to 'settle a score'. Hurt above hurt is not a solution, you know that" she intervened gently.

Catra gazed down drying her tears "I know, I know it doesn't"

Glimmer reached for her hand, intertwining her fingers, holding tight, staying there. No words said for a long moment "You know how you say you'd do anything for me?"

Catra held her hand tight "Yeah" she answered catching her breath "I mean it, anything"

"Then there's one favor I'd like to ask you" her words were careful and soft.

"Name it" Catra pleaded, yearning to make good on that promise so maybe the feeling of guilt and pain would subside.

Glimmer bit on her lower lip "Forgive yourself"

Catra felt the cold stab of reality hitting her heart and piercing through her thoughts "Glim-"

"That's what I want out of you more than anything else" she said unwavering "no more diminishing yourself, not only regarding this, but of every other aspect in your life. You are more than the shadow of the past you drag. You've learned to shine and your light is too pure and beautiful to keep throwing shade at it" Her hands slipped away and just when Catra feared that maybe she would take her leave, a pair of arms wrapped up around her, holding her tight, resting on her shoulder blade "that's my wish for you, Catra" she hid her face in her long mane "please"

Catra's breath hitched as fresh tears roamed down her face, landing on Glimmer's palms "I don't know how"

"Yes you do" she insisted with resolve "I know you are afraid that the moment you let go, everything that you have might go away, but I promise, you'll still have all of us. You don't have to live in pain to feel worthy of having happiness"

Catra's body went limb as she gave into the tears, allowing all her self-hatred, loathing and agony to leave her body. Maybe so it would still take time to completely let go, but she promised herself, she would never have this reason to cry. And a part of her heart broke free after that.

Glimmer was soon face to face with her, hugging her tight, careful not to strain her injured leg. Catra wrapped an arm around cuddling her close "I will" she mumbled into her hair.

Glimmer smiled softly "I know" she stroke her back gently.

After an eternal silence, Catra regained a bit of composure brushing her tears away, not even embarrassed to be seen in such a vulnerable state. She had nothing to hide from the Queen.

Glimmer whipped the last teardrop with her thumb, cupping her cheek caringly. When their eyes met, there was nothing but love in them.

Catra leaned into her touch and nodded, she was going to be alright, she was determined to make good on that.

The Queen rested her forehead against the brunette's.

"You should go find Marazz" Glimmer advised delicately, still holding her cheek "she may not understand all that has happened today, but I'm sure she needs her mom"

Catra nodded well aware of it, she had been dreading to confront her blue eyes and find fear in them. She didn't want her kitten to look at her with terror.

After swallowing the knot on her throat, Catra found her voice again "I…I called Adora" she mumbled.

"She knows?" Glimmer's voice spiked with curiosity.

"Yeah, I told her everything" she exhaled "and she told me how things are up there or…rather how they are not working on our favor"

"Bow is working with her" Glimmer assured trying to ease her up "she'll be here soon tucking in Marazz"

"That's what I hope; that she'd be here to take care of Marazz" she pulled apart in the slightest "Someone has to stay in the ship. I think it's my turn to stand in"

"You are leaving?" Glimmer looked at her puzzled, her mind was reeling, joining the dots to understand her reasoning, but before she could object, a blast of sparkly dust appeared in front of them followed by close footsteps that raced to catch up.

"You promised you wouldn't leave!" Angella said, her voice distraught, her eyes alarmed at the idea.

"Angie?" Glimmer turned to her as Saber ran to her side "Arrow?" the twins stood silent; unsure of what to say or do other than plea with their eyes "You were here the whole time?" Glimmer wasn't sure if she should be scolding them, but their faces revealed something more important.

"You said when you came back from space that you'd never leave again" Angela panted, her fists clenched tight.

Catra was visibly aback "I…I thought it was best if I wasn't here for a while, so you two could work your feelings without me imposing"

"No, you don't get to leave" Saber said firmly "you are our Aunt, you were an aunt to us before you were anything else. That's who

we really know, not the force captain, just you" he said strongly, his eyes watery "you can't go"

"I don't want to hurt you further" Catra admitted, her tone softer than a whisper "you were right to be mad and…whatever you still have to work through, it should be on your own terms" she looked away "Saber, there's still a lot you don't know about me. You deserve better than half-truths"

"I know" he said solemnly "And yes, we had mixed feeling and we still need answers to fully understand the past, from all of you" Saber said pointedly and sharp as the weapons he was named after "but that doesn't mean we don't want you near, you are our Aunt Cat. As long as I can recall that's who you have been to me. Someone I could talk to, a complicit in our pranks and a mother to our cousin" his eyes were close to tears "you don't get to take that away form us. I don't want you to leave"

The older woman bit onto her lower lip keeping herself from breaking down and just then, he enveloped her tightly. And Catra held him back with equal devotion.

"I'm sorry" Angella's voice broke in a mumble, her tone frail and honest "I didn't mean…all the things I said I…I do love you too" she admitted launching into her arms as her brother had "I'm sorry" she sobbed agaisnt her shirt "I'm sorry, please don't go"

Catra felt the air being knocked out of her lungs as reality took a new dimension. She had waited for the worst scenario to come up, but never granted herself even the illusion of something like this happening.

"I love you both too. So, so much" she let go of the cane hugging them tight, just opening her eyes to look over at Glimmer, who gazed at the scene as if it was a beautiful dream she didn't want to disturb. So Catra extended a hand and pulled he into the hug, into her righteous place in her heart.

There was still a lot that needed to be talked about, but at least for now, she could wrap her arms around them with a feeling of safeness and love. They were her family, nothing would change that.

***

Catra limped around the room, she just had checked on Marazz, the kitten was asleep, so she had laid a kiss on her head and left Melog to stay in her bed for the night. Seemed like the space lion had found a new person to care for once more, all while still responding to the emotional link they had towards Catra and Angella.

Catra gazed at the empty bed and sighed, she was half minded to go for her daughter or stay in her room instead. She didn't felt like being alone, but just when she was about to make that decision, the door slammed open and the tall figure of She-Ra walked in.

"Adora?" she asked surprised, ready to leap into her arms when she felt her leg falter "you are back!"

"I am" she smiled relieved, hugging her in the act and carrying her in arms to the matress, kisisng her messily.

Catra could see her tired eyes, so she kissed back earning a moment to catch her breath "Hey, hey, you are home" she cooed "You can turn back, you've been in fight mode for too long, you can let your guard down"

"There's just one thing I need to do first" she pressed a hand over her tight making her yelp as she allowed the bright golden light to flow through her and into her wife. Catra supresed a hiss as the magic took care of the wound.

"I'm sorry" Adora mumbled against her lips kissing tenderly at the corner of her mouth. Once the pain was pushed to the back of her mind and then out of her body, Catra melted as she sighed tiredly.

The blinding light took over the room and now Adora was exhaustedly lying over Catra, breathing shallowly. The feline woman held her close in arms, caressing her hair and purring softly, taking care of the warrior.

"You are home, Adora" she said reassuringly into her ear.

"Catra" she hid into her chest "I thought it was over, I thought I wouldn't have to-" she cut herself short, hugging Catra tighter.

"What is it love?"

Adora raised her chin, gazing at her with soft drained eyes "The world still needs She-Ra" she mumbled "I thought...I hoped that was behind me now but..." her lips quivered.

"It's okay" she kissed her forehead "Right now, I need Adora to be right here in my arms"

The warrior felt moved, giving in into the indulgence of being held and cuddled into her wife's chest again, taking refuge in her warm embrace.

Catra kept on softly stroking until Adora regained some composure and began talking.

"We managed to keep them at bay" she said the recollection of events "Entrapta managed to create a device that works like an electromagnetic pulse, no ship other than First One's can withstand it's effects. As soon as they cross the line, they shut down entirely. Once they were immobilized I would take out their weaponry. It's not a final solution, but it got me home, so..."

Catra traced invisible circles on her shoulder blade, listening closely.

"I'm glad you are here with us"

The door opened ajar, as two pairs of cat ears peeked inside.

"Mommy?" Marazz rubbed her eyes as Melog nudged her inside.

"Hi, lil' Mara" Adora sat up ready to take her in arms "I missed you so much, kitten" she cuddled her close kissing her face repeatedly, to which Marazz laughed making no effort in pulling away, she loved it too much.

Once the commotion quieted down, Marazz grabbed Adora's face pressing their heads together "You didn't tucked me in" she said, her ears tilting down.

Adora's smile slip a little "You know? I can do that right now" she settled their daughter in the middle of the bed pulling the cover up to her chin. Both gazed at their kid with proudly, wishing that days like this could come more often.

"I didn't get my kiss either" Marazz added looking at Catra with those big round innocent eyes.

Catra's ears bend down apologetically "I did, but you were already asleep" she leaned down kissing her forehead "I'm sorry I wasn't with you today"

Marazz played with the fabric in her small hands "It's alright, Uncle Bow played with me" she gazed up at both shrugging her shoulders "Are you okay?"

Catra felt the ache in her heart as she gazed up at Adora, in her blue eyes she could see that mutual understanding "Yeah, kitten. I'll be okay" she rubbed her tummy gently "but there's...there's a story I need- we need to tell you before bed"

"A story?" she asked tilting her head to a side in that adorable gesture that melted their hearts.

"Yes. Our story" Adora added "we want to tell you ourselves, is that alright?"

Marazz nodded as Melog jumped at the feet of the bed curling there.

"I think we'll start by saying how much we love you" Adora said gazing up at Catra "Because at the end, what is our story if not a long journey trying to find love?" she smiled longly at her wife.

Catra gazed at her as if she was the sun , the light that sparked joy in her life. And Marazz was the result of that fire, their torch, a legacy they were both proud of.

Chapter End Notes

I've had planned to write this chapter for a long time, but as I finally got to it, I realized how much I had to get in as this is virtually the penultimate update and I wanted to get a bit of perspective from as many characters as possible without it feeling overwhelming (who knows if I succeeded XP) and I've received so much amazing feedback that I really didn't want to let anyone down! So this is the result!

I really appreciate all the incredible support this fic has had and even though it saddens me (and scares me) to conclude this journey, I do think there's just one more arc for me to tell before saying farewell. Maybe later on I will add a one-shot or something of the sort developing in this same timeline, but for now, I think we are getting ready for the end.

I hope to see you all when it does happen!

Your sincerely, Zee!

Chapter 14

Chapter Notes

> So, you might cry...
>
> Honestly I think I'm more nervous about you reading this than yourselves, but here we go, "We're on the edge of greatness..."

See the end of the chapter for more notes

By the time the sun began to shine through the horizon, Marazz was already running down the hall, skillfully moving more feline-like than her own mother, using all four. No one ever told her not to, so she was free to express herself. The one downside of her wild march was that her long silky golden mane always got in her eyes and she would try to move it out of the way, for which she didn't quite saw the cloud of sparkles that materialize in front of her, so she ran into the figure that caught her in a tight embrace giggling as they stumbled to the ground.

"Angie!" Marazz smiled at her cousin as the 19-year-old fixed her tiara.

"I knew you would be up already" the princess smirked sitting up before properly hugging her "Happy birthday!"

Marazz embraced back excitedly "Thank you!"

"Thirteen already" she ruffled her hair making sure not to bend backward her ears "feels like just yesterday you were chasing your own tail" she grinned teasingly "and now you are just running through the castle with your eyes closed, pretty sure that's not how your night vision works"

Marazz smirked sheepishly "They were open" she shrugged standing up to offer her a hand "my hair just got in the way"

"You could wear it as your mom used to, I could style it for you, but maybe without the puffy thing on top," she accepted her palm getting off the floor.

Marazz chuckled "I want to try something else, something more… mine?" she offered.

Angella smiled softly, she too understood wanting to stand outside the shadow of her role models, she wanted her own path to follow "I get it, Mar-Mar" she nodded "but for now, try to keep it behind your shoulders because there's a whole feast waiting for you" she smiled endearingly wrapping an arm around her and teleporting them into the dining room where everyone was gathered with a huge banner that read "Happy Birthday" as they all shouted and cheered for her.

Marazz's ears and tail spiked up as she jolted at the reception taking a huge jump back before catching up to the events, blushing madly and laughing. They all snickered at her reaction before reaching her to bear hugs and congratulations.

Her mothers were the first to cuddle her tight, squeezing with might.

"Happy birthday, kiddo" Catra smiled proudly at her.

"Our Kitten is growing up so fast" Adora pressed kissed left and right.

"Mom" she complained shyly, folding her ears back.

"What? Are we embarrassing you in front of your cool cousins?" the blonde teased letting her slip away "Are you too old now for your mothers to smother you with affection?" she raised a brow smirking smugly.

Marazz tried to show annoyance, but the smile rapidly took over as she wrapped her arms around her for a brief hug "not yet"

Adora chuckled "Good" she kissed her head, letting her go to her uncle and aunt.

"Congratulations, sweetie" Glimmer cuddled her in arms feeling the feline fully lean against her chest, purring lightly.

"Thanks, Aunty" she swayed her tail energetically as she went to hug Bow as well.

"I can't believe you are so grown up!" he said picking from the ground in a tight embrace "you are always going to be our little kitty"

She chuckled breathlessly as he settled her back down.

Saber quickly took over and hugged her as well. He had turned out to be the taller twin and tended to act a bit more overprotective when it came to her.

"Happy birthday, 'cuz"

"Thanks" she tiptoed to be able to rest her chin over his shoulder.

"Now let's have our little celebration" they moved to the table where all sorts of sweets were "we know you said no party, but this doesn't count"

"This is perfect!" she grabbed a plate serving huge portions of cake and pastries "thank you" she gazed up smiling at all of them, her actions were always genuine and open. She was trusting and confident; her mothers had made sure to raise her with all their love, so she would never live the struggles they had. And her smile right now, it made it all worth it.

They shared a meal full of anecdotes and laughter. Most of the stories involved embarrassing things Marazz had done throughout her life thus far. From chasing after her mother's tail and biting down hard making her yelp, to the times she had sneaked into the kitchen with her cousins and had caught a few mice.

Once the food was gone, both mothers stood up sharing a knowing look "Hey Kitten, come with us, we have something to show you"

Her ears perked up as her tail swayed excitedly "Where are we going?" she turned to her cousins.

"You go, we'll meet later" Saber explained, they were in the loop of their aunts' plans.

"Yeah, we'll have a picnic at the woods later, so we have to pack" Angella nodded "go have fun"

Marazz nodded leaping out of her seat reaching them, not before turning over her shoulder and waving goodbye at the four of them "Thank you for the surprise!"

"You are welcome sweetie" Glimmer smirked "see you in a bit" she nodded at her moms, happy that they were tacking her to see that place…

***

Melog greeted them at the gates as they reached Darla at the garden making Marazz's eyes grow wide.

"We are taking the ship?!" she turned to them awestruck.

"We are not going very far, but yes, we'll take Darla" Adora smiled pleased with her excitement "So you can help us pilot"

"Yes!" she ran inside reaching the controls. It was rare when they would use the vehicle, but Marazz had sneaked in once or twice with her cousins to see the panels. By now she was familiarized enough with the controllers to know each function, but she never

had dared to take it for a joy ride, so this was the first time she would be helping fly it.

Catra sat back letting her wife take over the driving lesson "Take us off the ground, little one" she caressed Melog's head.

Marazz eagerly took over the ship under Adora's guidance and soon enough they were flying away from Bright Moon and into the woods.

"You are doing very well" the warrior praised as they smoothly soared the sky.

"Thanks, mom" she smiled hugely.

After a few minutes of flight, Catra stood up once she recognized the scenery. Melog's mane turned a different shade, not red as when she felt threatened or angry, but just…moved, in a way.

"Okay, Marazz, see that valley?" Adora pointed at the horizon "we are going to land there, alright? Now be careful a lot of the surface is not as firm as it looks"

"Understood" she turned, directing the ship, but her movements were a bit rapid and erratic for the landing, which turned out to be rougher than expected.

They shook trying to keep balance.

"Sorry! I'm sorry, mom. I'll do better next time, I promise" she rapidly said, ears bent back apologetically.

"It's okay" Adora reassured patting her back "it was a pretty good attempt for your first time"

"Yeah, you should have seen how my first time behind the controllers was, Aunt Entrapta almost fainted. And I was way older than you" Catra added standing up to open the door "Now come on, we have something to see"

Marazz smiled timidly, running with Melog to the exterior, leaving them behind for a second.

Catra waited for Adora at the door, arms folded "You saw it that time, right?" she pointed trying not to sound accusing "I talked to her about self-worth, I'm afraid this topic is on you, love. She keeps pushing herself to be perfect, and she does it for you"

Adora uncomfortably looked away releasing the air she had been holding "I…I've noticed" she admitted "It's been happening a bit more lately" she rubbed her neck "While we train and at fencing practice with Saber"

Catra frowned concerned about both of them, Adora seems almost as distressed as their daughter when it came to the topic "You need to talk to her, it could make you some good too"

"I just… it's complicated" she hugged herself defensibly. She had her own demons of the past to deal with when it came to that, the last thing she wanted was her kitten to walk into those footsteps, but addressing the situation made her beyond nervous and she couldn't quite place why.

"I understand, love" she reached for her arms pressing gently "but she needs to hear not only from mighty warrior She-Ra, but from her mother that you'll always be proud of her"

"She knows that!"

"It doesn't hurt to hear it once in a while; she really looks up to you"

Adora dropped her shoulders "Tonight, I'll talk to her tonight after her birthday celebration is over"

Catra smiled fondly "If you need me I'll be there"

"Thanks, but…maybe I should do this one on my own"

"Very well, then" she leaned in kissing her heartedly "now come on, this is something we've waited for a long time" she grabbed her hand as they reached the vast valley that expanded with nothing but green for miles.

Marazz was running freely from one side to another being chase by Melog as they played around.

"Hey Kitten" Catra called as the teen rolled in the flowers next to the space lion. Marazz ran up to them making sure to walk normally the last few steps to come to a full stop.

"Yeah, mom?"

Catra wrapped an arm around her gazing at the scenery "you see those hills over there?" she pointed at the protuberances at the short distance. The ground there was uneven forming unnatural bulbs.

"Yes"

"What does this whole place makes you feel?" she asked gently.

Marazz twitched an ear thinking through it. She felt the wind blowing her hair, the soft grass under her toes, the flowery scent that flowed around her "I feel…free" she decided "it's so open and fresh…it's…a sense of safeness" she decided with resolve.

"That is our gift to you," Adora said softly, pressing her lips to her head's crown "all that we have done up to this point has been so that you could have that" she cooed sweetly.

"You know why we brought you here?" Catra inquired delicately as their daughter shook no "this…" she gestured around "this used to be the Fright Zone"

Marazz's skin crawled at the words "The Horde?"

"Yeah, many, many years ago all this was a military base, where your mom and I were raised" Adora confirmed.

"The place from all your stories" she knelt down looking at it in a new perspective "It's…it's all gone"

"Exactly" they sat at each side of their kitten "all that we fought for was so that you could have peace and freedom" Adora caressed the back of her head.

"We wanted to take you here so you'd know, you can make your own path, kitten," Catra said "no matter how hard or impossible it seems, you'll always have a choice"

"And we'll support you, no matter what. You'll always have us by your side" Adora leaned in, cuddling her.

They stood like that for countless seconds, just gazing at the horizon of 'what ifs' and 'could haves' and as the sun washed over the valley exalting its beauty, Marazz finally find the words.

"Thank you, moms"

***

By the time Darla touched down at Bright Moon again, the twins were already eager for her arrival.

"How was it?" they asked.

"It was…" she gazed over her shoulder at her moms "really something" she smiled heartedly.

"Well, ready to go for a picnic?"

"Ready!" she smirked endearingly, her tail moving energetically.

"Okay, let's check we have everything packed" Saber leaned in to whisper "especially the chocolate"

"We heard that" Glimmer interrupted.

"Have to go, sorry mom!" Angella grabbed their shoulders teleporting them away.

The parents chuckled, gathering among themselves.

"I guess one day of pure sweets can't be that bad" Glimmer leaned into Bow, grabbing his arm "how was it?"

"Special" Catra offered.

"It's almost surreal there's nothing left" Adora mused out loud "going there and having nothing tie us to that place it felt… liberating"

"It really did" Catra sighed calmly "after so long we've finally earned a little peace of mind"

"Yeah, there isn't anything left to torment us" Adora hugged Catra from behind resting her chin over her wife's shoulder.

"That's the best part" Bow smiled sweetly "now that the past is behind us, how about we enjoy the present?"

"Sounds great" Adora kissed Catra's cheek before letting go to help pack.

"Why don't you make sure the kids don't take the whole pantry?" Bow suggested Glimmer, something showing in his eyes, perhaps concern "try not to carry anything heavy" he pleaded.

"You okay, Sparkles?" Catra asked noticing the exchange.

Glimmer rapidly waved a hand dismissingly beating Bow to the explanation "Yeah, all good. I've just been behind a desk too many days in a row, my back hurts, it's all" she smiled more naturally "but today is to celebrate Marazz, so let's not make them wait, we still have a bit of a walk ahead of us"

"No teleporting?" Catra folded her arms smirking "Ran out of sparkles?"

"Please, you still get nauseous every time we take a long jump" Glimmer retorted teasingly "would you really rather risk it?"

"Hey, I'm not complaining about a little hike" she raised her hands smirking "you are the one that usually can' take ten steps before using your powers. Which you haven't done in a while, actually" Catra mentioned looking back at the last few days.

"Apparently dignitaries don't find it proper when a monarch jumps out of nowhere into a meeting room" Glimmer excused casually.

"So settling down a little is in order" Bow added.

"You are the Queen, do whatever you want"

"And what I want right now is a walk, so move along Princess Catra"

The feline rolled her eyes at the nickname "Can we go back to Horde Scum? I think I like that one better"

"No, I'm the Queen and I can do whatever I want, remember?"

Bow shook his head, amused by their bickering "Well, while you figure this out, I'll help Adora, see you at the main gate"

"Race you to it" Catra smirked watching him leave a bit faster than his usual pace.

Catra chuckled shaking her head "Let's go, Sparkles, time to find the kids before they leave the baker without any supplies" she threw a hand around the shorter woman's shoulders feeling her flinch and biting down a groan. Catra rapidly removed her arm inspecting the reaction.

"Sorry, my back really hurts" Glimmer explained shyly, rubbing the area.

"And are you sure you should be moving?" Catra asked aback, that was more than mere discomfort, the Queen seemed to be in pain.

"Yeah, it's a lot better when I'm standing, actually" she assured "now come on, we have a picnic ahead of us" she grabbed her arm and dragged her along.

***

They were under the shadow of a dozen trees, a tablecloth laid over the ground as they enjoyed the food and games, some more so than others.

"And that's three in a row" Marazz announced as she proclaimed her victory once again.

"Come on!" Bow gazed at the board completely dumbfounded "How?"

"Face it, you haven't been able to beat her at any strategy game since she turned eight" Catra smirked proudly.

"I was just letting her win back then" he folded his arms stubbornly puffing his chest out.

"Pretty sure she was letting you win before that, dad" Saber grinned widely.

"My own son!" Bow dramatically threw a hand to his forehead "how can you say such things?" he mocked before turning to his opponent "Good game, kiddo"

"Thanks, uncle" she smiled at him "do you want a rematch?"

"I'm good" he rubbed the back of his neck.

"Why don't you go explore a little?" Adora suggested, getting her daughter to look up expectantly.

"Deeper into the woods?" she asked, her tail swinging excitedly.

"Let's go!" Angella stood up dusting her hands off.

"Yeah, we'll keep an eye on her" Saber winked in complicity taking his own quiver and bow.

"Be back before sunset, okay?" Glimmer asked.

"Sure mom" Angella nodded before turning to them "need a lift?"

"I'll manage" Saber tensed his bow aiming at a high branch and using a wrapping hook version of an arrow swinging to the top of a tree "You coming?"

Marazz rapidly ran to the oaks beginning to climb skillfully to reach him.

"Please keep an eye on her, Little Sparkle" Catra asked her niece.

"Of course, Aunty," she said heartedly before turning into a cloud of dust and appearing several feet over the ground at the top of the tree.

"Can you believe how grown up they are?" Adora asked leaning back to rest her head on her wife's lap, taking the moment to relax.

"Yeah, it seemed like just yesterday you were coming back to Etheria"

"Tell me about it" Catra huffed leaning down to kiss Adora upside down.

"And now things are so different" Bow exhaled wistfully, "I think we did it guys"

Adora sighed "Not quite, not yet" she rubbed her hands together, throughout all her maternity years; she had to also be She-Ra, to answer the call and leave at a moment's notice. Her sacrifice was worth it because everyone she loved was safe, but wearing the title of hero was something that started to weight down on her shoulder more each time.

"Sadly, I agree" Glimmer added "the absence of conflict doesn't mean we are at peace. Especially with our close-by neighbors," she said bitterly.

"Well, I'll back up Bow on this one," Catra said rolling her fingers through blonde hair "The fact that we are here, together and enjoying the day, I think we've made it big time"

Adora gazed up at her smiling lovingly; reaching up to kiss her again "Moments like this certainly make it worth it" the warrior said dreamingly "makes me feel free"

***

Free, was the word that ran through Marazz's head as she leaped from one branch tree to the next in agile movements. She could feel in touch with everything around her, her senses on high alert, driving her through the activity with ease. This was definitely her scenery, not behind castle walls attending meetings and smiling at formals. She could always tell her own mothers looked rather bored and a bit out of element when they had to attend as active members of royalty to those dreadful events, but they would always look dignified while being there.

She on the other hand, would bear with it for the first two hours before fading into the background in search of her cousins to teleport away. Most balls they would end up on the rooftop eating and chatting. She could see in their faces that they too yearned

for more. And as they explore the woods with equal enthusiasm as her, she could tell that right now, they felt free as well.

Maybe if she hadn't been so focused on reading their smiles, she would have minded her footing, luckily for the youngest of them, Saber did notice.

"Wait! That's going to snap!" he shouted, but Marazz was already midair aiming at the dry branch that gave away under her weight, breaking in two "Angie!" he urged.

"On it" she teleported catching her in arms trusting her brother to smooth their landing as Saber shot a net that worked as a trampoline decelerating their fall as they bounced on the web.

Saber let go of his rope landing next to them while they laughed.

"You have to be careful, Rascal Razz" Angella scolded lightly, arm around her shoulders, snuggling her close as Saber laid down on the opposite side as they gazed at the clear blue sky.

"I just got distracted" Marazz smiled innocently.

"Your hair got in the way again?" she moved the loose buckles out of her eyes.

"No, I was just thinking…that I really like this" she admitted "being out here"

"Me too" Saber exhaled looking at the many planets he could still see at broad daylight "ever wonder what's beyond?"

"We know what's beyond, our parents have been there, we've heard the stories" Angella replied.

"I know, I mean…how it would be to see it"

Angella sighed, that thought had crossed her mind more often than not "Yeah, that must really be something"

"Well, I guess we'll at least get to know the kingdoms close by" Arrow added "Our diplomatic missions will start soon"

"We are going to our Aunts' lands, it feels more like a family visit and a long sleepover than a mission" Angella smirked.

"We'll still have time to have days like this, right?" Marazz spoke up, her voice carrying something in it "when you come back?" she had feared that the age gap between them would end up being too notorious. The twins would always try to spend time with her, but their duties had called upon them and as her moms had explained, a bit of a divide should be expected.

"Of course" Angella assured putting those fears at ease with the sweetness in her tone "we'll just be gone for a month at a time, but as soon as we are back home we can have picnics and game nights"

Saber nodded in agreement "Yeah, we are team, Mar-Mar. The Super Best Friend Trio"

They all chuckled "That was terrible" Angella teased.

"Hey, I bet dad and Aunt Scorpia would be proud"

"Definitely" she snickered looking at the sun, "I think we should head back" she raise a hand waiting for them to take it. And as soon as they held each other, a puff of sparkles took them away.

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"Look who's back" Glimmer greeted noticing the bright flash before anyone else could.

"How was your walk?" Adora stood up reaching them.

"Fun!"

"I'm glad"

"Do you guys want to go back to the castle now?" Bow inquired.

"No way" Saber shook his head "We haven't even had a match yet" he raised a brow ready to challenge his dad to a competition, Bow vs. Arrow.

The King, of course, took the bait grabbing his own weapon "Let's go"

"Race you to the top of the tree, mom?" Marazz asked Catra, feeling like the other two had the right idea.

"It's on" she stood up going as well.

"What do you say? Let's teleport" Angella smirked.

"You already have me beat, I don't think I was able to move like you until I turned 24" she admitted going to her daughter as well.

Adora smirked petting Melog as she saw them play around. She would have never guessed when she was younger, not even in her wildest dreams, that her future would be so perfect.

They played and dared each other for a while. Arrow had actually managed to beat Bow in the final encounter and although it wasn't clear if Bow had missed the mark on purpose, he looked downright proud of his son. Glimmer had been giving advice to Angella regarding how to predict movements and keep her momentum so each jump still had the energy of the last and she didn't have to build it up from scratch. And Marazz was happily running around chasing and being chased; that until Catra gave in coming back to the ground.

"You win, little one," she said panting, reaching Adora's side "I can't believe I'm growing old," she said breathlessly "she outran me"

Adora ran a hand down her sweaty forehead affectionately "You put quite a fight"

"Mom" Marazz called "can we practice swords?" she inquired and Catra laughed looking at Adora.

"Let's see how you put up a fight"

Adora huffed pulling at one of her ears lightly "I'll show you how" she stood up while Catra called after her.

"Yeah, you are welcome! I've already tired her out!"

Marazz awaited eagerly while Adora handed her the wooden swords they had brought because of course, she had foreseen her daughter wanting to duel on her birthday.

They prepared their stances mirroring each other. Catra just loved how much they were alike and moments like these reminded her how much.

"Whenever you are ready, kitten" Adora invited and Marazz took that as her signal, taking a step closer to give the first blow. The warrior easily evaded taking a step back and deflecting the blow "Don't make big movements, you are announcing your attack" Adora pointed and at each effort, she would give feedback. Marazz would listen to the advice closely, improving her technique but frustration was building up inside, she wanted to be good enough for her and Adora didn't seem to realize that.

Catra sighed deciding to intervene in the slightest "She's going to swing high" she predicted the movement Adora was going to make, successful preventing Marazz from getting struck "now low" she said again and Marazz took a jump "Good, now switch your stance and try to get behind her"

Marazz smirked and slid down with her catlike reflexes to then stand at her mom's back ready to strike.

Adora barely had time to deflect the swing "Hey! That's cheating!"

"Sorry love, just helping my kid"

"I'm your wife, you know?"

"Meh, you can't blame me for reading you so easily" Catra stuck her tongue out "How about you call it a draw?"

"I can keep going," Adora said "How about you?" she turned to Marazz.

"Adora," Catra said in a firm tone sending her a look that said 'enough'. The warrior had to then take note of how hard she was pushing her daughter, so she backtracked offering a smile "you are right, it's going to get dark soon" she set the sword down walking to Marazz and putting a hand on her shoulder "you were really good, kitten" she drove her to her arms hugging her "you are great"

Marazz exhaled tiredly, allowing herself to melt into the embrace "Thanks mom, I'll keep practicing"

Catra smiled, they were getting there but a conversation was still necessary "Okay you two, come sit down and relax"

"That was relaxing" Adora countered.

"Only you would say something like that" she teased.

"Hey, Aunty Adora" Saber called "can we see the sword? The actual one" he asked eager to see She-Ra's weapon.

Adora smirked proudly "Of course" she effortlessly conjured it into existence grabbing it midair. The massive piece of weaponry shone before their eyes.

"Showoff" Catra teased getting Glimmer to laugh along.

"Don't pretend you mind the view" she raised a brow enticingly making her blush before turning to them "here you go, give it a go" she handed the sword to her first-ever student. Saber was not

used to the dimensions of the sword. He preferred something resembling more the shape of the blade he was named after. He moved it around in the usual posture and technique they practiced over and over and although his movements were precise and centered, he didn't have the grace or balance to wield it as properly as something more refined.

"Too robust?" she asked noticing his struggle.

"Yeah, I prefer something lighter" he gripped it tighter; the weight was definitely a setback for him. He needed to move quickly and on point and this weapon was for a more blunt out front approach, opposite to his nature.

Adora nodded emphatically "Sometimes you have to be chosen by your armament. And I think you already have, since birth, actually"

He smirked, he liked that she didn't diminish his effort nor made him feel less of a warrior for not being able to maneuver the sword "Thanks, Aunty" he handed it back.

"Can I try, mom?" Marazz's voice rose up, sounding rather nervous.

Adora turned to her. In all those years of transforming into She-Ra, she had never requested to hold or even see up close the multifunctional weapon, Adora had thought it was because she resented it a little, the fact that every time the sword was there, it meant Adora would have to go away and save the day.

"Of course" she smiled sweetly presenting her the blade.

Marazz gripped it firmly managing to steady it by keeping her stance as Catra would. It was a weird amalgam of the two fighting styles she knew. She has Adora's force and will mix with Catra's strategy and speed. The teen began swinging it around; it didn't felt foreign at all. It was as if she had wielded it her whole life, probably because she had grown next to it and the familiarity

could be accounted because it was her mother's sword, Marazz reasoned.

Adora smiled at how confident her kitten was, her posture was firm but not stiff, her grip was secure without it being tense, she seemed so in tune.

"Really nice form," she said "maybe that's your kind of weapon after all"

Marazz face lit up at her words "Just like you?"

"Just like me" she nodded.

"You look so much like Adora right now," Glimmer said "like the first time we found her in the woods"

"I'm pretty sure she was scared and confused" Catra snorted.

"No! I mean yes, she was, but that's not what I'm talking about! You are showing that kind of energy as the first time Adora was drawn to her sword"

"That feels like an eternity ago," Bow said gazing at the past.

"It was" Adora huffed in agreement.

"And you were blaming us too for turning into a princess as if that was contagious" Glimmer added laughing at the memory.

Adora turned beet red, she wanted to refute by pointing out the fact that she was raised by Horde, but then again, so was Catra and she was definitely not oblivious to a lot of things she was.

"Don't worry babe, it was contagious enough, they turned me into one as well" Catra chuckled.

"I could still officially change your title to Princess Kitty, you know?" Glimmer jabbed teasingly making Catra's skin crawl.

"Don't you dare, Sparkles"

While they joked with one another, their kids gazed at them amusedly.

"How in the world did they saved the galaxy?" Saber mumbled at the other two.

"More than likely by accident"

They snickered among themselves.

"Hey, Mar" Angie called "how does it feel to have the most powerful weapon on the universe?"

The young teen tilted one ear looking for the words "Right?" she tried "I don't know, fitting I guess"

"Right now we look like exact replicas of our parents" Angella chuckled loudly.

"That's meant to be a full-blown compliment, right?" Saber snorted.

"Oh, sure" Angella answered with feigned innocence mimicking one of her mother's infamous pouts, making them giggle.

"Wait, let me try dad's hero pose" Saber climbed a rock posing with his bow in a theatrical way that invited the imagination to add flashes of light in the background.

Marazz laughed so hard the adults even turned to see what they were up to.

"Your turn" the twins smirked.

Marazz's smile turned from amused to cunning as she gazed at the sword "For the Honor of Grayskull!" she swung the sword up in the air in her most faithful imitation of Adora's performance ready to get a reaction out of them. But then the sudden white flash washed over her and a blinding light wrapped around her body as she for a second lost the concept or herself just to re-

emerge as part of something bigger than her own existence. And then the feeling wasn't foreign anymore, instead, it felt like it was now a part of her and as she gazed down to herself she found the ground to be farther away and her body to be built and buzzing with pure energy. She was…

"She-Ra?" she heard Adora's voice call with such…hurt?

Marazz quickly turned into her direction to see her shocked eyes gaze up at her in disbelief. The others were just as struck; no one dared to move or even breathe.

"It can't be" Adora mumbled covering her mouth as tears overflown her eyes.

The scene itself was enough to make Marazz snap out of it, throwing the sword to the ground, breaking the link, going back to her true self as she stumbled backwards falling to the ground.

All eyes were on her as she hyperventilated, a million questions running through her mind as panic took over her body. Why were they looking at her like that? Why did all the adults seem so distressed? So…so scared? She quickly scrambled to her feet running to Angella's arms as they wrapped around her protectively. Arrow rapidly stood by them trying to soothe her.

"Please, let's go" she pleaded her cousin as her words brought everyone back to reality.

"Wait- go?" Catra repeated alarmed, ready to take a step forward to intervene.

"Please" Marazz turned back to Angie begging with her teary eyes.

Angella gazed back up at them and in the split of a second knew exactly what she needed to do "I'm sorry" she said honestly, her tone failing to hide her own worry as she hugged her tight, taking Arrow's hand as well.

"Angella!" Glimmer reached out a hand to interfere with the teleportation through a magic seal, but Saber had already thrown a smoke bomb that covered them as they disappeared.

"Come back!" the Queen urged distressed trying to sense where they could have teleported off to as night fell upon them.

"We have to move quickly!" Catra turned around "If they are close by I could follow their scent"

"They couldn't have gone far; Angella had already used a lot of her powers" Glimmer corroborated, ready to mobilize.

"Stop!" Bow shouted, getting everyone to stay still for a hectic moment "Don't follow them" he said gently.

"Are you out of your mind?!" Catra hissed, her canines showing "We don't know where they are, at the edge of night and my kid just turned into mighty She-Ra!" she raged getting in his face, but Bow was unfazed.

"Yes, and as scary and unnerving as that is, it's ten times worst for her and my kids"

"All the more reason we should go to them!" Glimmer shouted exasperated "It's not the time to take things calmly Bow!"

"Listen to me!" he rose his voice without shouting "She chose to go to them" he argued gently "And they are good kids, you raised them" he grabbed Glimmer's shoulders gazing at her eyes with love and empathy before turning to Catra "Marazz will be safe as long as she's with them, they won't let anything bad happen to her, she just needs time and space and right now, who she needs is not us, it's them" he let go of Glimmer "They know the way home and when they are ready, I'm sure they will reach us there. We have to trust them"

Glimmer let go of the swirling emotions turning her insides, gazing down "He's right"

"I can't sit here and do nothing!" Catra yelled turning around "Adora, we have to-" she gazed at her wife who had crumbled to the ground next to the sword "Adora?" her voice turned concerned as the warrior gazed up at her with streaming rivers pouring down her chin.

"I can't feel a connection anymore, Catra" her voice broke, but Catra's heart shattered at the sight of her wife so defeated "It can't be, she can't be She-Ra" Adora pleaded, choking on sobs "I've done everything to keep the peace, there shouldn't be a new She-Ra, she can't get that burden, she can't be in that danger, please" she clutched the sword to her body begging for the bond to spark again "All I ever did as She-Ra was to make sure she would be safe. She can't be, please, not her" Catra rapidly fell to the ground to wrap her in arms holding her together "Not our girl, please not her"

"I've got you, love" Catra mumbled into her hair "You did nothing wrong, Adora. You took care of our kitten; you didn't fail her or anyone"

"I did, Catra, I couldn't protect her" she clenched into her shirt giving a heartbreaking sob.

Soon Bow and Glimmer were at her side embracing her as well. They too knew the long journey Adora had to face by being the chosen one, a task she never asked for and that had changed her life forever and now…now the same responsibility was falling on her daughter's shoulders.

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Angella had teleported off in such a chaotic way she hadn't even visualized a place to run off to, she had let her instincts guide her blindly and now, as they re-appeared in the middle of the forest, she realized they were falling to the ground. Arrow didn't have a

chance to set a net either, so they crash-landed after breaking a couple of branches on the way down.

"I'm sorry, sorry" Angella apologized profusely holding her side after the wind had been knocked out of her lungs, but all pain and discomfort were forgotten at the sound of Marazz sniffing and doing her best to suppress the crying.

"Hey" Saber softly laid a hand on her shoulder, but Marazz shrugged more into herself, a hand tightly clenching her tail as comfort "It's okay, 'cuz. We've got you"

The teen rapidly launched into his arms, hiding there as Saber gently stroked her back.

"What's wrong with me?" she asked brokenly.

"Nothing is wrong with you," Angella said with unmovable resolve.

"You just turned into She-Ra," Saber said trying to transmit excitement "that's incredible"

But Marazz shook her head against his shoulder "The look on my mom's eyes… I-I've never seen her so disappointed on me" she sniffed refusing to show her face.

"Aunt Adora would never be disappointed in you" Angella stated firmly, caressing the back of her head "You caught her by surprise, same with everyone else"

"Yeah," Saber said gently "No one was expecting that, it's…it's beyond bizarre something like this would happen"

"It doesn't make sense" Marazz finally let go of the embrace pushing the tears away with the hill of her hand "I don't want…" her lip quivered, she couldn't bring herself to say the words.

"Hey" Saber called gently "Whatever this is and whatever happens, we'll be here for you"

"He's right" Angella softly brushed her cheek drying the remaining teardrops "You'll always have us"

Marazz smiled genuinely at them, knowing fully well they meant their words.

Once sure she had settled a bit more, they took in the second problem at hand.

"Sis?" Saber called "Where…are we?" he looked around, nothing seemed familiar and the growing darkness wasn't helping.

Angella stood up trying to recognize something, her powers wouldn't take her somewhere unfamiliar, or at least that's what she thought "I'm…I'm not sure" she admitted, "I didn't really aim for a specific place" she created a ball of light to hover over their heads.

"Can you take us home from here?"

Angella did an effort to conjure enough sparkles, but her previous games and the unexpected last jump had dried her out "Probably not in one jump, I don't know how far away we are"

Arrow checked his quiver "Okay, I have enough provisions, we should walk the first part and rely on your powers as a last resort, in case we run into something"

And as if fate had heard them, branches snapped and the bush in front of them ruffled.

"Marazz, stay behind us" Angella extended an arm protectively while the other started to draw a sigil with the same dexterity as her grandfather.

Arrow was already aiming while covering the other flank "I keep it at bay, you take her out of here" he instructed "ready?"

And just as they were about to execute their plan, Marazz's eyes caught sight of something they couldn't in the pitch-black night.

"Wait!" she urged jumping in front of them.

"Marazz!" Angella called ready to yank her from harm's way when suddenly a figure appeared.

"What took you so long?" a familiar voice called them and the twins finally saw under Angie's light what the feline had.

"Madame Razz?"

"Well come on, let's go inside, the tea is getting cold" she turned around without further explanation.

The three of them exchanged looks trying to figure out what was happening.

"Are you coming?!" Madame Razz called already several steps ahead.

"I…guess we are" Saber shrugged as they started following her.

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Catra rested her head against the outside of her room's door. Adora was on the other side, spiraling down and she felt powerless to do anything about it. She could hear every hitched breath, every sniffle, and choked sob. She could also hear her own heart breaking and then another sound…

"Aren't we usually on opposite sides of the door?" Catra asked without turning around.

"I guess we can agree today is, by all means, unusual" Glimmer answered walking towards her.

"Came here to try to talk to Adora?"

"No, I'm actually here for you" she admitted "right now I don't think Adora can process anything I'm about to say. I'm hoping you will…"

Catra turned around rapidly "We are chasing after the kids, right?" she asked already taking her hand and driving her down the hall "If we can find Angella's tracker you could teleport us there and-"

"I can't" Glimmer sentenced coming to a halt.

"What do you mean? Bow won't even notice we are gone, we-"

"Catra" she insisted tugging her arm free "I can't" she repeated firmly, looking into her mismatched eyes.

"What are you talking about Sparkles?" her sudden fire changed to concern seeing how weak the Queen's tone and posture were.

Glimmer couldn't hold her gaze as she twiddled her thumbs nervously "You…could say I…did run out of Sparkles" she tried to offer a smile at their inner joke, but her face seemed far from cheerful.

"I'm-I'm not following. Do you need to recharge? Let's got to the crystal and-"

"No, it's not that" she reached for her hand holding tightly trying to ease her up, Catra was so accelerated she wasn't listening closely "I need you to hear me, alright? So, deep breath and let go slowly, just like Perfuma says"

Catra frowned but admitted to herself she was acting purely on instinct. She breathed in and exhaled longly, her ears tilting down. Glimmer smiled appreciatively at her effort before softly caressing the back of her hand with her thumb.

"You…you were right, earlier today, when…when you took notice that I haven't used my power in a while, it's…it's because I don't have it anymore" Catra felt a punch in her gut and as she was about to make a million questions from how that could be to

inquiring about her health, Glimmer was already talking again "There's nothing wrong with that," she said gently "You've seen Angella, her teleportation has grown so much lately, she's way more skilled than I ever was" she smiled proudly despite herself "All my magic has been passed down to her"

Catra felt herself relax in the slightest knowing Glimmer's safety wasn't an issue. It also explained why she hadn't tried to teleport after their kids in the woods "Are you holding up alright with that?" Catra asked and it melted Glimmer that she would take a moment to make sure she was coping with such an extreme change.

"Yeah, I'm going to be okay" she looked down "But…there's one more thing" she let go of her hand "Bow is the only one that knows, I-I wanted to give the news at a better time, but given the circumstances" she unbuttoned the cape, letting it drop to the ground just for a pair of splendid wings to spread behind her.

Catra jumped back in shock "What the-? Are those yours? Your- you tattoos?"

Glimmer blushed, shyly looking down "Yes I…they finally grew, I'm-I'm like my mother now" she smiled sweetly at the reminiscence.

For a moment all Catra could picture was that "She would have been proud" she said genuinely.

Glimmer nodded empathetically before averting her eyes unsure of how to address her point "Magic usually only expresses itself like this when change is upon us" she explained "I have my mother's torch, Angella has mine" she began "that today Marazz turned into She-Ra…that isn't a coincidence. It's not by chance"

Catra felt the cold stab of reality sinking in "No, no, but- we've, we've restored magic, we-"

"We finished our mission, yes. But this isn't about us" she said delicately trying to reach her hands again "I know this is scary

and confusing but…magic works that way and the fact that Marazz was ready-"

"She isn't ready" Catra cut her off, not out of spite, but with utter sadness dripping through her voice "She just turned 13 today" she sniffed as the words caught up in her throat, she had been so worried about finding them and keeping Adora from crumbling that she hadn't had the time to process it herself "I almost lost Adora to that sword before, I can't let it take my kid too"

"Oh, Catra" Glimmer wrapped her arms around her tightly, gently rubbing her back, letting her cry against her "there's nothing I can say to make this better, but I promise, you won't have to face this alone and as long as we can help it, we won't let Marazz be in any danger"

"But she will be in danger, sooner or later" she sniffed "I don't want my kitten to go through what we had to"

"I know" Glimmer cooed "that's what being a parent is about, looking after them" she let go to meet her eyes "but they will grow and make their own mistakes and their own path and we can only hope we have raised them strong enough to thrive through all of it" she cupped her face "Wasn't that what you wanted to tell her this morning when you took her to the Fright Zone? That you would always stand by her? Whatever path she chooses?"

Catra's heart twisted in so many different ways at her words, realization washed over her. She leaned against the wall covering her face "I just want to hold my kitten right now, hug her until she falls asleep and promise her I'll be always in her corner"

"I know, and you will" Glimmer said solemnly "But right now someone else needs you and she's only going to listen to you"

Catra uncovered her face taking a deep breath "You'll tell us if they come back, right?"

"When they come back, yes" Glimmer nodded.

Catra smiled weakly nodding "Thanks, Spark-" she cut herself off thinking if the nickname would be in bad taste given the recent admission regarding the wings.

"Please, don't stop calling me that now, after so many years I was actually starting to like it" Glimmer smirked.

Catra chuckled weakly "As long as Princess Kitty doesn't stick"

"Deal, with so many things changing, is good to keep some the same," she said heartedly, her words carried more than they showed.

Catra leaned in for a hug, mindful not to touch the wings, which now explained her back pain "Love you, Glimmer"

"Love you too" she rested over her shoulder "go, I'll stay by the front gate"

She nodded turning around and went to her room, her hands sweaty. She opened as quietly as possible finding Adora sited by the edge of the bed, facing away from her.

"Adora" she knelt before her, noticing she hadn't set down the sword "let go," she asked gently trying to reach the blade, but she held tighter.

"I can't, as soon as I do, she'll be She-Ra"

Catra exhaled looking at the cold metal, seeing her wife's reflection in it "I think no matter what we do, she's already the new She-Ra" she mumbled "that look you had…when you saw her…that was the same look I wore when I saw you transform for the first time" she tried to meet her eyes "So we can both imagine what's going through her head right now"

Adora shut her eyes tightly recalling the bitter memory, feeling remorse at the soul idea of making her daughter feel the same way she had when Catra had backed away "This shouldn't have

happened" she mumbled "Marazz shouldn't have to carry this responsibility...I've failed her"

"No, you haven't" Catra's tone was firm and decided "But if we don't step it up and help her we will have failed"

"There must be a way in which we can stop this" Adora insisted.

"She is a First One, the only descendant of your kind, this shouldn't be a complete surprise she was chosen" Catra's ears tilted down "We just assumed there wouldn't be a need for a next one, that was always our goal. To give Angella, Saber and Marazz the childhood we couldn't have…and I think we accomplished that" Catra tried to offer a smile "We got to give them parties, sleepovers, travels…we got to be there for them, give them hugs, having talks, watching them grow…"

"She's still just a kid" Adora's lip quivered.

"I know. And she's our kid. She has your headstrong bravery and selfless heart, she has my resilience and resourcefulness… and more importantly, she has all our love" Catra reached her cheek stroking gently "she's every bit of the fearless warrior you are. Even if unknowingly we have been preparing her for this, in one way or another,"

"How can you say that?"Adora accused and those words were enough to turn Catra's calmness into pure fire.

"Do you think I want this any more than you do?!" she planted herself right in front of her, making sure their eyes would see each other's soul "I thought I had lost you to She-Ra for three years. And every day and every night I wished you had never found that sword, but no matter how much I wanted things to change or go back to normal nothing I did could take back what had happened, and we all know how desperately I tried" she felt the ache of remembering the portal "And nothing I did, could ease that agony that kept on eating my insides. It wasn't until I accepted that you needed to discover who you were that the pain finally subsided"

she admitted "And right now it's Marazz's turn to do the same. And I can't stand to fight against that feeling for a second time" her tone became vulnerable "She's always had us by her side and we are not stopping now, Adora. We have to make sure she knows that. If we've learned anything is that you can't be She-Ra and stand on your own"

Adora sniffed running her words through her heart, she knew truth and experience rang through Catra's admission. There was no turning back, but much of the future was still to be decided. She gazed up at Catra reading in her eyes that they shared the same fears and uncertainties, but as long as they were together, they would always be stronger, and they would need each other for what was yet to come.

...Adora stretched the sword to Catra finally letting go ... She wasn't She-Ra any more.

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"Careful with you head" Madame Razz called entering her home.

"Careful with wha-?" Saber walked in hitting his forehead against the small door frame, groaning.

"One would think that after coming here so often you would have stopped hurting yourself on your way in" she scoffed moving around in her usual hectic way.

"Madame Razz" Angella called the old lady trying to get her attention "how did you know we would be at the woods?"

"Oh dearie, I told you before I wouldn't forget that today you'd come back from your mission, it's not every day you get to visit"

"Mission?" Saber repeated "what mission?

"I can't keep count of all your travels, my boy" she hurriedly shoved some herbs into the boiling pot.

The twins were about to run out of sources with her incoherent talk when the youngest one reached out for her advice.

"Grandma" Marazz called, standing in front of her to gain her full concentration "something happened today… I...I turned into She-Ra" she said and Razz's eyes went round and blank before she smacked her broom right in-between her ears making her hiss.

Angella rapidly pulled her away from Razz and into a half embrace as the teen rubbed her head.

"I've told you before to braid your hair to keep it out of your face, why do you think your mothers wore a headpiece?"

"What does my hair have to do with anything?" she complained still feeling the sting "I just told you I turned into She-Ra"

"And if you had kept your hair braided you wouldn't have half the forest tangled in it" she served her a cup "you need to stay alert even when you aren't She-Ra anymore"

"Wait, so do you believe us?" Saber asked "That Marazz is She-Ra"

"What's there to believe when I have seen it with my own eyes?"

They all stood speechless as she drank her tea untroubled.

"You saw me in the woods? Can you help me? I-I don't know what to do" she felt her voice tremble.

Madame Razz's face turned softer at the sight of Marazz so troubled "It's so unlike you to doubt yourself, dearie" she gently lifted her chin "Have you tried to talk to your moms?"

"I'm…I'm scared to do it" she admitted, tears already dripping again.

"They'll listen to you, dearie, whatever the problem is"

"I'm the problem" she buried her face in hands "I can't be She-Ra"

"You already are," Madame Razz said "you can't be in the shadows when you are meant to glow" she grabbed her hands "you are not taking it away from her," she said "you are lifting it from her shoulders"

"I'll never be as good as her" Marazz pressed her fists tightly.

"You won't" Madame Razz agreed "but you can be extraordinary as yourself," she said genuinely "you don't have to follow her steps to find yourself, but you can learn from her journey to make your own path"

Marazz was struck by her words, as she smiled at her and wrapped her arms around her "Thank you, Grandma" she sniffed against her shoulder.

Razz was aback, before returning the embrace "Of course, dearie" she patted her back soothingly.

The twins smiled comforted by the sight, Marazz would be alright and they would be right at her side to make sure of it.

"Now" Madame Razz let go turning around and shuffling through her stuff to pull out a metallic golden ring "here, Mara used to wear them, it will help keep your hair out of the way"

Marazz took it, gazing at the hairpiece. It felt so fitting that one of the people she was named after was gifting her something so special from the other person she honored with her name as well "Thank you" she said holding it against her chest "I'll wear it every day"

Angella softly placed a hand on her shoulder "Do you want me to braid it?"

Marazz nodded sweetly at her "Yes, please" she handed her the metallic ring as smooth fingers untangled her long messy mane "I think it's time I find who I am"

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Adora jolted back at the sight of Glimmer's wings, barely registering the explanation she was giving.

"That's why-"

"You have her wings" Adora interrupted feeling her eyes overflow "just like hers" she hugged her tightly, smiling against her shoulder "that's wonderful, Glimmer"

The Queen was cut short, but she knew nothing else really needed to be explained as she hugged her back, the last person to have seen her mother "Thank you, Adora" she said heartedly wrapping her wings around them as Angela would.

Bow sighed softly turning to Catra who was also smiling at them "How are you feeling?"

"Have been better" she shrugged "I just want to know where they are"

"Hey" he squeezed her shoulder lightly "I know it couldn't have been easy to let them go like that and not follow after, so thank you for trusting me"

Catra offered a timid smile "I'm still half minded to run into the woods, Bow"

"But you aren't"

"Guess I do trust you, then" she leaned into his shoulder exhaling tiredly "And I trust your kids, as you said, you and Glimmer raised them. There's very few people I'd be confident to leave Marazz with, and they are on the top four"

Bow wrapped an arm over her shoulders enveloping her in a half hug.

"Everything is going to be alright" he promised.

"I…I know" she smiled to herself. She didn't know where that sudden assurance had come from, but she believed it.

And just as Adora and Glimmer released the other from the embrace, an unusual flash of light began to form and sparkles exploded in every direction as the three runaways finally reached home.

Angella stumbled being barely caught by Saber before she could fall to her knees.

"See?" she panted, "told you I could do it in one jump"

"Kids!"

They all gazed up as their parents rushed to them, hugging them tightly.

"Where have you been?!" Glimmer scolded before taking notice of the scratches on their faces and arms "Are you alright? What happened?"

"That's my bad, I teleported into the air, we just fell down" she explained apologetically just then realizing the big change as well "Mom, you have wings?!"

"Since when?!" Saber asked in an accusatory tone "why didn't you tell us?"

Both parents were sure caught off guard "We'll talk about that later" Bow said nervously "But right now-" he began.

"You are so grounded," Glimmer said "Running off like that?! We were so worried!"

"You should have teleported home or somewhere near" Bow added, "That being said-"

The twins just braced themselves for whatever might come next.

"We are really proud of you" Glimmer said in a sweet tone "you both chose to protect your cousin even though that meant disobeying us. You looked out for her and for that we know your heart was in the right place" the siblings were speechless at the remark.

"We love you guys" Bow initiated the hug as they all held each other.

"Marazz!" Catra raced to her, leaning down and grabbing her face inspecting her hastily "Are you hurt? Are you bleeding?"

"I'm-I'm okay, mom," she said with little voice, not daring to move a muscle.

"You had me so worried, little one" she embraced her strongly, unable to hold a few tears "don't you ever leave like that again" she begged, those words seemed like an awful reminder of her past "whatever you need, you'll always have us, Kitten" she kissed her cheek releasing her from her bone-crushing hold just as hesitant steps approached them.

Marazz's body began to shake as Adora stood before her "Marazz, I-"

"I'm sorry mom," she said, her voice cracking "I didn't mean for it to happen, I was just-I was just playing" she bit her lower lip to keep it from trembling "I'll-I'll do everything I can to uphold your

legacy. I'll train harder, I'll study further, I'll prove myself to you, I promise, I'll make you prou-"

She didn't finish the sentence as strong arms were already holding her with might.

"I've always been proud of you, Marazz" she said heartedly, holding her child "since the moment I knew I was pregnant there hasn't been a day in which I don't feel proud of calling you my daughter" she caressed her nape "You are such a wonderful girl and I still marvel every day as I see how exceptional you are" she let go finding Marazz's mismatched eyes filled with tears "I'm sorry if I don't say it often enough and if I've pushed you too hard, I know that you are capable of so much and I've always been so confident in your resolve that I fell blinded to realize I was pushing you to be like me, when you are already so marvelous as yourself" she caressed the side of her face affectionately "You are going to be a wonderful, She-Ra" she said "There's no one as worthy as you for the title, my kitten" she briefly turned around picking the sword from the ground and presenting it to her "Whatever you choose to do with your spark, I'm sure you'll be amazing at it and your mom and I will be right here for you, in every step of the way for as long as you need us to"

Marazz's breathing stopped as she gazed at the sword before her. She inhaled sharply finding her resolve as her fingers secured a tight hold around the handle and she found herself saying, not for the last time...

"For the honor of Grayskull!"

****

Glimmer felt the soft morning drew caressing her wings as the wind crept through the window. She folded the last piece of

clothing, hugging it tightly against her chest, breathing in the moment.

The door had been open, so it didn't come as a surprise that a pair of heterochromatic eyes had gazed upon her from the other side. Soon a pair of arms wrapped around her waist from behind, mindful not to bend her wings and a chin rested over her right shoulder.

"Hey, Sparkles"

The Queen did her best to disguise her sniffing as she breathed in "Hey Horde Scum"

Catra chuckled lightly, her tail swaying softly as they stood in silence for a moment, taking it all in.

"I still can't quite picture it" Glimmer spoke first "how it's going to be from now on"

Catra's hold became a tad tighter "Me neither" she admitted burring her face on her back exhaling softly, tickling the Queen's skin.

Glimmer held into the arms that surrounded her and sighed looking up at the roof "Did you ever pictured it?" she asked out loud "All those years ago when we were just kids, how it would all come to be?"

Catra huffed releasing her hold "Which part? That'd I end up joining the rebellion and marrying Adora? Being crowned a princess of Bright Moon? That we'd be friends?" she smiled endearingly "Not in a million years, Sparkles"

The Queen smiled "It feels like it was all yesterday" she mused as if trying to remember a dream.

"Did...did I ever thank you?" Catra asked hesitantly "for...for being my friend?"

"That's nothing you have to thank me for, Catra" Glimmer gazed at her softly.

"For me it is" she averted her eyes "You hated my guts with burning passion and you had every reason and right to, but at Prime's..."

Glimmer could picture what was running through her head, a past and upbringing of their origins no one else had taken part of. Those events would be the ones to eventually shape them to be so close "Who would have thought that for us to see eye to eye it would take a closed door?" she grinned endearingly making Catra melt away. She would be forever thankful of having her by her side, more so than the Queen would ever know.

"Yeah," Catra's voice got lost in the room as the empty walls echoed back, reminding her how change was still to come "...and now..."

Glimmer understood, there was no need for words as she took her hand "Come on, the sun is about to rise"

Catra felt the knot in her throat as they walked down the hall, passing through all the murals, taking a moment to look at the one of Queen Angela and the newest one of King Micah keeping her company forever once more.

"At least we were able to steal a little bit of time" Glimmer mumbled "before today arrived"

Catra's breath hitched "It never feels like enough time, does it?"

"It never does" Glimmer agreed as they reached the main gates, where Darla was being loaded.

And there, standing next to Bow and Adora were their kids, standing at 15 and 21 years old and ready to embark far beyond their stars.

"Remember, if you need any help or even just some advice, call us," Bow said.

"We will dad" Saber assured, smiling under his growing beard.

"And if you need assistance, call the galactic alliance, they will send backup from whichever planet is the closest, you have a good network to help you" Adora stressed.

"I'll make sure to establish communication with them as soon as we are in deep space" Marazz nodded, her long braid copying her movements at knee's length.

"And don't forget to send us a sign at least once a day" Glimmer added with a smirk approaching them.

"Mom" Angella complained mockingly.

"Okay, okay, once a week?"

"That we can promise"

"Look out for each other while you are out there, okay?" Catra asked.

"We promise"

"Good" they all stood in silence as the dawning realization of the departure settled in, it was time to bear farewell.

Bow held his kids in a tight embrace "We'll miss you so much" his voice cracked a little "But we know you'll do wonderful things" he said with conviction releasing them looking at Saber "son, you are every bit of a leader as you are a warrior, keep your aim true and you won't ever miss a target, and that aim is to keep them safe"

He nodded, his eyes reddening a little.

"Angie, never forget that your compassion is your greatest strength, not a weakness, your instinct has never lead you astray,

don't doubt your talent"

"Thank you, dad" she sniffed keeping her head tall.

Glimmer hugged Saber making him lean in at her height "You've never feared taking on new challenges and you always accomplish whatever goal you set your mind into, your determination is what will bring you all back home to us"

"I will mom" he hugged her tighter kissing her cheek.

Glimmer smiled encouragingly before turning to her daughter, there was so much she wanted to say and yet so little time, so she just found the words she wanted her to reassure her the most "My mom's name…it was only with on 'L', you hold two because you are the second to carry it, but I never wanted you to feel as though you had to fulfill what she couldn't or outrun her shadow. I want you to find your own way and let me be by your side to cheer you on in your journey"

Angella's chest felt lighter as something lifted from her, perhaps the fear of not being good enough for the name she was given "I love you mom" she cuddled in her arms one last time, cherishing the feeling she would have to replay in her memory for the months to come.

"Well kitten…this is it" Catra gazed down slowly working her way up to look at how much her daughter had grown, how she carried her posture with more presence and resolve, more confidently than ever before, she was ready to take on the world, and now, the universe.

"I'll write every day," she said standing tall "I'll find the time"

"I know" she grabbed her shoulders gently looking into her eyes, remembering the first time she had seen them, how they had looked at her with such love and so much later they still gazed at her with the same devotion "I just wished I didn't have to share you with the rest of the galaxy" she hugged her "you are one of the greatest decisions I've even made in my life, I'm grateful for

every single moment I got to see you grow and have you by my side" she purred softly "And I can't wait to see the woman you'll become" she let go looking at her with adoration "Go and find your way"

"I will" she nodded keeping the tears at bay with little success "and I'll come back and tell you all about it" she promised before turning to Adora who smiled at her swelling with pride.

Marazz took a deep breath keeping it together "I'm ready" she said with resolve "To see what's beyond, to help people, I'll do my best, mom"

"I know you will" she hugged her tight "You don't have to prove anything to me or anyone else, do it for yourself, kitten" she cuddled her as she would when she was a baby, kissing her head over and over "I'm so proud of being your mom, Marazz"

"Just remember, She-Ra is nothing without you, not the other way around, okay?" Catra added standing by her wife.

"Listen to her, that's one piece of advice that defined my life" she intertwined her fingers with Catra's "You are special because of who you are, not of what that sword can give you"

Marazz nodded hugging them tight one last time before having to board the ship "I'll see you in a year"

"We'll be right here waiting" they held back firmly and just like that, she slipped away. Suddenly, all the years they had raised her, all the laughs, tears, struggles and victories played back before their eyes as if they were mere seconds, all leading to this moment.

They hugged goodbye their niece and nephew saying loving words to them as Marazz bared farewell to her aunt and uncle. And the next thing they saw was the ship taking off into the horizon, flying towards the sun that shined over them as the new day announced its arrival.

The original four stood there by the gate waving goodbye, seeing them go answer their call.

"This is it, isn't it?" Adora breathed out holding into Catra as Bow squeezed her shoulder supportively. After all those years, her mission was over.

"For us, it is" he said.

"But for them?" Catra chuckled shaking softly.

Glimmer closed her eyes taking in the moment "That's only their beginning"

Chapter End Notes

> And thus, this story comes to an end. Thank you so much for all the support, the follows, favs, kudos, bookmarks, all of it! Thank you for the love and dedication, for writing such amazing comments, for interacting with me and taking part in the story. No other work I've posted has ever had such a warm and outstanding reception. I've said it before and I'll say it again, this is the nicest fandom I've come across and it's thanks to every single one of you, hands down.
>
> Writing this was such a journey, I can see my own shift in the storytelling throughout the chapters because as I commented before, I was aiming for a three-part story, but reading the comments with suggestions and speculations, it kept me reeling and this is the conclusion of that journey.
>
> I hope you enjoyed reading it as much as I did writing it. And I sincerely hope this was a satisfactory resolution of every emotional rollercoaster I've put you through! Thanks for sticking through thick and thin and I hope this isn't a farewell, but an "until next time"
>
> Sincerely, your author thus far, Zetara.

End Notes

Until next time!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!